

A close-up photograph of a woman with long, wavy blonde hair. She is wearing a white, button-down shirt that is open at the collar and has one sleeve rolled up. She is lying down, with her head tilted back and her hand near her face. The background is a soft, out-of-focus white fabric.

The Blonde in 3C

Kenny
Wright

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FOREWORD

It's been 15 months since I last published anything, and two and a half *years* since I published something that wasn't a collaboration. Seems like I retired from the game, but I never thought of it that way. For me, capturing hotwife fantasies in books and stories is not a job, it's a true passion. The fantasy is real, and anyone who's got it knows that it's not something you can just turn off. There's no "retiring" from this.

The Blonde in 3C, which actually started off with the working title, "The Things We Do For Love" (changed because of a terrific book by Sean Geist with a very similar name), actually was conceived sometime early in the 2021. Believe it or not, it was largely inspired by contemporary fiction author Emily St. John Mandel (author of *Station Eleven* and most recently *Sea of Tranquility*). I wondered what it would look like to write a hotwife book written in a non-linear, disparate, and multi-character way. This got me thinking about where these fantasies come from. What are some common origins for hotwifing, both for the husband and the wife? Thus, the book you're holding was born.

This book wouldn't be possible without the help and support of so many people out there. Ben Boswell, of course, helped me get this thing across the finish line. Once I did finish it, Max Sebastian helped me shave off some of the rough edges and confusing scenes that inevitably crept in when trying to write something non-linear. Kirsten McCurran, my old friend, helped me brush off the rust that comes with the actual business of publishing. All three are wonderful authors. If you haven't read a book by them (hard to believe that anyone reading this hasn't), definitely check them out. I also want to thank Duke Lattimore for reading the book and making sure the final product all felt cohesive. Thanks to my wife for supporting me in this mad hobby of mine and giving me the space to write. And thanks to you for picking up a copy of my latest.

Also, if you're not aware, in the last couple years since I've been quietly writing away, a fantastic new group has popped on Medium called #ACHE (Authors of Cuckold and Hotwife Erotica). It's a wonderful scene. Go check that out if you're looking for even more to satisfy your naughty, fiction-reading minds.

I cannot promise that I'll be publishing all the time (I always get into trouble when I promise stuff like that), but I do have one new book fully written (although quite rough) and another that's about three-quarters complete.

If you liked this book, leave a review wherever you bought it, find me on social media, tell a friend, and thanks again so much!

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PROLOGUE

“**Y**ou know what I could use a whole lot less of?” The blonde hefted her laundry from the washing machine to the industrial strength dryer. She didn’t give Cooper a chance to answer. She wasn’t expecting one. “Love,” she said, and slammed the dryer door shut. “The stupid shit we do for love.”

Cooper recognized her, of course. She was in 3C, the unit just above his, yet these were the most words she’d ever spoken to him at one time.

Beautiful, with dark eyes and honey-blond hair, she was the kind of girl that you recognize. She wore pink cheerleader shorts that showcased her long, athletic legs, and a loose, Yale sweatshirt because it was always over-air-conditioned in the laundry room.

Normally, women like her intimidated the hell out of Cooper. He would never, for example, approach a girl like her at a bar or a party, and if he saw her at a party, he probably would have steered clear. In that moment, though, in the basement of their condo building, he found some words.

“I once adopted a cat for an ex,” he said. “And I’m allergic to them.”

She looked at him, looking confused, as if she wasn't expecting this to be a two-way conversation. Her confusion resolved a moment later as something else: "Wait, don't you have a cat now?"

Cooper's heart pulsed. She knew he had a cat? He just grinned. "She didn't want to keep Mr. Fluffy when we broke up."

"Love," she said with a nod. "It's total shit."

"I take it you just broke up with someone?"

The *someone*, he knew, was like Ken to her Barbie, only this Ken was named Brett, he wore his dark hair in a top knot like a Caucasian samurai, and had a big cock. Cooper knew this because he lived just below her, and the floors did a poor job of insulating sound.

"*Fuck me, Brett! Oh, fuck me with that big fucking cock!*" was a common cry he heard on Friday and Saturday nights as he lay beneath them, listening to the mattress squeak and jerking off.

"I should," she said, bringing him back into the laundry room. "He can be a real asshole."

"So why don't you?" Cooper asked, and in his head, he answered for her, "*Because he's got a big cock.*"

Instead, she shrugged. "Because I love him." She heard the resignation in her voice. "Guess I'm adopting my own Mr. Fluffy."

PART I

THE WEDDING

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Annika wasn't quite sure how she'd ended up here, at her ex-boyfriend's wedding years after they'd broken up. When she got the invitation, she'd tossed it into the recycling pile. Now here she was, watching the man she once loved spin his new bride on an oceanfront veranda in Monterey, thinking how she'd once dreamed of sharing this moment with him.

He still looked good. The topknot was gone and his hair had receded, but he wore it well. You don't lose shoulders that broad, either—shoulders that seemed designed for the tuxedo he now wore.

Annika rubbed her thumb along her own wedding band, then turned to look for her husband. Where had he disappeared to?

"Here, you look like you need this." It was a man that she didn't recognize, holding two glasses of white wine and looking at her with kind eyes.

“I’ve got...” Annika began to lift her glass, only to find it empty. “... one.”

He held his second glass out to her. “Yeah, you do.”

She was used to this kind of attention from other men, but it had been a while since she was in a situation to receive it. Her husband had a jealous streak that he wouldn’t admit, but that Annika had to tiptoe around nevertheless.

But now he’d gone and disappeared, and she was in need of a new drink. This was harmless. “Thanks.”

“I’m Ryan.”

“Nice to meet you, Ryan. Annika.”

“Swedish, right?” he said.

“My grandmother’s name. I was born and raised in Wisconsin.” She’d said those words countless times with countless men trying to make small talk. She glanced at Brett and his new wife, Margot. Margot had changed into a short, white dress, her veil holding back her long, blond hair. Annika asked, “So which one do you know?”

She was surprised to see a hint of color spring to his cheeks. He glanced at them, then away, but not towards Annika. “I’m a...friend of Margot’s.”

She heard the hesitation. Now *this* was more interesting. “You two dated.”

Ryan’s eyes snapped back to hers. “In another life.”

Annika leaned in. “I actually dated Brett... in another life.”

“No kidding,” he said. Annika saw the transformation in his eyes. She went from a pretty girl with wavy, blond hair and nice tits to someone with a story. He glanced around the crowd. “Wonder what’s up with that? Do you think there are other exes out there?”

Annika looked, too, wondering the same thing. “I don’t see anyone that I recognize, but that doesn’t mean much. We broke up when he moved away.”

“So it was mutual?” Ryan asked.

Annika’s turn to look away and feel cagey. “Not exactly.”

“Margot broke up with me to start a poly relationship with the couple we were swinging with at the time,” Ryan said. “Your story couldn’t be weirder.”

“Surprisingly similar, actually,” she said as heat ran up her neck.

“But you don’t want to share the details?”

She was already blushing at all the confusing memories. “Not really.”

“Fair,” Ryan said. “But tell me at least one of those details involved you and another girl.”

She gave him a flat stare. “Really?”

“Number one guy’s fantasy, right?”

“Not Brett’s,” Annika muttered.

Ryan, like many men thinking with their dicks, was persistent. “So that’s a ‘no’?”

She sipped at her wine. “Nope. Not a ‘no’.”

“If I buy you another drink, would you share?”

She giggled, the effects of the wine. “These drinks are free.”

“I’ll tip *really* well.” His smile was so infectious. “Look, we’re at a wedding of our exes, both of whom seem to have pretty kinky pasts. We’re like kindred spirits. That’s got to be fate or something.”

“I’m not going to sleep with you,” she said. She held up her wedding band.

“I saw it.”

“But you can ‘buy’ me another drink. This one’s empty.”

“Be right back.”

Annika watched him go. He was handsome. Older than her usual tastes, but the gray at his temples was nice, and he wore his suit well. Maybe in another life, she would have been tempted.

Her attention strayed back to Brett, who was whispering something to Margot. Jealousy flared before she could tamp it down. She didn’t really want to be with Brett. She was happy with the way her life had turned out. She loved her husband, Cooper.

Why was she here again? Why did she come here, knowing all the confusing emotions it would stir up from her past?

“So how do you know Brett and Margot?” the guy asked.

The restaurant overlooking the Pacific Ocean as the sun set was gorgeous. The night couldn’t have been more pleasant, mid-70s with a light breeze. It was a storybook location for a storybook wedding between two storybook individuals. But Cooper was not in a comfortable place.

“Oh, my wife knows them,” Cooper said vaguely. He forced himself to smile and relax. The beer helped. “I’m her plus one.” Sip. “You?”

“Old buddy of Brett’s,” he said. The guy had shared his name with Cooper, but Cooper had forgotten it immediately. Maybe something that started with an L? Larry? “Still can’t believe that asshole is actually settling down.”

“Yeah?” Cooper was only half involved in this conversation. Most of his attention was on the crowd, looking for his wife. When he couldn’t immediately find her, his apprehension rose.

“My buddy, Kai here, knows what I’m talking about. Kai, hey Kai!”

Kai. Cooper’s whole body went cold at the name. There was only one Kai that he’d ever met, and whenever he had, disaster seemed to follow. Looking up, sure enough, this was the same Kai—stocky, muscular, going a little bald now, all these years later, but still ruggedly handsome.

He didn’t seem too thrilled to be roped into their conversation, like he didn’t really love the L guy. “Hey, Lucas.” Even the way he spoke was like a man looking for an escape hatch. “I actually have no idea what you’re talking about.”

He glanced at Cooper, who flinched, but there was no recognition. The man didn’t remember him, which was a feeling that Cooper was used to. He was never the guy that people remembered. That belonged to his wife.

Speaking of, the crowd parted and all of a sudden there she was, standing on the opposite side of the veranda, chatting with a guy a few years older than them. His stomach squirmed as he watched her laugh at something he said.

“We were just talking about how much of a pussy hound Brett was back in the day,” Lucas explained to Kai in what felt like another world.

Annika looked really good—the kind of really good that Cooper had begun to take for granted after seven years together. She wore a dress that didn’t fit with the image that he’d developed of her over those years. He was used to Annika wearing yoga pants and loose tops, t-shirts, practical things. Her dress was somehow both sophisticated and sexy, made of a metallic navy that hugged her curves, with a neckline that was complex and sensual without giving much away.

She wore sunglasses against the setting sun, and as the breeze caught in her golden hair, she looked like a movie star.

“...I mean, have you seen Margot?” Kai was saying. “She’s a fucking eleven.”

“But all his girlfriends are elevens,” Lucas said. “The man doesn’t date anyone but a fucking eleven.”

Cooper watched his wife banter with the stranger. Jealousy tightened around his chest and made his gut squirm. His scalp tingled, as if each individual follicle burned.

Lucas apparently followed Cooper’s gaze. “Speaking of, isn’t that the chick he was with back when he was down in San Diego?”

And suddenly they were all looking at Annika, and that white hot ball of fire in Cooper's gut burned brighter.

"Anni," Kai said. There was a wistful quality as he said her shortened name. Cooper looked at him, but he seemed lost in a memory.

Cooper waited for Kai to finally connect him with Annika, for the recognition to return. *Hey, weren't you the guy who lived in Annika's building back in the day?* But it didn't, and when it didn't, he started to spell it out for them—*That's my wife*. Not making that fact known now would probably lead to some embarrassing reveals later on. *That is my wife and she's why we're here*.

But Cooper couldn't get the words out, and Lucas quickly moved them past the point of no return anyway. He sipped his beer, squinted at her, and said, "Yeah. Anni. Swedish, but not. You fucked her, didn't you?"

It was like Lucas's words formed a fist that he drove right into Cooper's stomach. He... fucked her? The blow was so visceral that at first, Cooper didn't catch Kai's response.

"...really good head. Eye contact, both hands, the works." Kai seemed to be loosening up.

"You can always tell when a chick loves sucking dick," Lucas said.

"Yeah. She had a sub streak, for sure. Not like Margot," Kai added.

Lucas agreed. "Definitely not like Margot. So you think it'll last?"

The two men moved on from the subject of Annika. To them, she was the footnote. To Cooper, she was always his center. It just took moments like this to remember.

The man she was talking to had left her, and she was leaning on the railing, watching the sun disappear beyond the horizon. It was a picturesque scene, one they didn't get often in Dallas. He should have been at her side, holding her as they shared this moment.

Instead, he'd let himself be drawn in by Lucas and the possibility of learning something about her past. Or maybe it was watching her flirt again, watching her smile the way she used to before life's stresses caught up with them.

It was time to end this. Time to go to her and reconnect. Only when he started to pick his way to her, Margot stepped in front of him in all her brilliant, bridal perfection.

"Cooper, right?" she said with her brilliant smile. Margot was the kind of beautiful that made a simple thing like remembering his name feel like a

compliment. She was also, apparently, a hugger. "I'm so glad you came."

"Um... of course. Congratulations."

"So you've been married for what? Five years?"

Again, the fact that she knew that about him felt better than it should have. "Five years in October."

"Any advice?"

With those big blue eyes of hers, he found himself reaching for advice that had been shared with every couple about to get married. "Communicate with each other. Be honest. Talk."

If only he was able to put that advice into practice.

"Then I think Brett and I will do just fine. Thanks, Hon."

He stood there, spellbound for a moment in her wake. When he snapped out of it, a group had moved between him and Annika, and when he found her again, the guy who'd been chatting her up was back.

This was the time to approach. To shut it all down. But Cooper wasn't the kind of guy who shut things down, even in a situation like this. He was a watcher. He was a passive traveler.

So instead, he turned and decided to get himself another drink.

Annika spotted Cooper on the opposite side of the veranda, watching her. And at his side were two guys, including... Kai Lawrence. It may have been over ten years since she'd last seen him, but she remembered Kai. She remembered looking up at him, her legs over his shoulders, all his weight, all his solid muscle, pressing her into the bed as he thrust his cock deep—

“I got you this.” Ryan had returned with another drink for her—something mixed this time and garnished with a lime wedge. “It’s not roofied or anything, promise.”

“I don’t think you’re supposed to lead with that.” She took it anyway and tossed half of it back before she even considered that it could be spiked. Glancing through the crowd, she tried to read her husband. Was that horror on his face? Had Kai said anything?

“Slow down there,” Ryan chuckled, “or you’re going to make me go back into that line again.”

Annika smiled in the direction of her husband before finding her cool again. With a breath, she turned back to Ryan. “I was thinking about this while you were gone,” she said. “Margot left you to be with a couple that you were swinging with.”

“I did say that.”

“So you’re a *swinger*.” She didn’t realize that she was trying to get him off balance until she made the statement, and yet he seemed totally unfazed.

“Hm... I think that’s more of a characteristic of someone in a relationship, and right now, I’m not.”

Annika studied him. “And if you were...?”

“I’m feeling a little judged here,” he said, although he wasn’t acting like he was being judged at all. “I guess it all depends on the woman. If I were dating you, then I’d be whatever you wanted me to be. So would *you* want me to be a swinger?”

“I’ve been married for just about five years,” she said. “I’m actually good with monogamy.”

“And yet you dated Brett in what, by your own admission, wasn’t exactly a monogamous relationship.”

“Pretty sure I didn’t say that.”

“So in your time with the groom over there, you only ever slept with him?”

It took all her focus not to look over at Kai Lawrence. Instead, she looked around to make sure no one was listening in and said, “Brett may have liked to share.”

“I see. And you? Did you like being shared?”

“That is all you get.” She must have looked as red as a tomato. “Why are you still here, anyway? Didn’t I say you weren’t going to sleep with me?”

For a second, she didn’t think that he’d let it go, and she wasn’t sure what she’d do if he pressed. She never talked about this stuff with her husband. It was... refreshing.

But he did move on. “Fine. If that’s the case—a decision which I respect even if I disagree with it, by the way—then at least you can help me evaluate my other options.”

Annika snorted. “You’re pretty sure of yourself.”

“Past experience backs it up.” He pointed at someone. “What about her?”

“Too skinny,” she said. “She probably doesn’t consume enough calories to do more than lay there.”

“Ouch.”

“You asked. I’m a judgmental bitch.”

“Okay then. How about her?” He pointed at a woman wearing a long, flowing dress and thick, curly hair.

“Oh, she’s probably fun in that love child way. You do run the risk of needing to pick pubes out of your teeth.”

“She does have that Child of the Sixties thing going on. How about you? Does your husband get a free floss?”

“Are you really asking me about my pubic hair?” She laughed and covered her mouth, but also was tipsy enough that she couldn’t stop herself. “I keep things nice and tidy.”

“Shame. I was hoping you were bare.” Ryan didn’t seem embarrassed by any of this, and that brazenness was rubbing off on Annika. “If I were your husband, I’d insist that you shave it all off.”

“But you aren’t my husband.” The thought of Cooper asking something like that was funny enough to make her smile. Hell, the thought of having a conversation that was anything like this one with her husband was funny. “Maybe you should go find him and convince him.”

“You’d do it for him?”

“I’m a people pleaser.”

“Hence the sharing thing,” he said. “You ever done something like that with your current man?”

“You get no more from me. In fact, I should go find him now. You’ve already kept me away from him long enough—Cooper!” And like that, he was there. Her husband. Her heart. Panic set in like touching a live wire, sizzling through her.

“Hey, Annika. Who’s your friend?”

“Um... Cooper, this is Ryan. Ryan, this is my husband, Cooper.”

“Pleased to meet you,” Ryan said. “Your wife’s been telling me all about you.”

Cooper looked from Ryan to her. She tried to read his expression, but her anxiety and the booze made it hard. Cooper smiled warmly, but was there a moment’s hesitation before he did? He said, “Oh, I’m sorry she was

boring you like that,” in his good-natured, self-effacing way. But was it all a put-on?

“Ryan knows Margot. They *dated*.”

Cooper followed, nodding. Like it all clicked into place. Like there really wasn’t any cause to be jealous—or feel guilty—because they were just commiserating about how awkward it was to be at your ex’s wedding. “Ah, interesting. Now I see what you two have in common.” Then, like Ryan before, he looked around and added, “Wonder how many other exes they invited.”

“We were wondering that, too!” She glommed on to this line of conversation because she *was* feeling guilty. She tucked a strand of blond hair behind her ear before she could stop herself, because that was the thing she did when she was feeling guilty and Cooper knew it.

He definitely saw her do the tuck motion, too, and when he did, he glanced back at Ryan. “So sweetie,” he said, glancing at her only after calling her ‘sweetie’. “I’m feeling beat. West Coast time’s catching up and all.”

“Okay, let me just go and say goodbye to a few people.”

“Oh no, I don’t want to take you away. Stick around. Enjoy yourself. You’ve got a key.”

He said it casually, but she knew him so well. That was a rehearsed line. He’d probably even practiced it before coming up to her. What was he up to? “I really don’t mind,” she said. “I’m pretty tired, too.”

She could feel Ryan’s eyes on them, watching this exchange and jumping to all kinds of conclusions.

“Ryan, will you make sure she stays out of trouble? I’ve heard some interesting stories about Brett and Margot over there, and I have no idea where this party is headed.”

“Absolutely,” Ryan said. “What stories?”

“Just...” Cooper’s laugh and smile was definitely forced. “You know... they like to have fun.” The bride and groom were still on the dance floor, now surrounded by the wedding party, having a good old time. “And the night’s young, right?”

Annika started to say, one more time, that she was leaving, too, when Cooper leaned in and kissed her. “Have fun,” he said. “But just... not too much fun.” And she swore he looked at Ryan. But maybe he hadn’t. “Love you.”

“I... love you, too.”

He was already on the way out.

She almost didn't want to look at Ryan. She didn't want to hear his theories on what was going on. “Nice guy,” he said.

“He really is.”

“You know what?” Ryan said.

She held her breath, ready to hear him voice some truth about her marriage that she wasn't ready to admit. “What?”

“I think we should dance.”

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Cooper wasn't anything close to tired. He'd never done drugs, but he got the feeling that this was how it could have felt. He stepped out onto the sidewalk, it was like his senses were on overload. He could hear the lap of the waves and the insects chirping. Even the crunch of the tires of a passing car felt hyper-real.

Back inside, that guy, Ryan, was hitting on Annika. He knew how this story went. He'd been by her side when it played out before, back when they were just friends. Some douche bag would come along, and as soon as he realized that Cooper was just a friend, he'd start working on her with the most idiotic lines. Annika was too nice a girl to tell the guy to fuck off. Eventually, they'd wear her down, and then Cooper was alone in his condo listening to Annika's bed creak above him.

And every time, he'd jerk off to that sound, the *creak, creak, creak*. Annika's cries. The man's inevitable orgasm. It was better than porn, yet far

more painful. He was, he had realized, falling in love with her, so close he could hold her if he just had the guts.

All these years later, at Brett and Margot's Monterey wedding, many of those same emotions and insecurities swirled. It was like coming home. Same butterflies. Same excitement that gathered at the base of his neck and buzzed in his balls. Same sense of total inevitability, and all the sticky anticipation that came with it.

Their hotel wasn't far. Brett and Margot had reserved a block of rooms at the boutique hotel two blocks away, also along the water. He entertained the fantasy of hiding somewhere in the lobby and waiting for their return, Annika's arm linked in Ryan's, but one look around the Cormorant's small lobby and he had to dismiss it. It would be too obvious that he was there, hiding, and there was nowhere to actually hide.

Frustrated, he went up to his room. This wasn't the way he imagined things would play out. It took him his ride up to his room to realize that he didn't know how he imagined things would play out. He had some vague notion of following them from the lobby to Ryan's room and listening through the door, but the real life logistics of that fell down pretty quickly.

Why do you even want this? he asked himself as he moved through the room. He grabbed a glass and poured himself a drink from the bathroom sink. "Because I'm drunk," he announced.

But that wasn't all of it, either. Things had been strained between the two of them for a while now. He'd started to worry that she was bored of him. They'd gone to her ten-year high school reunion last year. Seemed she was pretty popular back then, and while no one actually said it, he could read their curious expressions. *Why had Annika married this guy?*

Or maybe it was all in his head. That's what his shrink would have told him were she here.

In the mirror, he saw Annika's bikini hanging to dry on the shower rod. They'd gone swimming at Big Sur yesterday. He turned and reached for the suit. It was new, bought specifically for this trip—specifically for him, although he didn't know that. One of the triangular cups was white, the other blue—reminding him of the flags at a swim meet—and while it did not have big, loopy bows or a bottom that hugged the insides of her asscheeks, it was still really sexy.

He hung the suit back up again, even though it was now dry, and wandered back into the main room of their hotel, changing into a pair of

jersey PJ bottoms.

What was she doing now? How quickly had Ryan started working on her after he left? Were they already on their way back to the hotel? Or maybe they couldn't keep their hands off of each other long enough to make the walk...

Cooper brushed his teeth, trying to block those thoughts—or at least telling himself that he was trying to block those thoughts. Again, he was gripped by the same nervous thrill that he used to get when she was just 3C. When he heard her laugh in the stairwell and knew that in just a few minutes, he'd hear her moans.

He got himself another glass of water, drained it, and started for the bed before pausing. Turning, he grabbed some toilet paper, prepared to clean up the mess he was about to make. Even the thought was humiliating—jerking off while his wife was out having fun with a stranger—but that wasn't going to stop him.

He'd just stepped out of the bathroom when the lock on their door chirped. For one irrational moment, he waited for Annika and Ryan to spill into the room, their hands all over one another, sucking face and grabbing ass.

Instead, it was only Annika, alone with her clutch purse in her hand and a smile that fell as soon as she saw the ball of tissues in his hand and correctly guessed the intent. She recovered, though, a playful smile and a raised eyebrow. "Need help?"

Cooper's face flooded with heat. "Uhh... I have a..."

She helped him out. "Sniffle?" She advanced into the room, a sway in her step that was part confidence, part alcoholic buzz. "You need to blow your nose."

"Yes?"

"Or maybe you need me to..." She placed her hands on his chest, looked into his eyes, and began to lower herself to her knees. "...blow something else."

Cooper's breath caught. They'd always had a healthy sex life. Annika was inspiring that way. But she didn't do things like this. She'd never knelt before him, peeling his pants off, and wrapping her hand around his cock. When they were together, things were a lot more vanilla. This felt like a porn version of Annika. This was the Annika he imagined she was with other men—not Cooper.

She kissed along his shaft, dancing her tongue along the sensitive underside. “Or are you still tired?”

“I’m... good.” His voice was tight, squeezed out as he tried to keep it together.

“Verdict’s out on that one,” she said. “You did leave your inebriated wife alone with another man so you could go back to the hotel and masturbate.”

“Anni...” That was different, too. Not something she’d normally say. She only got this direct when she’d had too much wine.

She sucked the tip into her mouth, swirling the circumcised head in a way that made his eyes roll back and his knees wobble.

“I’m sorry, I shouldn’t have done that,” he said.

She pulled away from him with a slurp. “No, you shouldn’t have.” She continued to jerk him off, though, her hand almost as good as her mouth. “One more glass and I could have gotten into real trouble there.”

“Really?”

She may have been drunk and on her knees, but she was the one firmly in control. She felt the desperation in his question, the not-exactly-fear that quavered in his voice, borderline hysteria, borderline excitement.

But rather than ask about it, or confess his feelings, they both moved past it. She took him back into her mouth, this time bobbing with her eyes shut and her thoughts on... what? Was she thinking about blowing Ryan? Did she wish she was with him rather than Cooper?

“Oh my... oh God—” Before he could stop it, he was coming, filling his wife’s mouth with his spunk. When he opened his eyes, she was staring up at him, amusement curled in the corners of her mouth as she sat back and swallowed.

She looked like she had something to say, or ask, or talk about. When she finally did say, “Better than your hand, right?” he didn’t think that was what she really wanted to say.

He blushed again, reminded that he’d been busted. “God, I’m so...” He looked away, but he felt the tissues in his hand like a sack of bricks.

She rose. “You know I’ll always be here, right?” She took the wad. “You don’t need this. Ever.”

He nodded.

“Is there...” Her turn to be hesitant. “Is there something you’d like me to do for you? Some... fantasy you want to talk about?”

“No, no... not like... it’s not like that.” And yet it was, and he couldn’t even meet her eyes when he denied it.

She reached behind her back and unzipped her dress. “You sure?”

The dress slid to the floor. Beneath, she wore lingerie that he’d never seen before—a bra and panties and garter belt all in rich, black lace. The garters held up a pair of nude-colored silk stockings, also topped in a band of lace. “That’s new?”

“It is.” She turned, giving him a view from the back, where the thong plunged between her firm ass cheeks. “You like it?”

“Yes.”

“You like me dressing up for you?” She turned back to him.

“Of course,” he said.

“I could dress up... in other things for you...?” This was asked with the same shyness that he was feeling, like they were both embarrassed by this conversation despite being married for the last five years. “...if you’d like.”

He stepped close. “Yeah, that could be fun.”

Could be. They both heard it. He winced. She glanced up at him, processed it quickly, and filed it away. She pulled his t-shirt over his head as he kicked off his pants and boxers. “What do you want me to dress up as?”

“Um... I don’t know.”

She kissed his neck. “A slutty nurse?” Her fingers found his cock, starting to rise. “A sexy librarian?” She nipped his ear. “I once dressed up as a French maid. *Iz zat somezing you would like?*” she asked with a sultry, French accent.

But it wasn’t the accent that got to him. It was the “I once” part of that phrase—the idea of her wearing a short, frilly black dress and fishnet stockings, her blonde hair up, her tits spilling out, *for someone else* that had him hard all over again.

Cooper had her in his arms, kissing her, spinning her, guiding her to the bed. “*Oh, but monsieur, we should not be doing zis...*”

Cooper wasn’t Cooper. It was so easy to pretend that he wasn’t Annika’s husband. To pretend that he was some stranger in a hotel room, fooling around with the maid. Only he wasn’t roleplaying—not the way Annika thought that they were. Annika *was* Annika pretending to be a French maid with another man.

She gasped as he pulled her thong down and crawled between her legs. “*Oh, monsieur!*” she cried as he kissed her thighs. She was soaked, the

smooth skin of her shaved pussy glistening as he ran his tongue along her slit and into her landing strip. She shuddered as he teased her button, which was engorged and ready for him.

“Oh, yes.” The fake accent was gone. Annika was back, his Annika, twisting her body on the bed. “Mmmmm...”

She pulled her bra down over her tits, freeing her nipples, and started playing with them. Cooper reached up, cupping her left breast as he began eating her out in earnest. Her eyes were closed again, her mind cast elsewhere.

“Eat me. Oh, yes,” she sighed. “Eat... me!”

Maybe it was seeing Brett and the wedding and watching her flirt with Ryan, but Cooper was transported back to his apartment, back to 2C, listening to his then upstairs neighbor utter the same words through the thin floor. It spurred him on, the way a mount is spurred when struck. He felt the pain of it. He felt the urge for more.

She arched her back, thrusting her hips against his aching jaw, and clutched at his hair. “Yessss!”

It was a loud orgasm. It was an intense orgasm. It was the kind of orgasm that took some time to recover from. Cooper always gave her that time. Tonight, he couldn’t.

He rose up over his still-panting wife, dick in hand, and entered her. She hissed as he slid into her silky embrace, but welcomed him, arching until only her head and ass were on the bed.

“Oh Cooper... you feel so... hard!”

And now he was Cooper again, doing to Annika what he always fantasized about after listening to her with Brett. Reclamation, they called it, but back then she wasn’t his to reclaim, and now she didn’t need reclaiming.

In dark parts of his mind, the rest of the night played out. In the fantasy that he was about to jerk off to, she stayed out later with Ryan. They’d make out. They’d go back to his room where she would blow him and he would make her come with his mouth. He’d fuck her. He’d come inside of her—

“Oh, Annika!”

Annika wasn’t close. He wanted to wait. To give her time and pleasure. But he couldn’t hold back. It all came on like an onslaught.

“Give it to me,” he heard her whisper.

No more than a few minutes of pumping and he exploded.

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Cooper felt so good fucking her. This was the sex she needed right now—hard, sweaty, passionate. She loved this man and loved making love to him, but right now, she didn't want to make love, she didn't want five-years-of-marriage sex. She wanted to get fucked.

“Oh, Annika!”

She clutched his back, just beneath the shoulders, drawing him down to her. She wanted to feel his skin against hers. She wanted to be as close as she could as he came. She felt his chest catch, his whole body shudder as he pushed one last time into her.

“Give it to me,” she whispered, her voice tight with need.

It was enough. His climax filled her with heat and happiness and satiation. She didn't come, but she'd already gotten that. She didn't need it right now. Her husband's gasps and groans were enough. Her husband, sweaty and pink in her arms, was everything.

“I’m sorry, I’m sorry. I couldn’t hold back,” he apologized. Seemed like Cooper was always apologizing these days. Or maybe she was just noticing it more.

“Don’t be sorry. Still felt really good.” She pecked his lips. “And you made me come before.”

Cooper rolled off of her. She missed his weight and warmth. “I like the new lingerie,” he said.

“I’m still wearing most of it,” she giggled, realizing that they’d been so desperate that she still had her bra and garter belt on. “I like it, too,” she said. And she really liked the effect it had on Cooper. “I’ve got something even sexier for tomorrow.”

“Really?” He was so earnest, eyes wide at such a small thing. Where the other men in her life demanded, Cooper never did. That was part of the problem: she didn’t know what he wanted.

She wanted to ask. She wanted to talk about this stuff. Sometimes, she’d even have conversations with herself, alone, to practice. “*What do you fantasize about, honey? Tell me what you want and I’ll do it.*” But she always chickened out.

Like now, in the afterglow of wonderful sex, she wanted to know what he had been thinking about as he came back to the room to masturbate. What kind of porn did he watch? What kinds of women got him excited? What was he seeking that she wasn’t giving him?

“Did you have fun tonight?” he asked, moving them on.

Or maybe... maybe not. “It was awkward at first, to be honest,” she began. “I’m still not sure why we came.”

“We needed a vacation,” Cooper said quietly.

Right. Only... who’s idea was it to come to the West Coast, to Monterey and the Pacific Ocean and their pasts? If it was Cooper’s, that was... interesting.

“The drinks helped,” she continued, probing closer to what she wanted to get at. She could still feel those drinks like a low hum buzzing along her skin. It had been a while since she’d had that much alcohol. Those drinks helped her probe more. “Hope you didn’t get too jealous when you saw me talking with Ryan.”

She watched his reaction carefully, and saw it. The quick intake of breath. The way he averted his eyes, just for a moment, ready to deflect and deny a truth he didn’t want to admit.

“I’m sorry I get jealous,” he said. Another apology. “I shouldn’t.”

Maybe you should, she briefly considered saying just to get a reaction. “You couldn’t have been that jealous,” she said. “I mean, you did leave me there with him.”

There it was again. The shift. The stir. The discomfort and arousal all mixed together. Here’s where she should have just asked: *Does the idea of me being with another man excite you?* She’d heard it before, although before, she didn’t have to pry the information out.

“You didn’t want to stay longer?” he asked without meeting her eyes.

“Well, actually, the party started closing down just after you left. Brett and Margot invited a few of us to the rooftop pool.”

“They invited you?” He asked it so casually. Too casually.

“Pretty sure they were actually inviting Ryan.” She placed a hand on his chest, to feel his heart. “I guess I was his plus one.”

There it was. His pulse quickened. His breath definitely caught. This turned him on. “And...” He could barely speak. “...you didn’t want to go?”

She smiled. “I had to get my swimsuit.”

It wasn’t exactly a lie. She would have had to get her swimsuit to join them, of course, but she also hadn’t intended to go. Knowing Brett, that would have only led to trouble, and she’d already led Ryan on long enough.

“So you’re going?” he asked, and she swore she heard hope in his voice, mixed with anxiety.

“You think I should?”

He did, she knew. He wanted her to go. He wanted her to be bad. “You should if you want to.”

She rolled over to the edge of the bed, facing away from him. She could see his reflection in the window, watching her carefully. She reached behind her back, unsnapping the bra.

“Did... did that guy go? Ryan?”

She brushed her fingers over her erect nipples on her way down to her garter belt. She was on fire.

“I’m not sure,” she said. Hooking her thumbs into her garter belt, she pushed it down over her hips like a pair of pants, taking the still-attached stockings with it. “Probably.”

In the window, she saw a ghostly reflection. She saw him take his erect cock in his hand, pump it once before realizing where he was, then turn to

hide it. She squeezed her legs together, rubbing her thighs, wanting to touch herself, too.

He got under the covers, rolling onto his side, and faked a yawn. "You should go if you're up for it. I'm beat."

The same lie he gave her back at the party. The same setup. The one time could have been her reading into things. The second time was a confirmation.

"Me too," she said. She saw the disappointment register in his face. "Too much to drink."

He wanted her to go, but he would never say it. She touched his face, tracing his delicate features. He had high cheekbones and smooth skin. "I love you, Cooper."

"I love you, too." But he was back to the formality. The passion from earlier had faded with his disappointment.

And yet now she knew how to rekindle it. Could it be that simple? She leaned down and kissed his cheek. "I'm going to take a shower. You get some rest."

"Okay." He sounded down. Or maybe just tired. "Good night, Anni."

"Night, Cooper."

Cooper was almost asleep when the shower cut off. He waited, pretending to be asleep when she came out, and was disappointed when she crawled in with him rather than sneak out of the room.

“I love you,” she whispered. He shifted, but kept pretending to slumber.

He was disappointed, and knew that it wasn’t fair. He should have been happy. Annika had chosen him over the likes of Brett or Ryan—not just now, in this moment, but in life. She’d married him. They were building a life together. He was being an idiot, wishing that she’d go up to that party.

And then he really was asleep, and his dreams were troubled. He’d walk into a room to find Annika riding another man, hands braced on muscular shoulders as this man gripped her hips and fucked up into her. As always in these dreams, the sex had the kind of physicality that he could never give to her. The kind that he knew she got from her past lovers.

When he awoke with a start, it was dark. The lights were out. He felt the sickly throb of a hangover threatening. The dream faded quickly, leaving him feeling jealous and disgusted with himself.

He turned to touch Annika, to reassure him that it was just a dream and that she would always be there.

But her spot in the bed was empty. More than that, it was cold. She was gone.

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PART II

THE FANTASY

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“So just so I’m clear here,” Annika said, even though she was already pretty clear on the expectations, “you want me to sleep with another man.”

“That’s right.”

“As in have sex. With another man.”

“Another *man*, yes. Another woman, while seriously hot, doesn’t pack the same punch.”

Annika shook her head. She comprehended the words. This wasn’t a case of miscommunication, and yet she still didn’t *understand*. She reached out and took his hand. “Brett, honey, why would you want me to do that?”

He just shot that disarming smile that got her to notice him in the first place. “Because it’s—”

“Hot,” she said with him. “But why is it hot?”

He shrugged. “Why does a blowjob feel good?”

It was such a Brett thing to say—simplistic and graphic and all-encompassing at once.

“You want to fuck around with other women.”

“Not without you.” He winked, and she blushed, thinking about Phoebe.

She tried another reason. “You want me to be a slut.”

“Sometimes,” he said. They were lying in bed, naked and sweaty from sex. She could feel his come inside her, warm and slippery and starting to ooze down her inner thigh. He said, “You like sex, right?”

“I like sex with you.”

“But not just with me.” Brett had a way of speaking in declarative statements that were never up for interpretation or debate. It was infuriating, at times, but it was also one of the things she loved about him. “You can’t tell me that I’m the only person that you’ve had sex with that made you come.”

“Of course not. But that doesn’t make me want to run out and fuck every guy who looks at my tits.”

“You could though, you know.” He palmed her tit, running his thumb across her small nipple. It bloomed into a hard knot. “They’re great tits, and you’re hot. They all want to fuck you.”

“But I don’t want to fuck them. I’m with you. You’re all that I need.”

“We’re not talking about what you need,” he said, persistent.

“No, we’re talking about what *you* want.” She giggled.

“And what I want, you want,” he stated. “You like to please.” He nuzzled her neck, buttering her up. “Like with Phoebe.”

Phoebe, her wild friend from college, and now something more... She fought down the blush. “Didn’t you just say that me with another woman doesn’t pack the same punch?”

“I also said it was hot.” He ran his hand down between her legs, rubbing his slippery come into her clit. “And I seem to recall that it didn’t take much convincing.”

“Maybe I’ve always been a little bi-curious.” She gasped as he pressed two fingers into her.

“No,” he said. “I don’t think that’s it. Not entirely. You started kissing her, at first, for me...”

It was true. They’d all been hanging out, drinking wine and smoking some joints her friend had brought when Phoebe started touching her hair. Annika saw the look on Brett’s face, the way he was smiling, encouraging.

The way he gave her a subtle nod. The next thing she knew, she was in a full-on, girl-on-girl makeout session.

“You liked that I was there,” he whispered, his fingers pumping into her pussy, just the way Phoebe’s had. “You kept looking over, checking my reaction.”

Annika whimpered, but was unable to deny it.

“I saw how you nearly came when I told you to go down on her,” he said.

She gasped, thinking about how she’d done that. How she’d made another woman come with her mouth and her tongue. How she’d gotten into it, knowing how hot it was making her boyfriend.

Brett helped her connect the dots. “So what’s so different about doing it with another guy?”

And suddenly it wasn’t Phoebe and her bare shaven pussy in front of her, but another man and a stiff, rigid cock. “Would you really want that?” she asked Brett, her voice strained.

“I don’t play games, Babe. You know that.” He kissed her, his thumb now encircling her clitoris and lighting her world on fire. “We’re young, hot, and having fun.”

She was so close. Almost there. Almost there.

“I know you have a vibe in your bedside drawer. Who do you think about when you use it—and don’t say *me*.”

Years later, she’d think back on this conversation and marvel at his directness, and how different it was from her future husband.

“You think of anyone we know?” he pressed.

“Yes,” she gasped.

“Tell me.”

She couldn’t, but when she looked at Brett, she realized that she could. That she wanted to. “Kai.”

Kai Lawrence, one of Brett’s best friends, currently living in Boulder. He was hot, the same way Brett was hot—fit, confident, easy-going.

“You like that dirtbag rock climber look?” He chuckled. “Fucking knew it.”

“Oh, he’s not so dirty,” she said. She said it as much to get a rise out of Brett as anything. “But he does look good without his shirt on.”

They’d spent a day at the beach earlier in the summer, and she liked what she saw. Brett was more muscular, but in a gym-hewn way versus

Kai's more outdoorsman physique. She'd looked at his calloused hands and wondered what they'd feel like on the inside of her thighs.

"He's got a big cock, too," Brett said.

She'd always wondered. She gasped, right at the edge of release.

"Uncut," he whispered. "And he fucks like an animal."

She came, thinking about Kai, bending her over and fucking hard into her—and she came even harder as she imagined Brett's excitement when she told him what she'd done. She let go of all the feelings of guilt, of propriety, of being the good girlfriend. Brett didn't want her being that woman. He wanted a slut.

"That really gets you off?" she asked.

"See for yourself." He pushed her down his body, where she kissed each rippling abdominal muscle on the way to his steel-hard erection. "Show me what you'd do to Kai," he said. "I'll show you exactly how it makes me feel."

With a glance up his body to meet his eyes, she took his cock into her mouth. Annika could taste herself on his shaft, mixed with the saltiness of his come. She didn't mind that taste, but more than that, she knew that he liked the idea of her tasting herself.

Brett liked the idea of her being a slut, and while she wasn't one, she liked putting on a show for him. It was like deep-throating—wasn't a great feeling for her, but it was so worth it to watch the guy's reaction.

She watched Brett as she swallowed all of his meat, suppressing the gag as she took him into her throat. She knew he was imagining her doing this with Kai now, and he wasn't getting any softer.

"God, Babe," he groaned. "That looks so good."

Looks so good, not *feels* so good. Well, if a show was what he wanted, a show was what she was happy to give. She gathered her hair back and out of her face, locked eyes with his, and swallowed all girthy, eight inches.

She used to be self-conscious of the sounds she made when she did this—the gurgling chokes and gags as she stroked his glans with her throat muscles. She used to try to suppress that until she realized how much it got him off. Deep-throating was as much about the show as it was about the sensation.

"That's it, Babe. Keep sucking my cock the way you would suck his," Brett said, and Annika obeyed. She choked on him, thinking of choking on

Kai. She wondered if he was shaved bare like Brett, and hoped that he wasn't.

"Play with yourself," Brett commanded.

She did that, too, pushing her fingers into her sex and tickling her clit as she thought about Brett's hot friend. Only it wasn't just her and Kai. Brett was there, too, watching her blow his friend, just like how he watched her go down on Phoebe. And like her time with Phoebe, it was electric.

Her orgasm caught her by surprise. She had to pull back or risk actually choking on his cock. Brett was right there with her, though, grabbing his cock and taking over. She felt his come splash across her cheek, but was too caught up in her own climax to turn away from the facial.

"I cannot wait to see you do that with Kai."

"I haven't agreed to actually doing it."

Brett was so smug. She wanted to shove him, but instead cuddled back into him. "Sometimes I don't get why I love you so much."

"Because you like being naughty, but you also need an excuse." He kissed the top of her head. "I provide."

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The line at the coffee stand at Kramer Books was long, and like everyone else in it, Cooper was on his phone, killing time. Because of that, he didn't see her until it was his turn to order, and even then he didn't immediately recognize her.

"Hey, what'll you have today?" she asked with a pleasant smile. Annika looked younger than when he'd run into her a week ago in the laundry room. Her hair threw him off—worn in a pair of long, skinny braids—along with her chunky glasses. She actually recognized him first. "Oh, hey. It's Mr. Fluffy's owner!"

Her smile gave her away. "Hey," he said in a way that instantly made him feel like an adolescent boy. "You work here?"

She looked around. "Hope so, otherwise I'm not sure why I'm wearing this apron."

Cooper laughed a little too enthusiastically at the joke, running his finger through his hair the way he did when he got nervous. “Right, of course.” He looked at the apron, trying hard not to notice how it conformed to the swell of her breasts and tied around her narrow waist. He focused on her name tag. “Annika. That’s a pretty name.”

He resisted the urge to say something about how she must have Scandinavian parents, figuring she got that all the time.

“Thanks. I’m sorry, but I’m actually not sure what your name is, either.”

“Oh, um, Cooper.”

“Nice to meet you, Um Cooper. What’ll you have today?”

“Hm?” For a second, he completely forgot where he was. She held up the paper cup and Sharpie, raising her brows in expectation. “Oh, right. Medium mocha please.”

She scribbled something on the cup. “Whip cream?”

“No thanks.”

“Grande mocha, no whip,” she called to the barista, setting a cup along the counter’s edge.

As strange as it was to meet her in the laundry room last week, this seemed even stranger. Like meeting a character out of a book.

It got even stranger when the man at the espresso machine turned out to be her boyfriend, Brett. Brett, with his man-bun and stubble and broad shoulders. Brett, who had fucked her to a screaming orgasm a couple nights ago, as Cooper lay a floor below, jerking off. Brett, who made Cooper feel small and pathetic for no other reason than being Brett.

He stepped in behind Annika and put an arm over her shoulder. “This guy flirting with you, Babe?” He didn’t say it like he was angry or jealous. It seemed more like a joke between them.

Annika just rolled her eyes, bumping him with her hip. “This is Cooper. He actually lives in my building.”

“Really?” Brett said, giving Cooper an appraising look. “Nice to meet you, Coop.”

Coop. Like they were buddies already. Cooper wasn’t sure how he felt about that. He was used to not being seen by jocks like Brett. He didn’t want to like this man even a little, yet the guy seemed harmless. It made it easier to imagine a sweet and smart girl like Annika with the bro-y barista.

“One grande mocha, no whip, coming right up,” he turned back to the espresso machine, grabbing a paper cup off the queue and flipping it in his

hand. He bobbled it, almost dropped it on the floor, but caught it at the last moment. “I got it, I got it.”

Annika rolled her eyes again, but was giggling to herself. “You’ll have to excuse Brett. He’s an idiot.” She adjusted her glasses. “That’ll be \$4.25.”



THAT WAS the way of things for a while. Cooper ran into Annika around their neighborhood, passing in the stairwell or at the bookshop. They’d stop and exchange pleasantries—mostly about books or the weather. Safe subjects. No more talk of love and the stupid shit they did for it.

He tried not to act too much like a stalker. He had his own life, of course. Own job, own hobbies—cycling—and his own friends. He was on some online dating services which did lead to a few dates, although they never went that well. Annika just happened to thread herself through his life, the way any neighbor would.

The sex in 3C continued, too, of course, as wild and loud as ever. It was made even more unreal because he knew the participant so well. When he heard them above, the rhythmic squeak of the mattress and, on occasion, the sound of a spank followed by a cry of ecstasy, it broke his brain a little to square the two Annikas.

It got even stranger when he ran into Brett and Annika one night at a bar down the street. He had actually been on a date that didn’t go so well. They had not clicked and spent most of the time awkwardly bouncing between subjects without ever gaining much traction. She’d left. Cooper had stayed. And that’s when he saw them over by the bar.

Annika always looked good, but that night she looked particularly radiant. She wore the kind of dress that hot girls wore in fantasies and the internet, but not one he thought Annika would. It was a tight, heather gray bodycon that highlighted her toned legs and her tits, full and hanging like a pair of ripe grapefruits.

She was laughing, doing a little dance for Brett, who sat at the bar and laughed with her. Cooper knew it was his imagination, but it seemed like this woman bent the light to her, like she was perpetually in the spotlight. Everyone seemed to notice but her.

And then she saw him across the way. Cooper fought the gut-reaction to avert his eyes and duck into the crowd. Instead, fueled a bit by the beers he'd had and the failure of his date, he shared her smile. When she waved him over, he went.

"I thought that was you," she said, actually hugging him there in the bar. They'd never hugged before. They didn't have the kind of hugging relationship, but it seemed right for the venue. She felt good, and smelled even better. Cooper was mortified when he started to harden, breaking the hug before he was ready for it to end.

She turned to Brett. "You remember Cooper?"

He shook his head, which is funny because they had definitely met a couple times, both at Kramers and outside their apartment.

"He lives in my building," she helped out.

"Ah, right," Brett said. Cooper was pretty sure he'd be forgotten again as soon as the night was over. "Coop, right?"

Or maybe he did remember him. "Cooper, yeah."

"Sorry, sorry. Nice to see you again, *Cooper*." Brett wasn't being a bully, or even antagonistic. His careful enunciation of Cooper's preferred name was more casual than that, like everything in the world was a joke, and nothing was worth taking seriously. "You stalkin' my girl?"

Brett put his arm around Annika's shoulder and gave Cooper that look that he was so used to getting from jocks through his whole life. *Go ahead and look, because that's all you're going to be able to do.*

"Oh, stop," Annika said. "He was here on a date, looked like."

She'd noticed him earlier? Cooper thought. He felt his feet lift off the ground. The urge to do a little dance was real. Instead, he just smiled and waved it away. "That wasn't meant to be. All she wanted to talk about was knitting."

Annika's laugh felt good, like sinking into a warm bath. "Hey now, I enjoy knitting, too."

To Brett, Cooper said, "But does she talk about it all the time?" He was starting to find his stride.

Brett shrugged. "I didn't know she knitted at all."

"I made you a scarf for Christmas," she said flatly.

"Oh, you *made* that? I thought you got it at Abercrombie or something." Brett pinched his topknot. "No shit! That's pretty good."

Annika rolled her eyes and looked at Cooper. “See what I have to deal with?”

And you shouldn't have to, Cooper fantasized about saying.

Brett ordered them a round of shots. Apparently it was Brett's birthday, and Cooper went right along. His failed date was an ancient memory. He was spellbound in the presence of Annika. This wasn't idle chit chat. This wasn't passing in the halls or in the coffee shop, exchanging pleasantries. This was *hanging out*.

It was everything he imagined that it would be. There was this air of youthful innocence mixed with carnality to Annika. She was sweet and smart. They discussed their favorite authors. But she also stood there, wearing a tight dress that accentuated her very naughty body.

“So you do anything fun for your birthday?” Cooper asked Brett. The small talk got easier the later it got and the more he drank.

Brett wasn't immune to the alcohol, either, though. He looked at his watch. “My birthday technically starts in... ten minutes.” Cooper was surprised to see that it was nearly midnight. Brett glanced at Annika as he said, “And I'm hoping for a lot of fun.”

Cooper saw the exchange pass between the two. Annika's face darkened as she held her boyfriend's gaze for a moment, then looked away. Brett's happy drunk facade fell for a moment, yielding to an intense and hungry look before the sloppy smile was back.

“I think she's still trying to decide what to get me for my birthday,” he said. He glanced at Cooper and then back at Annika, raising a single brow. “Hm?”

Annika shook her head, quick and tight. *No way*, the gesture said. Red flooded up her neck.

Despite feeling thoroughly confused, Cooper's stomach fluttered at whatever was happening. He felt so out of his depth, like he'd been invited to sit with the popular kids in high school and couldn't tell if he was being pranked.

“I am going to use the ladies room.” Annika held up her empty glass that once held a gin and tonic. “Hoping this will be full again when I get back.”

Cooper was buzzed enough that he openly stared at her ass as she weaved away through the crowd. She had to be wearing a thong beneath the dress. That or nothing at all.

Brett caught him looking. “Amazing ass, isn’t it?”

“I...” Cooper rubbed the back of his neck, half expecting to feel flames. “You’re lucky, Brett.”

“Want to fuck her?” He was grinning in a silly way that Cooper couldn’t decipher. The answer was yes, of course, but Brett had to know that. Instead, he felt like he was finally going to sink into the depth that he’d waded out to.

“I...” He felt hot. Felt like he was hyperventilating.

“I’m just fucking with you,” Brett said. It didn’t help. He looked past Cooper, seeing something that made him light up. “Excuse me.” He stood from the stool and stepped past him. “Oh, and can you order us another round? Add one more. Put it all on Annika’s tab.”

Like that, Cooper was forgotten. Turning, he watched as Brett approached a guy he apparently knew, watching the two embrace in a back-slapping man-hug. “Kai...” he vaguely heard Brett greet.

He knew what came next. Cooper had been a fun diversion for Brett and Annika, but Kai belonged, looking like he’d stepped off the pages of an REI catalog. He had scruff. He had tattoos. He wore a North Face vest despite it being summer in San Diego. Most of all, he had confidence.

Cooper ordered the drinks, turned, and left. It had been fun, but he knew that things were about to get awkward.

Annika liked her neighbor, Cooper. She didn't have many friends in the city, but she could see the two of them actually being friends. There was an ease and openness to him—different than Brett's easy-going persona, which revolved around maximizing fun. She would fantasize about staying up late at night with Cooper, drinking wine and talking about Big, Important Things.

More to the point, until tonight, she'd never thought about Cooper in a sexual way. And now, Brett's fantasy had poisoned her own. Worse, now that they had, she couldn't *not* think about it.

Cooper was good looking. Skinnier than Brett, more of a runner than a surfer, he still kept in shape. He was shy, too, in an endearing way that made her want to hold him and protect him—and even that became sexy thanks to Brett.

As was becoming the norm, Annika was both flustered and frustrated by her boyfriend. She'd worn the dress and put on her makeup with the intent of teasing him for his birthday. She'd flirt with other guys, let them all look, just to get her boyfriend worked up... and get herself worked up, she admitted.

But she wasn't going to sleep with some random stranger she met at a bar. She could pretend to be the naughty girl in Brett's bedroom—and it turned her on flirting with the idea—but that wasn't really her, either.

Cooper's not a random stranger, a husky voice in her head whispered. She knew this voice, and worse, knew how much fun she had when she succumbed to it. For a brief moment, she considered it. She saw herself dropping to her knees in front of Cooper as Brett watched, and the heat was intense and real and dangerous.

Was she ever going to be able to look at her neighbor the same way after tonight?

You're overthinking it again, the voice prodded. Or maybe she was just channeling some of Brett, who unfailingly jumped head first into any situation with little thought of cost or consequence. It's what she loved about the man.

"I can go with it," she whispered to herself. "It's his birthday, after all."

Just like that moment when she decided to have a threesome with her best friend, she felt freed—freed from her good girl persona, freed from societal expectations, freed from her own guilt. She was just having fun.

"You done in there?" someone yelled, banging on the bathroom door.

Annika jumped, then laughed at herself for the big reaction. "Yeah, I'm all good now."

She exited to a long line of glaring, disgruntled people. Scrunching her head into her shoulders, she quietly apologized as she moved past them. "Sorry, sorry." Her cheeks were warm by the time she made it back out to the bar.

Brett was there, but it wasn't Cooper he was with. "Oh, hey, Kai," she said.

"Anni, so good to see you!" Kai had a boisterous personality to fit his large, muscular frame. When he gave her a hug, she couldn't help but run her hands up his triceps and over his muscled back. She wondered what that would feel like without the layer of shirt. She wondered if she'd find out later that night.

Glancing at her boyfriend, it was like he was reading her mind. He just smiled appreciatively at her, the fire burning as bright as ever.

“So what brings you out?” she asked. This wasn’t a coincidence. Another glance at Brett confirmed it.

Kai wasn’t going to give up the game, though. “What kind of friend would miss his boy’s twenty-third?”

“A true milestone,” Annika said with a sagely nod. “Cooper leave?”

“Yeah, guess so,” Brett said with a shrug. He handed her another gin and tonic. “He got you your drink, though.”

Always thoughtful. She felt equal parts relief and disappointment that Cooper was gone. Around him, she could be herself—yet tonight, she kind of liked the idea of not being herself at all.

“He also got us a round of shots,” Brett went on, waving his hand to the bar, where three shots sat. “And...” he looked at his watch, “looks like it’s now, officially, my birthday.”

Annika passed the shot glasses out, wondering where this night was going. She still didn’t get it. She still didn’t get Brett’s fantasy. If he loved her, why did he want her to have sex with other men? She loved him. She didn’t need anyone else. Was he saying that he also needed other people?

They were the same thoughts and emotions that warred within her whenever she thought about it. She’d tumbled through them over and over, never coming up with a satisfying answer. But she wasn’t going to go there tonight.

The gin and tonics helped. Kai and his slab-of-muscle body helped. And inexplicably, Cooper, her neighbor and his boyish smile, helped the most.

“To the birthday boy!” she said, raising her glass. She looked at Kai—and made sure that her boyfriend saw the look. “I cannot *wait* for him to unwrap his gift.”

Annika, Brett, and Kai were laughing as they fell into their apartment. She was drunk, but not so drunk that she didn't know exactly what was about to happen. That was part of the buzz—the sexual tension that hopped between the three of them like heat lightning.

Nothing had happened... yet. Nothing had even been stated outright. It was 1:30 in the morning, and Brett had declared that he was done with the bar, but not done with drinking. They'd picked up Big Slice pizza on the way home, and back in her apartment, Brett prepped her bong.

Kai and Annika watched from the couch with big smiles, sipping their beers from longneck bottles. "He seems happy," Kai said. He had intense, blue eyes—beautiful eyes. Annika was always a sucker for that. "You make him happy."

"I'm not sure if Brett has a mode that's *not* happy," she said.

Kai chuckled. "Fair. Okay, so you make him *extra* happy."

“Just him?” She’d shed her shyness several drinks ago, and felt as forward as her boyfriend.

“That dress is making me extra happy,” Kai admitted. He didn’t even blush. She wondered if Kai and Brett had done something like this before. If anything, that prospect made her more excited.

“This old thing?” she asked, running her fingers over the material. “I love how soft it feels against my skin.” She bit her lip and looked up at him, taking his hand. “Here, feel.”

With that, she pulled his hand—calloused and manly—against her. She’d considered bringing it to her breast, but chickened out at the last moment, placing it on her ribcage instead. It was enough. His touch felt good—different than Brett’s, but sexy because of it.

“Very soft.” He stroked the lower slope of her breast with his thumb, tracing the underwire of her bra. “I can see why you like it.”

Annika gasped as he shifted his hand up, palming her whole tit. He would be able to feel her nipple through the dress and the bra.

Kai had tattoos all up and down his arms. It was sexy because it was so different than Brett. And where was Brett? She looked for him, turning her head to the kitchenette. He was there, watching, bong frozen in his hands. Kai pressed closer, kissing her neck, and her boyfriend grinned and raised the bong to her.

That was all the encouragement that she needed. She turned back to Kai and kissed him, pushing her tongue into her mouth and her body into his hands.

Their clothes came off quickly. She’d always admired his body, but it was even better to touch. She ran her nails over his muscles as he slid a hand between her legs and into her thong. She was so wet, and was excited that he felt that.

“Ngh!” she cried as he pressed those strong, climber’s fingers into her.

“You’re so fucking sexy,” he whispered. He had her bra off, and dipped down to swallow her nipple into his mouth. His face was scruffy. He smelled like a man.

She sought out his cock, finding it hard and ready for her hand. Brett hadn’t lied—he was big. Bigger than Brett. Bigger than most she’d been with. It scared her. It excited her.

She kissed and made out more, hands roaming, lips and tongue exploring. “I want to suck your big dick.”

Guys loved hearing when she said stuff like that, but for Kai, she wasn't just saying it for his ego. She did want to suck it. She wanted to gag on it. She wanted Brett to watch her do it.

Kai didn't protest. When she looked at Brett to make sure that this was okay, he gave an enthusiastic nod. He'd settled into the chair perpendicular, and had lit up the bong.

Annika got up onto the sofa, leaned over, and took as much of Kai's sizable dick into her mouth. Brett could see it all—a frontline seat to his ultimate fantasy. She nearly came herself, knowing that he was watching.

"Fuck, Babe, that feels so..." Kai shuddered, nearly coming. "Not many chicks can take that much of me."

She slurped off of him. "I'm not most chicks." Her voice was husky from having his dick in her throat. She knew that only added to the appeal. She licked his balls. "And I love a good challenge."

"Damn, man, this one's a keeper."

Brett chuckled. "If you like this, just wait until you fuck her."

Try as she might, she couldn't take all of him, but managed to touch her lips to his dark, pubic curls. She fucked him with her throat, playing up the gagging sounds for both Kai and Brett. They all knew where this was going, though. They all knew what the main event would be.

By the time Annika rose, peeling her thong off and crawling into Kai's lap, she was practically vibrating with anticipation. They kissed, hungry for one another, ready to take things to the next level. Grasping Kai's dick, she looked him right in the eyes and asked, "Do you have a condom?"

She heard Brett choke, which brought a smile to her lips. She glanced over at him as Kai grabbed his pants and fished out a foil wrapper. He had the most intense expression on his face. She shivered, encouraged to continue.

She took the condom from Kai and tore it open with her teeth. He groaned as she rolled it over his uncut cock. "You're unreal, Anni," he groaned. "Your fucking body..."

"That's right," she said, looking him in the eyes as she guided his cock to her pussy. "You're about to fuck this body."

Feeling the pressure of his dick against her very wet opening, she hesitated only a moment, long enough to glance at Brett. He was chewing on his lower lip, chest rising and falling rapidly, his hand massaging his cock through his pants. He nodded to her. *Do it. Enjoy it. I sure as fuck am.*

Annika tossed her hair and looked back at Kai, who seemed just as eager. It made her giddy. It made her feel free. And when she sank down onto a new dick, it made her feel—

“So good!” she cried out. He was huge. The pressure was unreal. This wasn’t Brett. This wasn’t her love. This was unmistakably new, and unquestionably erotic because of that. “You’re so... big!”

“She loves a big dick,” Brett said. “Don’t you, baby?”

“Mm, yes!”

She heard him take a hit off the bong, then chuckle. “Best fucking birthday, ever.”

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“**U** h! Uh! Uh!” She was going at it hard, Cooper thought. “Yes! *Fuck me! Fuck me!*”

They weren’t in the bed, but whatever they were fucking on was banging against the wall with each thrust. Something crashed to the floor and broke. They didn’t slow down. If anything, the bumping only got louder and faster.

This was typical behavior coming out of 3C on a Friday night, only things felt different. He’d just seen her. He’d had a drink with her. He knew what she wore when the night had begun, how she smelled, how she laughed.

Listening to her fucking had once felt like porn. That had begun to change since he’d run into her in the laundry room. She wasn’t just the sexy and unapproachable blonde with the big-dicked boyfriend. Now she was the sexy and unapproachable blonde with the big-dicked boyfriend who knitted

scarves and worked in a bookstore coffee shop. She was the woman who understood why he adopted a cat despite being allergic to them. She was so much more than a pornstar, and because of all of that, her moans and cries above were that much more visceral.

He could hear talking, but couldn't make out the words beyond a bassy rumble. Annika only moaned louder. "*Yes! Yes, I... I... I love it. Love that... big fucking...cock!*"

Hard not for Cooper to think of his first meeting with her, when she'd said, "*Love. It's total shit*" and called her boyfriend a real asshole. He wondered what she was doing for him "for love"? Breaking more of her furniture? Complimenting him louder on the size of his own manhood?

But she did love her boyfriend. Cooper saw it earlier, at the bar. As much as he wanted to vilify the guy, to secretly root against their relationship, he couldn't. He wasn't that kind of guy. Besides, a man like Brett could make a girl like Annika a hell of a lot happier than Cooper ever could.

"*Come, Baby!*" she cried out above. "*Give me your come.*"

With one last, loud shove, Brett came with a roar. Cooper imagined it—the man's muscular upper body straining as he holds Annika up against the wall, their naked bodies beaded with sweat. It was like he was there, in the room, watching, spying.

Cooper came as Annika did, and his brain flashed dazzling colors of bright red and envious green. It was always transcendental, and it always passed. He was once again alone in his bed, and Annika and her sex partner were launching into round two as Cooper's come cooled on his stomach.

Later in life, he would reflect back on that night—and all the other nights like it—and think about how, even when he and Annika got together, it had never been like what he heard out of 3C. Their sex life, much like their eventual relationship, was one of mutual respect. They made love. They cuddled. They reveled in the feel of skin-on-skin. What Cooper heard in the apartment above was none of that. Brett *took*, and Annika was desperate to give. Brett fucked. Annika begged for more.

What he didn't want to admit, even to himself, was that as he jerked off, he never *was* the guy who was fucking her. With his eyes closed and the image of Brett naked ass rising and falling between Annika's legs, the only thing that Cooper ever got to do was watch. And he was okay with that.

“Oh, yes! Oh, fuck!” They were at it again, and as usual, Cooper found his second wind along with them.

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PART III

THE FESTIVAL

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“Hey, there. Grande mocha, no whip?” Annika asked. She could see the pleasure in Cooper’s face when she remembered his order. It was cute.

“Yes, please.”

Cooper was making it a habit of coming into Kramer’s in the morning, on his way to work. He didn’t do it *every* day, and he didn’t only come in when he knew that Annika was working there, but she was the main reason he paid too much for a cup of coffee. He said, “I should probably switch it up. You’re getting to know me too well.”

Her laugh was musical. Everything about her was musical. Her smile, the way it highlighted her high cheekbones and the soft dusting of freckles that never seemed to get any darker.

“I like the consistency, actually.” She took his card. “You do you.”

It had been a few months since Brett's birthday, and since then, their budding friendship had started to grow. They'd shared coffees. They'd gone to the occasional lunch. Now—

"I'm so excited about the Festival of Books," Annika said as she handed him back his card. They'd talked mostly about books, since that was one of their primary interests. That, and travel, although one was much easier to share than the other.

"I've already put my schedule together," she went on. There was Annika's smile, somehow both bright yet shy, like sunshine hiding behind some fluffy, summer clouds. "Emily St. John Mandel's talk, for sure."

"I saw that," he said. "I'd like to see her talk, too."

"Great! We can sit together."

They were going to spend a whole day together, and while it was totally platonic, the idea made him jittery with excitement, almost like it was a date.

It helped that Brett had moved away, although Cooper felt guilty about being happy about that. Annika and Brett had been long distance for the last month, and while he was only an hour away in LA and she visited often, Cooper got to see her a lot more. And this weekend, she'd chosen him over Brett.

Or chosen the book festival, but this was close enough.

Cooper got ready for going out like he would a date. He showered and shaved. He agonized over what to wear, finally telling himself that he was being an idiot and put on a pair of jeans and a flannel... then swapped the flannel with a light, v-neck sweater that he hoped didn't look too date-like. He was about to change again when she knocked on his door.

If Annika had been anxious, she didn't show it. She wore a casual, t-shirt dress and a pair of ballet flats. Like at the coffee bar, she wore her blonde hair in twin braids, and her glasses on. Not a date look, Cooper thought, burying his embarrassment beneath a smile.

"Ready?" she asked.

"Uh, yeah, let me just grab my phone." When he turned, he was a little surprised when she followed him in.

"It's so weird," she said, looking around. "It's the same layout, but looks totally different?"

"Hm?" Cooper tried to act casual, but inside he was freaking out. *She's in my apartment! She's here!* "Oh, yeah. You mean not every apartment has

a day's worth of dirty dishes in the sink?"

He was slightly embarrassed by that, but not enough to abolish the excitement of having *this girl* in his place. She laughed lightly, the way she did. "Actually, my dirty dishes are piled up on the counter. The sink's for holding dirty cups."

It felt good to laugh with Annika. "I know what you mean, though," he said. "I grew up in one of those suburbs where every house was the exact same. It was actually fun seeing how different they could all be, despite being so similar."

Mr. Fluffy strolled into the room and flopped himself onto the carpet, stretching out. "Aw, this must be the lucky guy." Annika crouched down, giving the cat a rub. He ate it up, his purr filling the whole room. "I love your carpets. I should get some myself." She looked up at him, a touch of nervousness in her voice as she asked, "I hope I don't make too much noise."

Cooper willed himself not to react to that—to act like he couldn't hear the hard fucking she got when her boyfriend visited. "Not too much, no. I wouldn't worry about it."

Annika looked relieved, nodding. She gave Mr. Fluffy one last stroke before standing and glancing into his bedroom. Cooper realized he'd left the various changes of clothes on the bed. Face heating up, he said, "Well, ready to get going? Don't want to be late..."

The book festival felt like a dream. They spent the day together. They had lunch, coffees, skipped sessions just to talk more, to get to know one another better. At first they stuck to standard book festival topics—authors they liked and didn't, ones who they agreed were overrated, their favorite books.

By the end of the day, though, they'd moved on to more personal matters. Cooper learned that Annika was the middle child of three sisters. She grew up in Ohio. She played lacrosse through high school. She spent more time in the library studying than at parties during college, and in fact spoke about Greek life with a disdain that Cooper identified with.

She was also just really easy to talk to. Talking to her, spending the day with her, helped him get past the intimidation he felt around someone as good looking as Annika. He opened up to her. He told her things he rarely told anyone else—how he was writing a book in his free time, about being an only child and the guilt he still carried around when his parents split up,

about living in San Diego for almost a year and not having made a single friend.

“I feel the same way,” Annika said.

“You’ve got Brett.”

“Had Brett,” she said, and Cooper wondered if he was reading too much tone into the correction. “But he doesn’t count anyway.” She blushed when she realized what she was saying. “I mean, he is a *friend*, as in boyfriend...”

He had no right, but the envy was real as it burned through his chest.

“We just don’t talk like this.” She gestured between the two of them. “We don’t... talk like...” She flushed again and trailed off.

They had sex. They fucked. Theirs was a physical relationship, and she didn’t want to admit that to her newest—and currently only other—friend in this city.

“I get it,” Cooper said, helping her out. “Different dynamic with a boyfriend.”

“Right, I suppose...” She was chewing on something. He gave her the space to work through it, and Annika appreciated that, too. “But should it be different? Shouldn’t our future spouses be, like, our best friends, too?”

I could be that man for you, he yearned to say. So much that he felt ill, even knowing that he had no right to feel this way. She barely knew him, and he hated himself for how creepy it sounded. “I don’t think relationships are prescribed like that,” he said. “Each is unique. That’s what makes them special, right? Brett seems like a good guy—”

“He is.”

“—and while he may not be part of your book club—”

She snorted with laughter at that.

“—you two connect in other ways.” Like hardcore fucking. He could almost hear the bed springs squeaking, her muffled cries, the occasional spank.

“Yeah,” she said with a smile all for herself. This was just the way things turned out for Cooper—he was the guy who made sure to remind the pretty girl that she’s got a boyfriend, when others would try and do anything but. “Brett... is a good cook.”

They were sitting in the lounge, drinking coffee. The last session of the day had started, but none of the authors or panelists interested either of them.

She continued. "And I'm a really bad one, but he's terrible at baking, and I'm pretty good, if I do say so myself."

"Okay." Cooper didn't really know where this was going, but acted like he understood because that's what you do when talking to girls who look like her.

"I love to bake because it requires planning and careful measuring. Cooking can, I suppose, but not the way Brett does it. He cooks like he plays an instrument. It's as much about feel as it is about the instructions. And I love that about him."

Hearing her talk about how much she loved another man wasn't Cooper's first choice of conversation topic, but she was happy, and that made him happy. "Seems like you complement one another well."

"Sometimes feels like oil and water, but..." She smiled and nodded to herself. "...yeah. He certainly can make life interesting. Plus, I think he'd make a great dad." She seemed to realize what she'd implied and went red. "Eventually, I mean. We're not planning on... you know..."

"Right, right, of course." He was flustered right along with her. "So, um..." he looked around for something else to talk about. Annika beat him to it.

"Kai?" she said.

Before Cooper could ask her what she was talking about, he heard another man answer, just behind him.

"Annika. Thought you may be here."

Cooper recognized the man, although they'd never met. He was Brett's friend from the bar, wearing a flannel with enough buttons undone to display that he had tattoos on the muscular chest, his dark hair cut short on the sides and longer up top, and the scruffy facial hair that goes with that kind of look.

"What are you doing here?" Annika asked. Cooper couldn't quite place it, but something had changed in her demeanor. The newly approachable vibe he got from her—the literal girl-next-door appeal—fell away, and he was suddenly in the presence of cool, beautiful people again, like high school.

"Same's you," Kai said. "A climbing buddy of mine wrote a book. I was here to support him."

Annika's eyes narrowed, just for a moment, more thoughtful than suspicious. She said, "What's his name?"

Kai gave the name of someone who Cooper had read about in the program. Annika recognized it, too. “You know him?” she asked.

“Yeah, we run in the same circle. His book’s fucking great, too. Didn’t realize the man could write like that.”

“You know, I had no idea you read... like, anything!” She wasn’t being mean. Annika never really got mean like that. This was a tease, and one shared between two familiar people. Cooper felt even more pushed to the sidelines. “Hey, this is my friend, Cooper.”

And like that, he was back inside the warming circle. “Nice to meet you, Cooper. I’m Kai.” They shook hands, and he had a grip like a vice. Kai seemed to size him up, his eyes darting between Annika and Cooper. Evidently, he didn’t see anything remarkable there. “You two having a good time here?”

“Yeah, it’s been a great day.” That’s what Cooper was going to say, but it was Annika who said it. That, too, felt good. The day *had* been great, and in large part because of her.

“Yup,” Cooper said. “It’s cool seeing the authors’ perspectives behind their books, you know? And just how much of their lives they write into them.”

“Totally,” Kai agreed. “That’s cool.”

Annika checked her watch. “Closing keynote’s starting soon. We better head in there to get a seat.”

“I think I’m gonna skip it,” Kai said. “You two have fun. But hey, you doing anything after?” The question was mostly for Annika, Cooper realized, although the man was gracious enough to look at him, too.

“No plans,” Annika said. “We were thinking of grabbing a bite somewhere.”

They were? Cooper loved the idea. He did a little, mental jig.

Kai handed her a flyer. It had a photo of his climbing “buddy” and a bar’s name on it. “You should check this out. Happy hour after the keynote. I’ll get us a round.”

Annika looked at Cooper. *What do you think?* she seemed to ask. That silent communication felt good, too.

“Sure, sounds like fun,” Cooper said.

Annika smiled up at Kai. “We’ll be there.”

“See you then, kids.”

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The next part of the day wasn't quite as great as the first. Like all things in life, Cooper realized that this one had to end, too. He'd later come to the same conclusion about his future marriage.

He barely remembered what the closing keynote had to say, other than talk about narrative structure—beginning, middle, and end. He got caught up on that, snagged like a piece of driftwood in swirling backwater. He was getting close to the end with Annika.

They left together, heading out into the late afternoon. It was still Southern California outside. The world kept on turning. Cooper surprised himself by asking, "Want to get that drink at Kai's thing?"

"Oh." Annika sounded surprised, too. "Sure."

Did she not want to? Did she actually want to just go home? Too late now. The bar was just a couple blocks away. All the bars along this strip

seemed to be filling up with people from the Book Festival, many still wearing their badges.

Cooper tried to make small talk, but it felt awkward again. “You have fun today?”

“Yeah. It was... it was wonderful. Thank you, Cooper.”

Cooper blushed. “Why are you thanking me?”

She shrugged. “Just... just... I don’t know. Like I said earlier, I don’t have many friends here. It’s nice to have that. A friend.”

A friend. It *was* nice to have a friend. That was going to be the best that he could be with her, after all. He carried that baggage into the bar with him, into the loud exterior of people drinking and socializing and connecting. It was one in which shy Cooper was never comfortable, and Annika seemed so at ease.

He went back to being a wallflower, watching, observing, being slowly moved to the outside once again. He watched her chat with strangers, to laugh with them, to talk about the festival or the news or whatever. He watched Kai come over, confident and familiar, and he watched them flirt.

This guy didn’t seem to have a problem with Brett being in the picture, and with Kai, Annika seemed to forget about her boyfriend, too. The emotions were strange—he spent so much time being envious of Brett, yet at that bar, he suddenly felt jealous *for* the man.

Or maybe jealous of Kai for being able to do what Cooper could not?

Annika was laughing at some story that Kai was telling a group of people when Cooper found her. “Hey, I think I’m going to head out.”

She turned away from the circle, her face falling a little. *Did she want him to stay?* Just like his suggestion to come here, it was too late to take this announcement back, either.

“It’s been a long day, and I’ve got my long ride tomorrow.” That *was* true. He usually reserved Sundays for long hauls on this bike, but that wasn’t the reason he was leaving.

“Right. Of course.” Her smile was back, her optimism and empathy for him. When she looked at him like that, with those deep, brown eyes of hers, Cooper felt like he was the only one in her world—it was a place that he wished he could stay forever, but knew he never would. “I’d love to ride with you sometime. You can help me get some new tubes in my bike and we can go out.”

“That sounds great.” So maybe this wasn’t the end. Just the end of the beginning. “Have fun tonight.”

Did she glance in Kai’s direction? Did she look uncertain—or maybe hyper certain? “I will. And Cooper? Thanks again for today.”

Again, he didn’t get why she was thanking him, but received it graciously. “Of course. See you around.”

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Annika knew that it wasn't fair to compare Cooper to Brett, but all day long, she'd been doing it anyway. She'd almost forgotten what it was like to have that kind of friendship. To be able to connect with someone intellectually. She loved Brett, and physically, he was a god in bed, but today reminded her that there was more to life than fucking.

Fucking was nice, too, though.

Not that she ever planned to fuck Cooper. Brett had teased her about her downstairs neighbor, of course, because the man was relentless in his fantasy. She maintained firmly with Brett—and herself—that Cooper was off-limits. She wanted one thing that was her own.

Kai, on the other hand, was entirely different. When she first saw Kai in the lounge at the book festival, her suspicions went up. Either he was there to spy, or to push Brett's "hotwife" game further. But Kai seemed to be

legitimately there, and besides, neither of those things seemed like things that Brett would do.

She had to admit that it was good to see Kai. The last time she saw him was when he had come down to help Brett move. With the truck packed and everyone needing a shower, they'd gone back to her place. One thing led to another and she'd ended up fucking Kai as Brett watched her. That was always the most intense part—the eyes on her, the way she could almost see his intensity radiate around him the way heat bent light.

They'd talked about it after—as much as she and Brett ever talked. “*You know you can see other guys when I’m not around, right?*”

“*But I don’t need to see other guys. I need you.*”

“*But you could... if you wanted.*”

“*You mean you want it,*” she'd said.

“*Hell, yeah I do.*”

She was past trying to figure out why he wanted that. She wasn't ever going to get a straight answer from him, and she had no more doubts that watching her fuck other men turned him on. But she also didn't need it, nor the complications that came with it, in her life when he wasn't around. The furthest she went was teasing him that she'd brought a man home from a bar, rather than telling him the real truth that she'd stayed in and read.

Kai was a reminder that it wasn't all teases, and that while she did it for her boyfriend, she did have fun. He was also the only man that she could actually talk about things with—Brett's fetish wasn't exactly a thing she was prepared to discuss with Cooper, no matter how easy it was to talk to him.

Even with all of that, she hated to see Cooper leave the bar. She was looking forward to having dinner with him and unpacking all the talks. She was curious what he thought about some of them, as a budding author. She just... liked being with him.

Maybe he didn't like her quite as much. Why had he left with that poor excuse? And why had she asked about going riding with him? It sounded desperate.

“Everything okay?” Kai had come over, seeing her alone. “Did your friend take off?”

“Yeah.” Her friend. At least she hoped so.

“Anything I should tell Brett about?” He grinned in his arrogant-yet-sexy way. “Or *not* tell him about?”

“No. It’s not like that. He’s just a friend.” She saw something in his face, though, something that she wasn’t accustomed to seeing with Brett. “You’re not jealous are you?”

Kai laughed it off, but she realized that he had something to laugh off. “Don’t worry, I’m not jealous of that guy.”

“He’s a good guy.” She heard the defensiveness in her voice, but maybe she could use that. “A gentleman.”

“Exactly, and it seems to me that you don’t seem to go for the polite ones.”

She raised her brows. “Is that so?”

“It is.” Any sympathy she had for him vanished with all that arrogance. “You need someone who doesn’t ask, but demands.”

“How very progressive of you,” she said.

“We’re not talking about me. We’re talking about you.”

She turned her chin up at him. “I can like nice boys.”

“Boys. See? They will always be ‘boys’. But you like your *men* a little more selfish.”

“You’re an asshole.”

“Sometimes. But I bet it’s turning you on.”

She hated to admit it, but it was. She was already thinking about their last time together, in the shower, her knees sore as she knelt on the tiles and blew him.

He sat back in his chair, smug. “So my hotel’s not far from here.”

“Did you forget that I have a boyfriend?”

Kai’s smile only grew wider. “Nope. We both know where he stands.”

“We do.” She made a show of looking around. “And he’s not standing anywhere close by.”

“He’s not.”

She groaned. “You would fuck your best friend’s girl behind his back?”

“He’ll forgive us.” He chuckled. “Hell, he’ll thank us.”

“Did I say you were an asshole?”

“A few times, yes.” He finished up his beer. “And honestly? It’s starting to turn *me* on, too.”



“Oh, yes! Oh, fuck! Oh... fuck me!” Annika wrapped a leg around Kai’s back, pumping her hips up into him with each downward thrust.

“You like it hard?” The question was a grunt that she had to interpret. It was a beast’s growl.

“Yes!” And she did, especially now, because *he* liked to give it to her hard. And good God did he do it well. “Harder! Give it to me harder.”

Everything about Kai felt different than Brett. He smelled differently. He had tattoos on his chest and upper arms. The weight of his stroking was different, less constrained, more demanding.

“Fuck, yeah!” he groaned above her. “I love the way you move your body, Baby.”

Kai flipped her onto her hands and knees. His cock was barely out of her before he rammed back home. He felt so good. So fucking big. “Ngh, yeah! Fuck it into me, baby.”

It was the kind of language that guys like Brett and Kai loved to hear from the kind of women that they loved to fuck. She could almost feel his cock swell at the dirty talk. It spurred her on. “God, your big dick feels so good.”

He held her hips, yanking her back into him with each thrust. He hit her deep, sending stars splattering across her vision.

This was different than when she’d fucked him in front of Brett. There was no need to perform. She was doing this only for herself. She never thought that she wanted it—she’d only ever fucked other men because it turned her boyfriend on—but this was fun!

She turned to say something over her shoulder, to whisper something naughty, only to see Kai’s attention on something off to the side. She followed his eyes and saw it herself: his phone propped on its side beneath the television, camera pointed at them in profile. Was he recording them?

The violation that she felt was swift and all-consuming. It was like waking up in her own bed to see a stranger staring down at her. She squirmed away from him, kicking him in the hip as she rolled off the bed and stalked to the phone.

“You’re *recording* this?!” She wanted to cover up, but she wanted to flip that damn thing down more than anything else.

“It’s not—”

She snatched the phone before he could issue any more denials. It was hot in her hands, the little computer working hard in its betrayal. When she

flipped it over, intending to stop the recording, she got another jolt. Brett was staring back at her, a video conference call running.

“*Hey, Babe,*” he said.

What the fuck?! She turned to Kai. “You set this up?” she accused, but realized that it wasn’t just Kai who did this. “You two set this up together?!”

Saying it felt gross. She wanted to be sick. She chose to be pissed off instead.

Brett spoke over the call. “*Hey, it’s not like you two haven’t done this before—*“

“Nope,” she cut him off. “Nope. Not like this. This is... this is...” She wanted to cry. She wanted to laugh at the absurdity. “This is too far. I just can’t.”

She ended the call. She knew she was ending the relationship. She would have done a lot of things for love. She’d *done* a lot, and enjoyed it all. No regrets. But this was different. She hadn’t chosen to do anything. She’d been manipulated, and that was too far.

“I think you may be overreacting,” Kai said.

“Maybe.” She smashed his phone on the hotel desk, feeling the glass break beneath her fingers. It felt good. “Oops.”

With that, she scooped up her clothes—glad she’d worn a dress—and stormed out.

Cooper wasn't asleep when he heard the knocking, although he was in bed. He'd been replaying the day over and over. How did it go from such a good time, to such a disappointing one.

He hadn't had this kind of crush since the eighth grade, with Amy Dexter in social studies, and that had gone nowhere. This was somehow worse, because at least in eighth grade, Amy had never actually talked to him.

If he'd never learned more about Annika than that she had a meathead boyfriend and loved to have loud sex, it wouldn't have been such a mind-fuck. She'd be the same as all the women in porn. But she wasn't just those things. She was complicated. She was real.

The knock came again. He got up and grabbed his robe. Who would be knocking this late? But of course, there was only one person in the whole city who would be.

Annika looked terrible. Where she'd been vibrant and alive when he'd left her at the bar, she looked tattered and drawn out. Her eyes were rimmed red. Some of her hair had escaped her tight braids. Even the dress, which she wore so effortlessly, looked awkward on her.

"Annika?" he said, sleep still in his voice.

She looked at him, then down at the floor, unable to hold his eyes. "I'm sorry it's late. I... I should go—"

"Wait." He reached out and touched her arm. Her skin was cooler than he expected, but beneath he felt her pulse race. "What's wrong?"

She paused, glanced at him out of the corner of her eye. "I... I broke up with Brett."

The waterworks began, and the next thing Cooper realized, he had her in his arms, holding her tightly against him as she sobbed into his chest. She was only a few inches shorter, but she felt tiny and fragile against him. He wanted to protect her. He would do anything for her, he realized.

When she stopped crying, he ushered her into his place, suddenly conscious that any of the neighbors might overhear. Inside, he asked, "Brett? He was here?"

"No. We broke up over the phone." She snorted, something halfway between a laugh and a sob.

"Want to talk about it?"

"Honestly? No. I just want a friend."

She was close. She smelled like alcohol and perfume and the clean scent he'd come to associate with Annika's apartment. He pulled her into his arms again, hugging her, being that friend.

"Thank you," she mumbled. Pulling back, she looked up at him and repeated it. "Thank you."

He could have kissed her. The urge to do so was nearly overwhelming. She would have been receptive to it, too, welcoming the comfort of a kiss like that.

But if he had, everything would have turned out differently. They may have gone out. It definitely would have been fun. Living so close to one another had its perks.

But it wouldn't have lasted. He would have been her rebound, and like most of those stories go, it wouldn't have ended in wedding bells.

None of this went through either of their heads in that moment, though. They were just two people being vulnerable to one another and choosing to

keep things platonic.

“Come on,” Cooper said at last. “Let’s get you some water.”

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PART IV

POOL PARTY

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Annika was thinking about that night almost a decade later as she made her way up to the rooftop pool for Brett and Margot's post-wedding after party.

Why had she come here at all? She'd forgiven Brett long ago—even fell back into bed with him a couple of times—but he permanently broke something between them when he pulled that stunt with Kai. Even when they got together after that, she hated him for it. Yet here she was, with the man she truly loved, celebrating her ex's nuptials.

Worse, she was heading upstairs to a pool party that would almost certainly devolve into some kind of orgy *without* that man that she truly loved.

"You should go if you're up for it," he'd said. *"I'm beat."* Only he wasn't. She knew when Cooper was tired, and when he was faking it to get

out of a hard conversation. This was the latter. She'd bet on it. Was she betting her marriage on it, though?

Cooper had been the one to bring up the wedding invitation, she realized. She'd tossed it into the recycling. She was almost certain. Yet Cooper had walked in with it a day later, suggesting that maybe they should go, that maybe they needed a vacation.

After his stunt at the reception—first leaving her alone, and then leaving all together with Ryan—she began to wonder what his real motivation was. She'd never told him about Brett's hotwife proclivities, although over the years, she'd hinted that they'd had an open relationship.

She'd also never told him how Brett had manipulated her into taking things farther. Now, here was her husband, potentially doing the same thing. It had ended badly before. She wasn't going to let that happen again.

She nearly jumped out of her skin as she walked into the women's locker room.

"You came!" It was Margot with all her enthusiasm. For a woman that Annika had never met, Margot acted like they were sisters. She was a good match for Brett, and she felt the bitter taste of jealousy admitting that, despite their stormy past.

Margot, being the new bride, wore a white bikini. Annika was a little surprised that the top was still on, but it was small enough on her impressive breasts that it was almost the same thing.

The blonde gave her a hug, pressing all of that warm skin against her own bare skin. "And I love the suit!"

"Thanks," Annika said. Her blue and white bikini felt like a nun's habit next to Margot's, but nevertheless she felt exposed in it.

"You've got a *great* body." Margot scanned her, leaving no doubt that while she'd married a man, she was open to women, too.

"Um, thanks." Annika realized she was stuttering like a record. "It's all the cycling. Cooper—my husband, that is—and I have been training for this century."

"Well, I'd say it's paying off. Where is your husband, anyway? I bet he looks good in some swim trunks."

Annika felt her claws come out. Margot seemed to sense it, too. "Relax. You don't have to worry about me. I don't steal men from other women. I only borrow, and only if all parties are willing."

She swiveled around. The white bikini was nothing more than a thong in back, her ass enhanced by the cork-heeled sandals she wore. Made Annika's flip-flops seem so boring. Everything about this woman made Annika seem boring.

"Come," Margot said. "Let's join the party!"

Annika took a deep breath. She had more jitters for this reunion than she had at her actual high school reunion. That probably had something to do with the reputation she had with this bunch... and this bunch's reputation.

But she wasn't going to run away from it. She came here for a reason, and she was committed to seeing it through. "Lead the way."

Margot looked back at her with a languid smile. "If you insist."



"SO DOES BRETT STILL LIKE..." Annika wasn't sure how to ask this.

Margot knew what she was talking about though. "Like to watch his women fuck other men? He does!"

There was a passion behind her words, the way Cooper would talk about a new bike. Clearly she didn't think it was a strange fantasy.

"Explain that to me. I still don't understand it, and he could never explain it."

"Yeah, Brett's not the best with words." Margot giggled. "Good with other things though."

"Uh huh." Annika couldn't be upset with this woman even if she had a reason to... and she didn't.

"Believe it or not, it turns Brett on when I fuck other guys because of how much he loves me. He wants to see me having a good time. Brett's a visual creature... I guess we all are, to some extent, right? He watches porn. He looks at pretty girls on the internet. For him, watching me fuck other guys is like his own, personal porn shoot."

"That's it?"

"Not just that, no. It's about... love?" She didn't seem sure that was the right word, her voice lifting at the end of the statement like a non-native speaker searching for the right word. "Brett *loved* you, Annika. Like, he

still talks about you to this day. If I were any other woman, I'd scratch your eyes out and shit."

For a moment, Annika wondered if maybe Margot would do that anyway. There was something wild and unpredictable about this woman. "Glad that you're not any other woman."

Margot snorted. "Oh, me too, honey. But yeah, he was really fucked up when you broke up with him. He gets why," she quickly added. "He made a huge mistake, pulling that shit with Kai."

"He told you about that?" She'd never told Cooper.

"Of course! I told him if he ever tried that shit with me, I'd cut off his balls. All he has to do is ask and he shall receive."

Brett was heartbroken? That was such an odd notion. She looked over at her ex, laughing boisterously as he spoke to a bunch of his groomsmen. It was like imagining Superman crying.

"It was never about Brett getting permission to play with other women," Margot went on. "A lot of chicks think that when they hear about this fantasy. It's more like... going down on you. Giving you pleasure."

"Come on," Annika said skeptically. "It's got to be more than that. I mean, what's he getting out of it?"

"You like sucking cocks, right?"

Annika's face went bright. "That's kind of personal."

Margot pursed her lips.

"Fine, yeah."

"What do you get out of it besides a blast of gooey snot?"

Annika laughed at that one. It felt good. "I guess... I like how it makes the guy feel. I like giving pleasure." Her turn to purse her lips. "Fine, I see what you mean."

"It's not a normal thing, I know," Margot went on. "But it's not all that unusual, as you can see. These guys, they like giving us pleasure. And this way, it's on their own terms, you know? It can also be a coping mechanism. Especially with guys who are more insecure. Like, if they give us permission to cheat, then it's not so bad."

That... felt interesting to Annika.

"Brett? Insecure?"

"What, you don't think he's got his own anxieties?"

"Honestly? No. We never talked much about our feelings and emotions."

“You never got to know the real man, then. He’d been hurt before you. He was hurt by you—his own fault, but still. Those things shape a person, for better or worse. I like to look at the better sides.”

She looked at Annika meaningfully, then added, “Also, I sure like fucking a variety of hot men with big dicks.”

The women giggled together. It was funny, but while Annika had just met this woman, she felt open to her. The alcohol helped. The celebratory mood of the wedding set the tone. She found herself confessing something she’d barely been able to admit to herself. “I think my husband has the fantasy, too.”

“Really? Now the plot thickens.”

“It’s not, like...” Annika suddenly felt very embarrassed—for Cooper and for herself. But she’d said it, and there was no going back. Tonight seemed like a night for action. “It feels different than with Brett. Brett just put it out there. Cooper’s more private.”

Margot nodded sagely. Funny to see so much wisdom in a woman younger than her wearing nothing but a tiny, white bikini that, now wet, looked see-through. “Look. It’s complicated. Sexuality just is, and everyone’s different, even from one relationship to the next. Tell me, Annika, is your relationship with your husband the same as it was with Brett?”

“Definitely not.”

“Did you love them both?”

She wanted to think that she didn’t love Brett. She’d spent a long time trying to convince herself that she didn’t. “I do. Or did. I see your point.”

“I think we should toast to this,” she said. “It’s not every day you learn you get to play with other cocks as foreplay, am I right?”

Annika's spot beside him was empty. Not just empty, but cool to the touch. For a second, he figured that this was a dream, an extension to an uncomfortable nightmare-fantasy that he'd had ever since he met Annika—that at last, his beautiful wife had decided to move on from him.

He lay there, staring at the ceiling, his eyes adjusting to the darkness, and realized that this wasn't a dream after all. He pinched himself. It hurt.

"Anni?" he'd called out. He knew he wasn't going to get an answer. It was 1:15 in the morning. When had he fallen asleep? When had she left? "Annika?"

No response. He crawled out of bed. He didn't feel great. His head felt fuzzy and too heavy, his mouth was dry, and his stomach fluttered with the reception drinks and whatever the hell was going on with his wife.

His wife, who wasn't in the bathroom, either. He could still smell her shampoo, though, and when he touched the tiled walls of the shower, they

were still wet. He licked his lips, chasing away the cobwebs.

“Okay,” he said to himself, out loud, working this one out. “What did you tell her before you fell asleep, idiot?”

He’d left her with that guy, then she’d come home only to catch him about to jerk off to the fact that he’d left her with that guy. They’d had sex, then he... encouraged her to go meet up with the guy again?

“You did *not* do that.” He groaned.

There was a pool party up on the roof. Not only would the guy be there—Ryan, he thought his name was—but so would Brett, her ex, and Kai, who apparently had fond memories of Annika blowing him.

“*You fucked her, didn’t you?*” The words came floating back, swirling like a maelstrom around him.

“*...really good head. Eye contact, both hands, the works.*”

“*You can always tell when a chick loves sucking dick.*”

Cooper thought about the time after her breakup with Brett. He couldn’t remember Kai ever being around. In fact, the last time he’d seen Kai was the night she’d broken up with Brett and—

“No fucking way.” He sat down on the toilet as a few things fell into place. “No *fucking* way.”

He never got the story about why she broke up with Brett. He always figured that Kai drunkenly let it slip that Brett was cheating on her in LA. It never once occurred to him that *she* had cheated on *Brett*, but it kind of made sense.

Did it? He rubbed his temples. He couldn’t think straight. Too much was whirling about him. He was growing dizzy, and was having a hard time deciding whether to vomit or start beating off. As fucked up as it was, the fact that she’d cheated was turning him on.

There was a comfort there, he rationalized. Cooper never felt secure in his relationship with Annika—even after they got married, even after all the years of life with her. This put him on the same par as a sex god like Brett. Even that guy wasn’t safe.

Or maybe he was being an idiot. Maybe she’d just gone out for a walk to clear her head. Maybe she’d gone down to the bar to catch up with old friends—old friends not at some wild, swinger pool party.

He was too much in his own head. It was going to be the end of him one of these days.

“Just go back to bed. Deal with it in the morning.” He said it out loud, as if saying it would make him actually do it. But then he glanced at the towel rack, where Annika’s bikini had been hanging. The bikini was gone.

Well, there was no chance that he’d be getting any sleep. He changed into his swimming trunks, stuffing his painfully erect cock in, then realized that he couldn’t go walking through the hotel like that. He pulled on the dress shirt he’d worn to the wedding. Untucked, it offered protection, although it also looked ridiculous.

He remembered something Annika had told him once years ago. “Is this the journey?” he asked himself. “Or the destination?”

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“To Brett and Margot, and the many fun—and sexy—adventures to come.” The toast was delivered by one of the bridesmaids, a sexy redhead named Fiona. “We all know you two won’t disappoint.”

“Here, here!” Everyone raised their shot glasses of various liquors and tossed them back. It was the second such toast Annika had shared since getting here, and she was feeling the effects.

As she watched Brett and Margot kiss, she felt things beginning to heat up between her thighs. “That’s some kiss,” said someone beside her. He wasn’t wrong, either. It was deep and full of tongue, their passion laid bare.

Annika glanced over. “Ryan,” she said. She didn’t mean to sound so excited to see him, but she was never good at hiding things when she was tipsy. “I didn’t think you were here.”

“Same.” He stole a glance into her cleavage that she didn’t really mind. “Glad you came, though.”

“I wouldn’t miss it.” She looked at the newlyweds. “I never got to give my best wishes.”

“Better hurry before one of them gets naked... unless that was the kind of best wishes you had in mind.”

She laughed. “No, the last time Brett and I were together, I told him it was the absolute last time, and I intend to keep that vow.”

“Lucky me then?” Ryan said. It was a hedging kind of joke—hopeful but could be played off as banter.

“Actually...” It was like a great big bubble of nervous energy rose through her, catching in her upper chest before popping. “I was actually hoping you could do a favor for me.”

He looked surprised that this was going somewhere. “I don’t know. We barely know one another.” Apparently he also wasn’t going to give it up so easily.

“Don’t worry, this is the kind of favor that is its own reward.”

Ryan grinned, once again checking her out. Her face burned, and he must have seen just how hard her nipples were. The bikini top was thin, and her nipples could get long.

“Pretty confident, are you?” he asked.

“Sometimes.” She stood and held out her hand. “Come on, let’s go somewhere more private and I’ll fill you in.”

Taking another man’s hand in her own—for the first time in her entire five years of marriage—felt so wrong. She felt guilty that it turned her on this much. She felt empowered that she still could hold so much sway over another man.

She felt the eyes on them as they left the pool deck, but no one judged. It wasn’t that kind of crowd. They just smiled up at them knowingly, grinning with approval. Pretty soon, this place would devolve into debauchery anyway.

She caught Margot’s eye on the way out. The blonde nodded, mischief in her dancing, blue irises.

Annika’s heart raced. She sure hoped this was what Cooper wanted.

Cooper took the elevator to the top floor, the placard next to the button indicating “pool.” One half expected the button to not work at all—like the elevator knew he was an imposter. He had this thought a lot. The other half expected that when he got up there, everyone would turn and wonder who the hell invited him.

Neither happened. The button lit up. The elevator rose. The doors opened to an empty reception desk, piled high with neatly rolled towels, ready for the next day.

At a loss, he grabbed one and wandered into the men’s locker room. It smelled like chlorine and cleaning solution, just like any other pool locker room, and just beyond, he heard the murmur of people.

Cooper was never great at these kinds of things. He could hold his own in small company, even with strangers, but a whole room was a different matter. At least his erection was gone.

He was about to push through the door when it opened towards him. A couple brushed by him—Kai, he realized, and for one jolting moment he thought it was Annika holding his hand. But the woman's hair was a darker blond than his wife's, and she was skinner. The two were giddy, the kind of hyped-up energy that preceded illicit, semi-public sex.

Not that Cooper knew what that was like. He'd just read about it.

It did help settle his nerves some. Deep breath, he finally made his debut.

The pool was amazing. Two of the sides went right up to the edge of the rooftop, the glass wall allowing for a great view of Monterey Bay, dark and infinite. It was a long pool with lounge chairs sitting atop the cedar wood decking. A bar was built into the building, just left of where Cooper emerged, and while no one was tending it, there were bottles of wine and liquor and beer set out. Judging from the state of things, plenty were partaking.

There were about twenty people up there, Cooper counted as he did a quick scan for his wife. Some were in the pool, swimming about and chatting. Most were either at the bar or at the tables that dotted the deck. At the far end was a hot tub, where two couples were making out.

Cooper's stomach tightened before he realized that neither woman was Annika. When he did realize it, while he felt mostly relieved, that wasn't the only emotion. But he wasn't *really* disappointed...

Both women were topless, and after a word from the men, the two leaned into one another and shared a deep, girl-on-girl kiss as the guys looked on.

"Pretty fucking hot, isn't it?" a guy that Cooper didn't know said, passing by him. "This place is about to explode, and that," he pointed at the hot tub, "could be the fucking match."

This guy was very drunk. "Hey," Cooper said, "I was wondering if you know if my... if a woman named Annika is here."

"Don't know her," the guy said. "What's she look like?"

"Um, blonde, little shorter than me, my age..." He looked at Cooper blankly. "Nice tits, wearing a blue-and-white bikini?"

"Oh yeah, I remember her." He looked around. "I don't know where she's at now, though. I think she left with some guy."

She left with some guy. The words echoed around Cooper, reverberating like he'd been dropped down a well—or the ever-expanding pit in his

stomach. *She left with some guy. She's fucking some guy. She's screaming, moaning, panting his name.*

"Hey, you okay?" the guy said, suddenly looking concerned. "You take some bad shit?"

"Um, no." Cooper forced a smile. A memory from long ago tickled in the back of his mind. "No, I'm good."

Of course she left with some other guy. Annika wasn't going to have sex with a stranger in public, and they *were* staying at a hotel. He was right back to 2C again, listening to a floor above as another man showed Annika just how good sex could be when a guy knew how to use his dick.

He entertained vague fantasies of going down to the front desk, of tricking the attendant into telling him which room "Ryan" was staying in.

"Hey," said a woman who'd been watching them. She was hot—red hair and a lot of eyeliner. "I think I saw them go inside." She pointed towards a set of doors behind the bar.

"When?"

"I don't know. Like twenty minutes ago or something?"

"What's back there?"

She shrugged. "Privacy?"

Right. This was probably what they called shell-shocked. He crashed around the bar, knocking empty bottles off and earning an affronted "hey man!" for it. He didn't hear them. The door was marked, "Employees Only," and for a panicked second, he thought it was locked. But then he realized he was just turning it the wrong way.

Inside stretched a long hallway with various doors off it. He shut the door behind him, and suddenly the murmur from outside, along with the heady reverberation, vanished. It was quiet enough in here that he could hear his heart beating and the ragged intake of his shallow breath.

He stood there, listening, and then he heard it.

"Uhh..." A man's groan, coming from one of those rooms. He felt numb. For a moment, he didn't think he could move. Maybe he'd imagined it. Maybe it wasn't— "*Mmm, fuck, babe...*"

No. There was no imagining it, and no dreaming it. There was no more outrunning this. The inevitable had finally arrived. His whole relationship with Annika had been on borrowed time. Always had been. Question was, what came next? But first...

He stepped quietly down the room, slowing as he reached the first of the open doors. It was empty, a storage room of some sort. The second was a kitchen. The third was much larger—the catering entrance to what was probably the party room. Wide windows overlooked the dark hills around Monterey. Tables with white linens loomed up in the dark.

There, on the far side of the room, was the guy who'd been flirting with Annika all night. On her knees before him, her blond hair damp, her blue-and-white bikini barely enough to cover her sexy body, was Annika. Annika, sucking Ryan's cock.

Cooper's world shattered.

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PART V

FRIENDS

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“So what do you think of the bike?” Cooper asked as they pulled up to their apartment.

“Love it!” Annika pulled off her helmet and shook out her hair. Sweat curled and darkened her honey-blond locks. “It’s so light.”

It had been six months since she’d broken things off with Brett, and Cooper had fallen into his role as Annika’s best friend—while falling deeply in love with her at the same time. She’d shown an interest in cycling, and he’d recently helped her get a bike. It was a thing of beauty, too, a Cannondale with a carbon fiber frame—Tiagras, but they were in good shape, and anyway, she wasn’t going to enter the Tour de France.

“It’s a nice one. I’m jealous that you get to start on something like that.”

“Oh, you should take it then,” Annika said. Crazy that she was offering him a \$2500 bike, but Cooper had come to learn that’s just the kind of person she was.

“Don’t worry,” he patted his own bike. “I’ve graduated. You enjoy it.”

They rolled the bikes into the apartment’s bike locker. Cooper couldn’t help checking out her ass in the tight bike shorts, then hated himself for being such a lech. It was easier when he didn’t know anything about her. Objectifying her now came with a healthy dose of guilt.

Still, she had a nice ass.

“Hey, you doing anything tonight?” Cooper asked. “I was thinking we could get another episode of *Stranger Things* in.”

“Just one?” Annika laughed. They were binging the show, and there was zero chance they’d only watch one.

“Well, I mean, we could start with one and see where things go.”

She laughed. How he loved hearing her laugh. “That sounds wonderful, but I promised Phoebe I’d check out this new club downtown.”

Ah, Phoebe. He’d met Annika’s friend, as outgoing as Cooper was shy. He liked her well enough, but they didn’t seem to have a whole lot in common. “Oh, sounds fun. Have fun! We can catch up with Eleven and the crew another night.”

“Hey,” she said as he started to turn away. “You should come out, too! I’ve never seen you dance.”

“For good reason,” he said. “I want you to like me.”

Heat flared up along his neck as he realized what he was saying. Annika didn’t seem to interpret it as a confession.

“Come on, it’ll be fun.” Cooper couldn’t resist her when she looked at him with those big, brown eyes. “Phoebe was actually asking about you.”

“Really?” Not that he was interested in Annika’s friend, but she was an attractive, extroverted brunette. Why would she be interested in him?

“She was, yes,” Annika said. “It’s settled. You’re going.”

“I... I don’t have anything to wear.”

“Sure you do. Just put on a pair of jeans and that shirt you wore to the Arcade Fire concert and you’ll fit right in.” She saw his hesitation and knew that she had him. “Come on, it’ll be fun.”



SIX HOURS LATER, sitting alone in the club drunk on Red Bull & Vodkas, the only thing “great” about the night was that he got to see Annika in her tight

club outfit—although her jeans were painted on and ripped in stylish spots along her leg, and her top was a skintight, black tank that could have passed for lingerie.

Actually, that wasn't the only great thing. He was drunk and being melodramatic. Like the day of the book festival, things started out pretty well. They entered the club together, just Cooper and Annika, like a couple. They'd arrived before Phoebe, so got a drink and scoped the club out.

It was large—multiple rooms, multiple floors, playing different types of club music. In the hip hop room, where Cooper felt most out of place, Annika managed to get him out onto the dance floor with her. She was a wet dream, too, the way she moved her body to the music. He'd never been to a strip club, but it must have been something like that—hips, shoulders, arms, all coiling and undulating like a sexy snake. It made him want to be better. It made him want to try.

"I know you say dancing's not your thing, but you're doing great!" She had to shout into his ear to be heard, which brought her body close to him, hot and sticky and smelling good. "Thanks for coming out with me."

"You're right!" he shouted back. "This is fun!"

It was around that time that Phoebe arrived, and things started to go downhill from there. Not that it was really Phoebe's fault. She actually liked Cooper, and was always friendly when they'd met. If anything, it was more in Cooper's head.

"There you two are!" Phoebe was a dazzling brunette who seemed to always wear tight tops and short skirts that showed off her trim body. Her tight, white top seemed plastered to her small tits, and her black skirt exposed most of her toned legs. "The fun has arrived!"

It wasn't so much that Phoebe excluded Cooper from things. Cooper excluded himself. Any courage that Annika had inspired earlier to get him out onto the dance floor was gone. He worried that Phoebe would laugh at him. He worried that later on, Phoebe would pull Annika aside, raise an eyebrow at her friend, and say, "Really?"

Not that she would have done that. Phoebe was a free spirit. She liked all types, and like Cooper, just wanted her best friend to be happy. But Cooper didn't know that.

It was exciting to watch Annika and Phoebe dance with each other. They got close, their bodies entwining, writhing, hands in the air or on each other.

At some point, two guys joined them—one African American, the other a fit-looking Asian dude. Cooper had seen them watching, commenting, working out their strategy before approaching. Phoebe glanced over her shoulder, happy to feel a man's touch—the Asian guy. The black man moved into place by Annika's side, and she smoothly turned and started dancing close.

Cooper felt a familiar twist in his gut. He'd been here before. Just last week, they'd gone out to see *Meru* in the theater, a documentary on some climbers in the mountain of the same name, and were at a bar after discussing the movie. Cooper had gone into the bathroom, and when he came back, a new guy was in his place. At first, the guy excused himself, not realizing they were together. It was Cooper who had set him straight. "*Oh, we're just friends.*"

Annika had looked at him strangely, but when the guy took that as a green light to hit on her, she was receptive to it. Just like that, Cooper had turned himself into a third wheel. It was his superpower. Later that night, he listened to them fucking, fantasizing that it was him up there.

It was happening again, and once again, he felt the confusing coils of jealousy and desire tighten around him, squeezing until he could barely breathe. He left the room, stumbled to a bar across the club, and got drunk as he huddled on a stinking sofa, wondering what the hell he was doing there.

"Hey, you okay?" It wasn't Annika, checking up on him, but another, pretty blonde with metallic makeup around her eyes and a halter top that left her midriff bare. She was talking to him?

"Yeah, I'm good."

She sat down next to him. He could feel the heat of her body. Her skin glistened with sweat from dancing. She was hot, and she was *talking* to him. "You sure? You take something bad?"

Ah. Drugs. She thought he was on drugs. Cooper almost barked a laugh at that. "No, really, just... I'm just tired. Should probably head out."

The girl bit her lip. She had white teeth. She had a nose ring that usually wasn't appealing to him, but on her, was pretty sexy. Was this happening? Was she flirting with him? He didn't know how this worked.

"Hey, I was wondering..." she began. Reaching out, she put a hand on his knee and leaned closer.

"Yeah?" His heart beat against his chest. "What's that?"

In a whisper, she said, “You have any pills? I heard there was a guy in here with a hookup.”

Cooper sighed. She thought he was a drug dealer. That was even funnier than thinking that he was on drugs. “No, unfortunately, I’m all out.” He forced a smile. Didn’t want to embarrass this girl, who quickly took her hand away and started to look around, cagily. “But hey, if you find any, let me know. I think mine’s wearing off,” he lied.

She quickly disappeared into the crowd. Time to go, Cooper thought. He knew that this was a bad idea.

Before he could get up, though, Phoebe threw herself into the spot vacated by the drug girl. “Hey, I heard you had some pills,” she said, then burst out laughing.

Cooper groaned. “You heard that?”

“That chick’s an idiot. I mean, who buys drugs in a club? The markup is probably stupid, not to mention the risk.” She leaned in close. “But if you’re interested, I’ve got some primo blow.”

This was the thing about Phoebe. He never could tell if she was fucking with him, but she seemed to know exactly what to say to put him off balance. He’d never done drugs of any kind—never even been around them. Hell, at the time, he wasn’t even really sure what kind of drug “blow” was. Did Annika? Were the two of them doing that?

The possibility shook him with the same reverberating intensity that he felt when he saw her dance with another man. He really didn’t know her that well. He’d fooled herself into thinking they were alike. Suddenly, being here at this cool club with cool people like Phoebe and drug girl made him feel ridiculous.

“I should go,” he said.

“Relax, Coop.” She turned her head to one side, her dark hair spilling around her shoulder and down over her chest. His eyes followed, drawn inevitably into her perky cleavage. She saw, but just smiled and said, “Come on, let’s go dance.”

“What happened to those guys you were with?”

“What guys?” She looked up and away. “Oh, *those* guys? They left with Anni. Bet she’s showing them a really good time right about now. You know how much she likes to please.”

Slam. Another spirit blow struck him in the gut. “She left?”

“Nah, just fucking with you. Those guys moved on a while ago. How long have you been moping around in here?” Before Cooper could answer, something clicked for Phoebe. Her eyes went wide and her face turned giddy. “You *like* her. You’re jealous!”

“No, don’t be... I’m not... she’s my friend.” His face couldn’t have been hotter. He’d felt this way back in high school, being outed for liking Kathleen Towson *in front of* Kathleen Towson, and how she’d laughed at the news.

“You are, and I *love it*,” Phoebe said. “I mean, I don’t love that you’re feeling jealous. That’s fucked up.” She had a way of speaking really fast, it was hard for Cooper to follow sometimes, especially in this loud club. “I think you’d be great for her!”

“I would? Wait, what are you talking about? We’re just—”

“Friends, right.” She rolled her eyes. “But I’m saying that you *could* be. And I’m going to try and make it happen.”

“Phoebe, please...” He thought about Kathleen Towson and that laugh. “Don’t...”

She patted his knee. “You’re so adorable. Don’t worry, Coop. I’m on your side. I’m on *both* of your sides. This is going to be fun.”

Cooper wished that people would stop using that word around him. Clearly his idea of “fun” was quite different than theirs.

Annika loved to dance. She did ballet when she was younger, and for a second there she thought she wanted to make a living of it. In college, she didn't participate in the frat scene largely because she had dance clubs to entertain her. Ballet had been fun. Getting sweaty on a dance floor as she moved her body to a driving bass was better.

Jason appreciated the way she moved her hips—so had all the guys she'd danced with that night. Jason was just the latest—a good-looking black guy who knew how to bump and grind to hip hop. She felt his eyes all over her as she swayed. She felt his cock against her thigh as she pressed close.

“Hey, baby, let's get out of here.” He had a deep voice—a strong one. One hand traveled up her ribcage, stopping just beneath her right breast. “I'd love to continue in a more private setting.”

Annika wasn't new to one-night-stands. She'd actually had quite a few since breaking up with Brett, including just last week. They could be a lot of fun, but they weren't the same as the sex had been with Brett. With the one-night-stands, she didn't have that connection. She wasn't sure if she had it with Jason.

"I... came here with a friend." A friend. She thought about dancing with Cooper, and how... nice that had been. He was a good guy with a great heart.

Not just that, but he was genuine, and made her want to be her genuine self, too. He saw her as a whole person in a way that guys like Jason didn't—hell, maybe not even the way Brett had. She'd been a hot plaything for her ex, and while that had been a lot of fun, she liked that she could just have an evening watching Netflix with Cooper, or go get drinks without expectations.

"*You like him.*" Phoebe had said it earlier, and she'd denied it in the moment, but she'd been wondering if she did for a while now. She'd been wondering what she really felt about him even before the breakup. But she also didn't want to lose the friendship that she had. She wasn't usually the one who went out and got what she wanted. She let the guys come to her.

"Why don't you go find your friend," Jason said. "Tell her you're heading out. I'll wait."

He was persistent. That could be a nice trait in guys, but they had to earn it. She'd decided that Jason hadn't.

"Sure. I'll be right back," she lied. She may have decided that she didn't want to play with this man, but she also hated to let anyone down, stranger or not.

She found Cooper and Phoebe together, at a bar on the second story loft. It overlooked a dance floor bouncing and rippling to club hits and strobe lights. Cooper was telling her good friend something, and Phoebe was laughing in that wide-mouthed, all-out way she had about her. It reminded Annika of a more innocent time, and yet she couldn't deny it—she felt jealous.

"Hey, you two," Annika said.

She wasn't actually *jealous*. Just... concerned. She loved Phoebe like a sister, but her friend had a habit of devastating guys once she was bored with them. Annika could already see the heartbreak on Cooper's face.

“Annika! We were *just* talking about you!” Phoebe smiled brightly up at her best friend, like she could read all of Annika’s confusing thoughts. “Cooper’s a really great guy!”

Annika maintained her smile, even as she had the uncharacteristic impulse to slap her best friend. She’d never felt that kind of cattiness with anyone, and definitely not her best friend. But thinking of Phoebe in bed with Cooper almost made her sick to her stomach.

“Hey,” Phoebe said. “That late night Chinese place still open?”

Annika felt her mood lift. She always thought it was funny how much Phoebe ate for a girl her size. “Yeah, still open.”

“Let’s go! I’m fucking done with all the shouting.”

Annika only had to give it a moment’s thought—a moment that included Jason waiting for her. She glanced at Cooper, and all at once she didn’t want to be anywhere else. “You going?”

Apparently he couldn’t hear a thing that they’d said. He put a hand to his ear and leaned in. “Hm?”

“Do you want to go get some greasy food with me and Phoebe?”

“Oh. Sounds... fun.” He seemed to laugh at something, and all of a sudden Annika felt self-conscious.

“I mean, we could go home, too,” she said.

“No, no.” He spoke quickly. He wasn’t laughing at her. “There’s nowhere that I’d rather go than to get greasy food.”

Annika beamed. She realized in that moment that there was nowhere that she’d rather be, either.

Phoebe watched the whole exchange, and couldn’t stop smiling to herself.



“SO YOU TWO have been friends since high school?” Cooper asked. They were seated at a table along the back of the restaurant, which was still full for two in the morning.

It had been a long time since Annika had been out so late. She’d forgotten how much she liked the feeling—warm on alcohol and friendly company. There was electricity in the air. Everything late night felt more vibrant than it did in the day.

Phoebe answered Cooper's question. "Since middle school, actually." She was sitting across from them in the one chair.

Annika and Cooper were side by side on the bench, the now-familiar scent that she'd come to associate with Cooper adding to the electrical mood. He didn't wear cologne. Not like Brett when he went out. Not like most guys she was with. She liked that about him. She liked so many things about him.

"She was always the bad influence," Annika added.

"Oh, please," Phoebe said. "You should thank me. Without me, you probably would have been a cheerleader and dated some dumb jock. Like Brett." Phoebe had never liked Brett—despite fucking him—and when she found out what he'd done, told her that she wasn't surprised.

Annika's retort was easy. She said, "If I remember correctly, pretty sure it was you who fucked the quarterback... and the wide receiver? And who else?"

"Shut up, bitch," Phoebe said with a laugh. "And it was the running back, Lance Johnson, not the wide receiver."

Annika snorted. She remembered Cooper was there, listening to this, and suddenly felt embarrassed. "I apologize for my friend here," she said.

"Although you are having fun," Phoebe pointed out. She was right, Annika thought. She was. "What about you, Cooper? Having fun?"

Cooper found his voice. "Yeah, I am. It's... it's been a long time since I've been out so late. There are so many people still up."

"We need to get you out more," Phoebe said. She paused, locked eyes with him, and added, "Or get you a girlfriend."

"Phoebe!" Annika was upset for him.

"It shouldn't be hard," Phoebe went on. "Cooper's a good-looking guy. He's smart, he's willing to put up with the two of us. He's got a steady job."

Cooper looked like he wanted to crawl under the table. He was shaking his head, willing Phoebe to stop. Her phone chimed, and she pulled it out, checking it. "Well, that's my ride."

"What?" Annika and Cooper asked together.

"Oh, sorry, kids, guess I forgot to mention it. Booty call... calling? Whatever. I'll call you next time I'm in San Diego, Anni. Have fun, you two."

She got up from her seat, tossing some cash down to pay for her part of the meal. "Oh, and for the record? I think Anni would have looked hot in a

cheer uniform. Even back then, she had the skinny hips-big boobs thing going on.”

“Phoebe...”

“By-ee!”

“Well, that was...” Annika began.

“Yeah...” Cooper scratched the back of his neck. “She always like that?”

“Pretty much.”

He was watching Phoebe go. “She seems fun.”

Annika tried to interpret that. She’d never thought about Cooper in that way—like a hot-blooded male with urges of his own. Not until tonight, anyway. At least not consciously. Now she felt the hackles on the back of her neck rise as he watched her friend strut out.

He turned to her. “Seems like the kind of friend who’s hard to have, sometimes.”

“Yeah, for sure.” His observation resonated with her, like two notes sung in perfect harmony. “Kind of unpredictable.”

“So how are you doing?” he asked after a quiet moment.

“Hm?”

“I mean, after Brett. You doing okay?”

Annika had been staring at her glass of water. When she turned to look at him, she saw the well of sincerity in his deep, brown eyes. She saw him the way Phoebe had been trying to make her see him. He was a good-looking guy. He was smart, and kind, and funny in his own way. Most of all, he saw all of her, too.

The electrical buzz of the late night was all around them now. It filled her ears. It skipped along her skin.

“I’m doing just fine,” she said. And then, before she could talk herself out of it, she leaned in and kissed him.

Cooper tensed up as her lips met his. His breath caught. His eyes went wide for the briefest of moments as his brain tried to make sense of what was happening. But it wasn’t a dream, and Annika’s lips were real—moist and soft, and when she pushed her tongue into her mouth, he could taste the late night Chinese food.

It wasn’t the kind of kiss she would have shared with Jason, had he gotten her back to his place. It wasn’t the voracious kiss of a one-night-

stand. It was so much better. The kind of kiss you could get lost in. The kind of kiss that both of them *wanted* to get lost in.

“That was...” Cooper couldn’t find his bearings, once she’d pulled back.

“I’m sorry.” Annika’s face lit up red. “I shouldn’t have—”

And Cooper did something he never thought he’d had the guts to do. He silenced her apology with a kiss of his own. As he did so, as his lips touched hers and he closed his eyes, he could feel her mouth form a smile. Everything about the moment felt so right.

“Want to get out of here?” Annika asked once they came up for air. “This is beginning to feel a bit public.”

Cooper looked around. They were still in the restaurant, and everyone else in there was buzzed on something and not giving them a second glance, but even so, Cooper felt self-conscious. “Good idea.”

On their way out, Annika slipped a hand into Cooper’s. He was surprised to find it just as clammy as his own. Were they really doing this?

“So,” Annika said, looking at him. “More fun than watching *Stranger Things*?”

“Jury’s still out.” It was the alcohol doing the talking. Or maybe it was Annika. She had this effect on him, making him feel bolder than he really was. It was that boldness that got him to add, “I’ll let you know in the morning.”

By the time Cooper walked into Annika's apartment, all of his insecurities were catching up with him. The momentum of their earlier kiss was on a slow, gradual downward curve heading back to earth.

The men Annika usually brought back here were usually ideal specimens of the male body. There seemed to be three prerequisites that Annika looked for in men—tall, muscular, and confident.

Cooper didn't fully tick any of those boxes. He wasn't short, but being 5'10", when Annika herself was just an inch shorter, was decidedly average. He worked out, but his physique was more lean than broad.

And then there was the confidence thing. The only thing Cooper was really confident of was that most of the guys probably didn't float along behind Annika like a tethered balloon with just enough helium to stay aloft.

Most would have taken charge, pulled her into his arms, and kissed her as soon as they were inside of the door.

Instead, she held him spellbound as she tossed her keys on a small table beside the door and kicked off her shoes. She wore a stylish, white belt atop her skin-tight jeans, which sat low enough on her hips that when she bent over, her g-string peeked out. It wasn't intentional, the way some women showed it off, but once Cooper saw it, he couldn't take his eyes off of it. He'd never known a woman who wore something like that—black, wispy, impractical.

It occurred to him that he might see more, and when that *did* occur to him, he realized just how out of his depth he was. Was this really happening? How the hell was this happening?

Standing frozen just inside her front door, Cooper asked, “Hey, do you want any water?”

Annika knew Cooper was nervous. Truthfully, she was, too. He wasn't just some hot guy to warm her bed that night. She *liked* him. She didn't deserve him?

She took his hand in his, smiling, pushing down those doubts and insecurities. “Come on, we can get water later.” She tugged him towards the bedroom, and Cooper followed.

Annika wasn't used to taking charge in the bedroom, and because of that, everything with Cooper felt new—when she kissed him at the foot of the bed; when she stepped back and peeled her cami top off; watching him take her in as she opened her jeans and shimmied out of them.

“You're so beautiful,” he whispered, as if it was a comment to himself, a shared thought. It was so sincere that it made her blush.

“Thanks.” She moved up close to him, running her hands over his shoulders. She began to work open the top buttons of his shirt, looking him in the eye. “You're not so bad yourself.”

Cooper let instinct take over. He let his hands wander the wealth of her body, marveling at how soft her skin was, how warm, how real this all was. They kissed as he traced her g-string with his thumbs. They kissed as she opened his shirt and touched his bare chest for the first time. They kissed and explored one another until he was down to just his boxers, and she in her black lingerie.

“Come on,” she whispered, pulling him into her bed. She crawled over him, rubbing his cock against her panty-clad pussy. They shuddered.

“You’re hard.”

“I’m sorry.”

She giggled. “Why? We’d have a problem if you weren’t.” She bent over him, and they kissed again. This time, his hand found her bra and twisted it open.

Annika pulled back, her honey blond hair spilling around them. “Very smooth,” she said with a smile.

He resisted the urge to say “sorry” again. Instead, he just smiled. “You bring it out in me.”

“Let’s see what else we can bring out.” She sat up again, and he got a glimpse of her bare breasts for the first time in his life. They were perfect on her, full and ripe and round.

Raising up on her knees, she reached between them and dragged his boxers down. His cock sprang free, embarrassingly leaking pre-come. Annika rubbed the slippery stuff along the head of his shaft. Even her touch felt expert. He almost came so prematurely. It was all too much.

“Definitely not something to apologize about.” She squeezed him, and again, he nearly came.

Sensing that, Annika slithered down his thighs. Her eyes never left his as she ran his cock along the warmth of her naked body. Her stomach was soft, her tits even softer as his shaft slid in and out of her cleavage, and then her mouth was on him.

He didn’t last long. She wrapped her lips around the tip and swirled him with her tongue. He’d known pleasure before, but the things she did with her tongue redefined all of it. It wasn’t just the sensations, either, but the way she seemed to read him with those glittering, gray-green eyes.

“Ha!” he gasped. “I’m—oh!” Before he could hold back or give more of a warning, he was filling her mouth. When he tried to pull away, though, she held him close and swallowed everything he pumped into her.

Cooper flopped back onto the mattress, his breathing hard and heavy. His abs ached like he’d done a hundred crunches. His skin was damp with sweat.

Annika bit her lower lip as she watched the last of Cooper’s orgasm play out. She’d done that. She’d given him the pleasure, and that felt good.

Sliding up beside him, she kissed his naked body. She kissed his chest, and the light curls of hair that gathered between his pecs.

“Sorry,” he announced to the ceiling.

“You keep saying that. What are we apologizing for now?”

“For... not lasting.”

“I don’t mind.” She laid her head on his shoulder and her hand against his chest. She could feel the rapid thump of his heartbeat. “This is nice.”

“Yeah.” Cooper still couldn’t believe that he was here. He looked around. This was the room where he’d heard her moans. This was where he’d heard other men fuck her until she screamed their names. He was starting to stiffen up, just remembering.

And here she was, with him, telling him that it was nice. Cooper wasn’t the cockiest, most confident of guys, but he knew when not to squander a golden opportunity.

He shifted out from under her, rolling her gently onto her back. “My turn,” he said before kissing her. He could taste himself, mixed with her saliva, and if anything, it made him more excited. “Am I dreaming?”

Annika giggled. “No, silly. I am.”

“Then close your eyes and I’ll keep the dream going.” He kissed down her body, stopping to suck and swirl her nipples. They were pale pink, standing out thick and hard, with large, perfectly round aureola.

She moaned loudly as he worked them, her fingers raking through his hair. He lingered there, teasing her and denying himself his ultimate destination. His right hand, however, wouldn’t be denied. It drifted down her flat stomach and out her hip, tracing the g-string again.

“You like my panties,” she said playfully.

“They’re very sexy.”

“Definitely.” She giggled. She found herself giggling a lot with Cooper. That giggle was cut short as he moved his hand into her panties and touched her very wet pussy. “Ngh!”

Encouraged, Cooper moved lower, down beneath the sheets and between her legs. He could smell her excitement, and could see how her black panties stuck to her mound. He kissed her, right over her clit. Now it was her turn to shiver.

He took hold of her g-string and pulled them down her hips. She lifted her legs up, knees together, over his head, as he whisked them off. Cooper held his breath as she settled back down, legs spread, her compact, little pussy ready for him.

Annika arched her back, shoulders digging into the pillow, tits high, as Cooper ran his tongue along her sex. She was so smooth down there, her

pussy shaved clean other than a narrow landing strip. He'd never been with a woman who did that. Everything was so exposed to him. Everything was so ripe.

"Oh, my... ngh!" Annika twisted and moaned. "Oh, Coop, that's... so... so..."

Cooper's tongue fluttered and whirled across her clit, playing her body with the same skill that she'd sucked him. He didn't have a ton of experience with girls, but his previous girlfriends had all loved it when he went down on them.

"Make me come, Coop! Eat me until I come!" His tongue had begun to ache, but her words spurred him only faster. He pressed a finger into her, curling it up, seeking out her g-spot. He knew he found it when she bucked. "Yes! Right there!"

He was doing it. He was the man in the room. He was making her scream.

She clamped her thighs around him, smothering her face as she hit her climax hard. The only other person who made her feel this good was Phoebe, and that was a memory she still felt confused about. This orgasm, this man and the things he was doing to her were pure and raw and powerful.

She was a sweaty mess when she came down from her climax. Her body tingled and trembled as he crawled back up. His little kisses along her skin were almost too much, and yet she wanted more. So much more.

She grabbed his head and pulled him in for a searing kiss. "God, I want to just... bite you," she said with a laugh. "That was amazing."

Cooper's turn to blush. "You're welcome."

She grabbed his dick, which was now hard again. "Ready to fuck me?"

The question was unreal. He could barely find his voice. "Yes," he croaked.

She turned away from him, reaching into her nightstand drawer for a condom. He caught a glimpse in there, over her shoulder. She had a couple of boxes—one box of Magnums, another Standard. When she grabbed a packet from the latter, the shame was real, but he didn't dwell. He was about to fuck his hot neighbor.

She tore the foil open with practiced ease, rolling it onto his cock before mounting him. He sank into her many, soft pillows as she guided his cock into her. Their eyes met just as he sank home.

“Oh, Coop,” Annika gasped. “That feels so...”

“Good,” he finished for her.

Her smile was there, lighting up his world, and his was reflected right back at her. “Told you that you’d have fun tonight.”

She started to roll her hips, undulating along his length. “Next time, we could go ahead and skip the club.”

She looked faux offended. “Oh, please. It wasn’t that bad.”

“You’re right. I did like watching you dance.”

She bent over and kissed him. “Sometimes, the journey can be just as fun as the destination.”

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Waking up beside Annika was just as magical as falling asleep beside her. She was facing him, her eyes closed and her breathing slow and steady. A strand of blond hair fell across the bridge of her nose. The rest was a tangled mess on the pillow. She made even bedhead look alluring.

She slowly woke, blinking at the sunlight that pooled into the room. Cooper braced for her to realize her mistake—to realize that she hadn't gone home with that stud from the club, but with her quiet neighbor.

Instead, a sleepy smile spread across her face, like the dawn breaking on the horizon. He felt her warmth. "So it wasn't a dream," she said, sleep still clinging to her voice.

He reached out and touched her cheek. It was hot and smooth and real. "Kind of feels like one," he said cheesily.

It only made her smile wider. "You need to stop beating yourself up."

“Maybe.” The way she looked at him was disarming. She was listening to understand, not just to make conversation. “But you’re still, like, way out of my league.”

“Why do guys always do that?”

“Do what?”

“What does that even mean, anyway? ‘Out of your league’?”

“Like... baseball. You’re the star of the Dodgers, and I’m warming the bench in AA.”

“Right, no, I get the metaphor.” She propped her head up onto her elbow, and her bedsheet just barely covered her tits. It was distracting, but Cooper managed to focus on her. “But you know it’s bullshit, right? There are no leagues. I don’t date guys because they check off a certain set of attributes or whatever.”

And yet most of the guys you bring back here all seem to be gym-hewn Adonises, he thought. He wasn’t going to say that, but he couldn’t let it go. “I don’t know. You do seem to have a type.”

Her eyes shifted back and forth as she scanned her memory. “Okay, I can see how you got there,” she acknowledged. “But I swear, that’s more about the guys who approach me, not by choice.”

“Because guys like me are intimidated,” he said.

“Seems like a ‘you’ problem, not a ‘me’ problem,” she said.

“When we see that beautiful women usually favor a certain type of guy... it only reinforces our assumptions.”

“This is what I like about you,” she smiled. “You’re honest. You know how rare that is? Anyway, I understand where you’re coming from. But believe me, I don’t have a type. It’s just that most guys who approach me look...” She bit her lip, realizing how she was coming off.

“Hot? Jacked?” Cooper helped her out.

“Stop,” she said with a laugh.

“You intimidate all the others because you’re—”

“No sports metaphors please.”

“—you’re you. You’re amazing and beautiful and smart.”

“And yet you haven’t lost your ability to form words around me,” she pointed out. She scooted closer to him, the bedsheet finally pulling away from her nipples. “Or do other things.”

“Temporary bout of insanity,” he said.

“Well, I hope you stay insane, then, because you just got called up to the big leagues.” They stared at one another for a beat before they both burst out laughing. “That was pretty bad, wasn’t it?”

Cooper swept her into his arms and kissed her. “It’s okay, I think I can cut you some slack.”

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PART VI

SORRIES

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Cooper stood just outside of the catering doorway, rooted to the spot, paralyzed as he watched the love of his life service another man from her knees.

The guy—Ryan, he vaguely remembered—was older than the two of them. He wore his pale blue linen shirt open, his swimming trunks pooled around his ankles. He stood proud and upright, holding Annika’s head in his hands as he guided it up and down his length.

“That’s it...” He groaned. “Suck my cock, Baby. Oh, yeah...”

Now that he was closer, Cooper could hear her sloppy blowjob, and how Ryan was using her. She slurped and glugged each time he pulled her face against him, his cock lodged deep in her throat.

Cooper should have stormed in there. He should have thrown a fit. He should have shouted, “*What the fuck?!*” and flipped a table. All of that

would have been excusable for a man in his position. Instead, he stood there and watched as his cock turned to steel in his swimming trunks.

“That’s pretty sexy, isn’t it?” A woman’s voice, right in his ear. She was right behind him, her warm body pressed to his, her hands reaching around to grab his crotch. “You thought she was me, didn’t you?”

“Annika?” He was thoroughly confused. The woman he’d thought was Annika pulled away from Ryan’s hands, long enough to turn and look back at him. He gasped.

“It’s actually Margot,” the woman behind him whispered. “The question is, do you wish that it was me?”

Margot, from her knees across the room, flashed a mischievous grin at him. He turned, glancing back at his wife just over his shoulder. Just like when she caught him about to jerk off, she looked more curious than upset.

“It’s still not too late,” Margot said, her husky voice even sexier from all the dick sucking. Cooper’s cock jumped in Annika’s hand. She raised her eyebrows, as if to say, *What do we think about that?*

Cooper’s insecurities pressed in around him. Was that what she wanted? She’d flirted with Ryan earlier. She’d come up here to meet him. If Cooper hadn’t followed, just how long would it have taken for Annika to join Margot on her knees?

“Come join me,” Margot persisted. “Cooper won’t mind, will you Cooper?”

Annika studied him, staring at him like this was a game of chicken. She didn’t give away what *she* wanted to do. She dared him to go first.

Did he mind? Is this what he really wanted? Or had he just convinced himself of that out of some kind of self-defense mechanism.

“I’m sure that you would like that,” Margot said to Ryan, somewhere behind them. He heard her shift, heard the wet slop of their kiss. “Nothing quite like a pretty blonde who has the hots for you, am I right?”

Annika was the pretty blonde, and she had the hots for Ryan. It was obvious enough to Margot, and she hadn’t been watching Annika and Ryan flirt the way that he had. Given enough time, it would have happened. Cooper knew it. He was bothered by it. But he was also so fucking turned on.

“I’d... like it, too,” he croaked.

Still, all Annika could do was stare. Her face showed neither disappointment nor excitement. It was like he’d admitted to liking a band

that she'd never heard of. The tension, though, felt thick and uncomfortable. Cooper couldn't take it. He turned fully to her, put his arms around her body, and pulled her in for a kiss.

For a second, he didn't think she'd let him. She pulled away, just enough to study him one last time, then closed her mouth around his. The tension didn't break, but added to the charge of the room. Their kiss was deep and unbridled, the kind of kiss that was rare after so many years together. Something had gotten into Annika, and he was pretty sure that something was on the other side of the room with his dick out.

Cooper wasn't ready to let her go, though. He kissed her like he wanted her to remember him. He groped her body, realizing that she was wearing a bikini that he didn't recognize. It was a small thing, smaller than any he'd seen her wear—nothing more than strings across her back and behind her neck, accompanied by big, loopy bows that just begged to be pulled. The bottoms were even sexier, a thong that plunged between Annika's heart-shaped cheeks.

He grabbed those cheeks, squeezing them as he rode his hard emotions through the kiss.

The moment's fraught and fatalistic energy was broken by the only person who could. "I thought I'd find you here," announced Brett as he swept into the room. "Mind if I join? This looks fun."

"Brett..." Margot didn't sound pleased at the interruption. She knew, like everyone else in the room except her new husband, just how delicate the situation was. His brazen entrance smashed it as surely as a hammer on glass.

"Of course," Annika said to him. Cooper had just enough time to gasp before she took his hand into his. "Have fun!"

And with that, she pulled him from the room.

Annika's heart was a riot in her chest as she escaped the room, pulling Cooper down the long corridor that led outside. She felt like she was running from a burning building. She was certainly hot enough for it.

They spilled out into the late-night air. The space behind the bar was empty now, mostly empty bottles of liquor and mixers cluttering the long surface. To Cooper, little had changed out here. It was disorienting how little time had passed since he'd walked through the Employee's Only door.

Annika's experience was different. She'd entered the back when this after-party was still just a party. Now, as she surveyed the rooftop pool, she saw the beginnings of an orgy. Couples were making out everywhere. Two women were kissing each other in the hot tub as their men pawed at their breasts. A man was actually getting a blowjob on the lounge chair just to their left.

“Hey, you found her,” a redhead said to Cooper, coming around the bar. Annika recognized her from earlier—one of the bridesmaids, only now she was topless, her fake tits attracting too much of Cooper’s attention for Annika’s comfort. She said, “I’m surprised you’re out so soon.”

The woman grabbed a bottle of tequila that wasn’t completely drained and poured herself a shot. She gave Annika a long up-and-down before tipping the shot back and slamming it upside down on the bar. “You look good in white.”

Annika resisted the urge to cover herself. When she’d switched bikinis with Margot, she’d only been thinking of the newlywed putting her blue-and-white one on to trick Cooper—not what it would feel to wear Margot’s tiny suit.

The other woman stepped up to Annika, holding her eyes even as she addressed Cooper. “I don’t blame you for looking for her,” she said. Annika could smell the tequila on her. “I wouldn’t let her out of my sight, either. Bet she could get up to all kinds of trouble.”

A wave of vertigo gripped Annika, like she was suddenly falling end-over-end, and couldn’t right herself. She squeezed Cooper’s hand. “Come on. We’re leaving.”

This place was trouble. This whole damn scene was too wild for her. The couples in the hot tub had rearranged themselves. One of the women was now perched on the edge as the other ate her out, and as she did, one of the guys fucked her doggy style. It was all just *too much*.

Annika dragged them through the locker rooms, not daring to look at the rest of the pool deck. Someone was taking a shower in there—two someones, based on the moans that filtered over the hiss of the water. Out into the empty front desk they went. Out to the elevators.

“Give me your shirt,” she said as they waited for the elevator to arrive. “I feel naked.”

Cooper looked her over, face drunk with lust. “You look great.”

“Your shirt.”

“Right.” He looked ridiculous in the dress shirt anyway. He pulled it off and handed it to her, his erection jutting a tent in his swimming trunks. His excitement, along with the way he kept looking at her, triggered something in her.

“Did you come up here to check up on me?” she accused. “Or to spy on me?”

His silly grin faded. “What?”

“Why are we here, Coop?”

“Uh, to celebrate Brett and Margot’s wedding—”

“But why? I swear to God that I threw away the invitation.” She had. She remembered the square envelope. Brett and Margot’s name on it. She remembered thinking, “*Oh, hell no,*” and tossing it into the bin.

“I don’t think so. I saw it mixed in with the other mail.” He wouldn’t meet her eyes. He was lying. “Where is this damn elevator?”

The doors opened. He stepped in swiftly, but Annika was slower to follow. She knew that he was lying, and she was processing exactly why he was. He’d wanted her to come to this wedding. He’d left her alone at the reception. She could still feel how hard he was when he thought that she was blowing Ryan. He wanted her to cheat. It turned him on.

“You coming?”

Annika blinked, seeing Cooper holding the elevator door and looking at her. His face brightened a touch. He said, “Or do you want to stay?”

She knew that tone—the I’m-mostly-joking-but-not-really thing he did when he wanted something but wasn’t sure that she wanted it, too. It’s how he’d asked her out on their first, real date. It’s how he’d proposed to her. Usually, she loved Cooper’s cautious optimism. Tonight, though, it rubbed at her.

“If I did, would you stay? Or would you pretend to go back to your room so you could spy on me?” That was definitely not the kind of thing that was typically Annika, but it was late and she was drunk and tired and turned on and confused.

Cooper looked wounded, but he also understood where she was coming from. “I’m sorry.” He held out his hand. “Come on, let’s get back to the room before this thing starts to close on us.”

Things were no less tense back in their hotel room, though. This wasn’t a scene wipe. This wasn’t even a reset. Annika still wore Margot’s crazy bikini. Cooper pulled on a t-shirt. They sat on the bed, side-by-side, but feeling miles apart.

“Tell me what’s going on, Coop,” Annika said at last.

“I... I don’t know.” Again, it was a lie. Annika didn’t call him on it, though. She remained quiet, letting him work through it. She knew he’d get there eventually. “It’s just... when we’re at a place like this, with all these fun, confident people, I worry that...” He trailed off. “I don’t know.”

“You worry that what?” She turned to him, taking her hand. They’d had this conversation before, early in their relationship. He felt that he didn’t deserve her, whatever that meant, and no matter how much she told him that she loved him, he always held that insecurity.

“That someone like Ryan would come along, I guess.”

“I’m sorry. I shouldn’t have spoken to him so much at the reception.”

“You looked like you were having fun.” Cooper looked shy, his gaze sliding away from hers.

She ducked back into that gaze, lifting her brows to hold it. “Sweetheart, just because I was having fun doesn’t mean I’d sleep with him. I’m married to you. I love you.”

There was something else, something that sat heavy on his mind, but she couldn’t suss it out. But then, the answer was right there in front of her, right? He was like Brett. It was his fantasy for her to sleep with other men. Unlike Brett, he always struggled with admitting those repressed fantasies. She could help with that.

She climbed into his lap, straddling his legs. “You were pretty hard, watching them,” she said.

Cooper blushed, looking away.

“It’s okay, honey.” She brushed his hair over his forehead and cupped his face. “It turned me on, too.”

He dared to look up at her, hope swelling through him. “It did?”

“I wasn’t going to do anything with him, but Ryan is good-looking.” She felt his cock growing between them. “He used to have a thing with Margot, and she couldn’t stop gushing about how good his cock felt.”

That was true. As they hatched their plan to swap places, Margot teased her with stories of her experiences with the older man. *‘His cock is nice and thick, but not too long, you know? And fuck, does he know how to use it... Maybe, if this works out, you could try him yourself. He’d make a fine bull for you and your husband.’*

She’d filled Annika in about what a “bull” was—a man who had sex with a willing couple—and told her all about the benefits of being a “hotwife”—a married woman who had sex with other men with the husband’s knowledge.

‘It’s a fantastic lifestyle. I’m so excited for you!’ the blonde had practically squealed. Annika wasn’t so sure, but when she’d said as much,

Margot had an answer. *‘I know you’re game for it. Brett told me all about it. We just need to find out if your husband is, too.’*

That was the thing, though. She wasn’t sure that she was game for it. She’d done it so many years ago for Brett, not for her, just like she took up cycling for Cooper.

But now she did bike on her own, didn’t she? And she loved the freedom of the hard road beneath her wheels...

Once again, Cooper snapped her out of her thoughts. “A part of you was tempted?”

Was it? Not really. Not seriously. But maybe a small part. Enough that she could look Cooper in the eyes and say, truthfully, “Yeah. I guess I was.”

Now it was her turn to want to look away. She didn’t, though. Instead, she leaned in and masked her embarrassment with a kiss.

This kiss turned into more. They’d already had sex earlier, but that felt like a lifetime ago. It wasn’t lost on either of them how excited the other was, or that this was the first time in years that they did it twice in one day. It wasn’t lost on Annika how Cooper’s cock pulsed each time she whispered something about Ryan, or how, when he finally came inside of her, his eyes were closed and his thoughts were far away.

As she fell asleep in his arms, satisfied yet still unsettled, she wondered if she could actually do it. Could she actually be a hotwife? It had been fun with Brett, until it wasn’t. Maybe it would be different with Cooper. Maybe she *should* do this for him...

Cooper was used to waking up in strange places. Working for an NGO—even now, as a VP—required him to be on the road more than he would have liked. But waking up with the California sun filling his hotel room was particularly disorienting. He'd been dreaming about Annika going off with another man, but that man's identity was already lost to the sunlight.

He turned to her spot in the hotel bed, and once again his heart skipped when he saw it empty. This time, the mystery was solved by the sound of the shower and her soft humming.

He felt relief, but he also felt mild disappointment. He pushed that away, refusing to acknowledge those facts, and dragged himself out of bed. It was nearly ten o'clock. He hadn't slept that late in years.

He was naked, of course, and the air conditioning in the Cormorant was, typical to hotels, too high. He crossed the room, dick bobbing between his

legs, thinking of how warm the water would feel, and how long it had been since he'd showered with Annika.

"Ugh!" Annika groaned as he barged into the steamy room. He froze. What he'd thought was Annika singing was actually something else completely. "Uhhh..."

"Annika?" He peered through the thick steam. He saw her jump, reflexively covering herself on the other side of the fogged up glass.

"Cooper?"

Who else could it be? "Expecting someone else?"

"No, I..."

He slid the shower door open and stepped in to join her. "Don't let me interrupt."

Annika seemed to recover, looking up at him with a shy, yet playful, expression. "Maybe you could help—*out!*" She gasped as Cooper took her into his arms. "Jesus, you're freezing!"

"So warm me up."

Annika snorted and pushed him away. "You stand over there. You like watching anyway."

The reference to last night did more to warm him up than the shower. He laughed nervously, but she wasn't wrong. Particularly when she squeezed a dollop of shaving cream into her palm and began to shave her legs.

"You're right, this is a good spot," he said.

Annika flashed him a wide smile. "Last night was fun."

It was hypnotic, watching her sweep the razor up the muscled contours of her right leg. She had it propped up on the soap dish, her bare pussy teasing him. She thought last night was fun. What did that even mean? It was like he was too hungover to unpack it, so he just grunted in response.

She glanced up at that, issuing a sharp laugh. He thought that maybe she'd tease him a bit more, or begin the serious discussion that he knew was coming eventually. Instead, she said, "You know, Ryan said I should shave my landing strip."

Cooper's mouth fell open. "How did that topic come up?"

Finished with her right leg, she foamed up her palm again, and for a moment, Cooper thought that she might actually do it. Instead, she switched to her left leg.

“You know, I can’t remember.” She spread the white foam along her skin. “He wanted me to do all kinds of things.” Glancing up at him, she added, “He was really forward.”

“Clearly.” Cooper licked his lips. “Like... like what other things?”

She took her time answering that one. “Things no married woman should do with a strange man.”

He was hard. So very hard. He also felt bad. Like this was some elaborate joke at his expense. It wasn’t. Annika wasn’t the type to do that. She didn’t have a cruel bone in her, and Cooper knew it, but it didn’t help.

She was so beautiful, so out of his league. And here she was, naked in the shower with him, her full tits and hard nipples and neatly groomed pussy all for him, and he was—

“Hey,” Annika said, seeing the humiliation as it spiraled through him. “Hey, Coop...” She set the razor down and closed the space between them. “I’m sorry, I shouldn’t have—”

“No.” He dragged his eyes to hers. “No, don’t apologize. It’s... it’s me.”

“Well, then maybe it’s us,” she offered. He liked the sound of that, and he liked the way she said it. There was weight behind it. “I love *you*, Coop. I love you so much. You never, *ever* have to worry about me and anyone, okay?”

“But what if I kind of like being worried?” He mumbled it, so quietly that he wasn’t sure that he’d actually said it aloud—and kind of hoped that he hadn’t.

But he had.

“I know,” Annika whispered, her admission seemingly just as reluctant. “Last night left little doubt.”

“I’m sorry,” he said.

To Cooper’s surprise, Annika started laughing, and for one horrifying moment, he thought that she was laughing at him. His dick shrank. He wanted to crawl into a hole.

“Look at the two of us,” she said once she got her laughter under control. “It’s like we’re too polite for an honest conversation.”

“How’s that?”

“It’s like every other word we say is ‘sorry’.”

“Sorry,” Cooper said instinctually. They both cracked up this time. “It is a nice word, isn’t it?”

“Maybe a little disingenuous?”

“I really am sorry. I don’t know what’s wrong with me. I should be totally satisfied with just you. I mean, I *am* totally satisfied,” he quickly added when he heard how that sounded. He caressed her breast, squeezing and lifting the heavy tit. “Yet here I am, fantasizing about you with other guys.”

He winced and waited for her to freak out. Instead, she asked him the one question he wasn’t sure how to answer. “Why does it turn you on?”

Because before I even knew you, I’d listen to how loud you came when you got fucked hard? “I don’t know.”

“I think I do,” Annika said.

Fear exploded through him. He’d never told her about his voyeurism. He always worried how perverted that sounded. “You do?”

She slinked back in the shower, resting on a small, tiled bench. “Margot helped me understand.”

Margot knew about this? Oh, God...

“It’s more about giving than receiving.” She spread open her long legs, the gesture unusually lewd for Annika. “She said it was like oral sex. Is that it, Cooper?”

“I...” Not exactly, but maybe kind of? He was distracted even more as his wife picked up the shaving gel again and coated her mound—her entire mound.

“Making me happy makes you happy, right?” She picked up her razor. “I like making you happy, too, Baby.” She ran the razor right through the center of the white foam, decimating her landing strip. “Even if ‘making you happy’ sometimes involves preparing myself for another man.”

“Uhn!” His dick was pulsing before he realized he was even stroking it. His come arced between them, catching Annika across the tits. He groaned. The shame was real. “Oh, God...”

And yet he couldn’t stop. The sight of her bare shaven snatch and what it signified kept him pumping all over her juddering swells. Annika was masturbating, too, the razor cast aside, her fingers working her newly hairless mound.

Cooper went to his knees, pushing her hand to the side. She tasted like Gillette shaving gel and soap and her own excitement. He tongued her gash, which was always smooth, and then higher, where her womanly curls used to be. He’d never thought that he wanted her to do this until now—seeing it, feeling it, tasting it.

“That’s so hot,” he groaned. He ran his thumb over the bald skin. She shuddered as he brushed her clit.

“Feels...” Annika’s voice was taut, like rope tightened until it creaked. “...so good... yes, Coop... eat me...”

“Don’t think of me.” He pressed his two fingers deep. He may not have fucked her the way guys like Brett fucked her, but he knew exactly how she liked her pussy licked. He found just the right angle, he pressed with his tongue in just the right way, and she was going off as loud as she ever had in 3C.

“Yes... yesyes—yes!” She clamped her thighs around him, creating a seal that the hot water captured. Suddenly, he was drowning, water in through his nose, cutting off the air.

Yanking back, he gasped in air as his sinuses burned from all the inhaled water. He sat back on the floor of the shower, looking up at his wife as she glanced back down sheepishly. With an ironic smile, she said, “Sorry.”

There was no denying that Cooper's fantasy turned her on. When she was with him and saw how excited it made him, she got excited with him. But she also got excited doing all the smaller things with him, too. Like taking a stroll along Monterey's waterfront, holding Cooper's hand, the ocean breeze in her hair and the bark of sea lions all around.

"I'm glad we did this," she said. Cooper had been working so much lately, they rarely had time to just be with one another like this. While she wasn't crazy about coming to Brett's wedding, she did love the idea of spending more time with her husband.

Cooper's response spoke volumes. "Yeah?"

Annika understood why it was a question rather than a simple agreement. With Cooper, she'd learned that things were rarely simple. She squeezed his hand. "And it's not about adding spice to our marriage. I'm happily spiced."

He didn't say anything. The sea lions filled the silence for him. She stopped, pulling him to a stop, too. "You know that this is all I need, right? This is exactly what I want."

She looked at Cooper, reaching up to touch his face. He had a hard, sharp jaw and a slightly aquiline nose. Over the years of cycling and other outdoor activities, his skin had taken on a rugged, weathered look that she found sexy. He wasn't the same man she'd met so many years ago, just as she wasn't the same woman. They'd grown together, like two trees planted side-by-side.

She slipped up close to him and rested her head against his chest. The ocean stretched out to the hazy horizon, a single fishing boat amidst all that glitter. "How did I get so lucky?"

"Think I should be the one asking that," Cooper said. His voice was a rumble in his chest. She could hear his heart beating. As always, her husband seemed to carry the weight of fatalism with him, like an anchor. He changed the subject. "So was it weird, yesterday, seeing someone else marry your ex?"

This was dangerous territory. Cooper was setting a trap for himself, and Annika needed to be careful. If she said that she was jealous of Margot, then Cooper would come away thinking that she still pined for Brett. If she was indifferent, then he'd hear the lie because how could she not be a little jealous?

She glanced up at Cooper, pulling away enough to look him in the eyes again. "Of course it was weird, but I'm glad that you were there with me." And then, because she was still a little bitter for being left alone, she added, "Most of the time, anyway."

"I'm sorry." He winced at the apology, but left it hanging between them.

"Why did you really do that, Cooper?" She hadn't intended to have this conversation here, but it had arrived regardless. "It wasn't because you were tired."

"I..." He wanted to look away, Annika knew. She was proud of him when he didn't. "Well, you know. I guess it kind of, like..." He cleared his throat. "It was exciting, leaving you there, flirting with another guy."

"Because you thought that something would happen?"

"Yeah, I guess." He seemed to bite back another apology. That, at least, was progress.

She was about to tell him—again—that he had nothing to worry about. That she wasn't tempted. That, in fact, it was a little insulting that he thought she'd turn into some kind of slut whenever a guy with a nice smile and a pumped-up ego looked at her. But that was part of his fantasy. To set him straight was like throwing water on an already sputtering flame.

"I did have fun last night," she said instead. "At the reception."

"You did?" That sputtering flame seemed to catch, and it felt good to do that for him.

"Honestly, I wasn't crazy about coming to this wedding, but liked the idea of a vacation with you." She took a deep breath. "And I wasn't crazy about coming here because I wasn't sure how I'd feel, seeing Brett get married."

"Like he's The One That Got Away?"

"No! But he did mean something to me once. Like you and Rachel. Is she The One That Got Away?"

She'd never met Cooper's college girlfriend, but had seen photos and heard a few stories.

"How could you even ask that?" he said.

"Right, and now turn it around and ask yourself the same, please." She linked her arm in his and led them down the gravel path. "So no, Brett was definitely not The One, but that doesn't mean it felt great watching him get married."

They walked quietly. A seagull cried overhead. Waves crashed along the stony shore.

"I'm happy for him," she said at last. "Seems like he's met someone as wild as he needed."

"Did..." She could feel her husband building up the courage to ask this next thing. "Did he push you to try wild things?"

They'd never actually talked about their past sex lives. Cooper had never asked, and she wasn't going to volunteer. But now he had.

"He didn't really *push* me to do anything. Everything I did, I did because I... cared for him." She was about to say loved, but worried what that would do to Cooper's fragile state.

"So, like, what did you do for him?"

"He liked getting blowjobs in the coffee shop's storeroom. That always felt risky."

"Wow."

“It’s why I started wearing my hair in twin braids. Brett liked something to hold onto.”

“He was rough with you,” Cooper said.

“Sometimes.”

“Do you like it rough?”

She heard the present tense in his question. Their sex was more sensual than physical. “I liked it with him, because he liked it that way.”

Cooper digested it. They walked on. She gave him space to think. She did some thinking, too. Those were intense times. When she was with Brett, anything was possible. She did things that she never dreamed she would when she was with him, and it was always exciting because it got him so excited. How was that any different than what Cooper fantasized about now?

Cooper emerged from his thoughts with his own questions. “A part of you is still drawn to him, isn’t it? Still tempted? Like, you went up to the afterparty last night because maybe something could have happened?”

“How could you even ask that?”

“I don’t know. I mean, I know you weren’t, like, actually tempted. But you have a lot of history with Brett, and I know that when you two were together, you know, you... you... did stuff for him, and... and—”

“Hey, hey, Cooper, sweetheart.” She stopped, turned to him, her hands on his shoulders, looking him in the eyes. His face was so red. “That was then. That’s just how I am in a relationship. I give everything because I want to give everything. But I’m not in a relationship with Brett. I’m with *you*. I went up to that party for you, believe it or not.”

He wanted to say something else, but couldn’t seem to manage it. She knew what it was, though. It was scary and exciting.

She spoke for him. “But you liked the idea that I went up there to meet up with Brett.”

“Or the other guy. Ryan?”

“Yes, Ryan,” she said. Cooper looked so cute, so lost. So ready to have his buttons pressed. “Flirting with Ryan was a fun side effect of teasing you.”

“You’re very good at that. The teasing.”

“I’ve had some practice.” She took a deep breath, staring right up at him as she squeezed his hands. Moment of truth. “Brett liked sharing me, too.”

It was shocking that it had taken her so long to tell Cooper about this, but as soon as the words were out, she felt a wave of relief. The weight was gone.

“I... I kind of knew. Kai?”

“How did you...?”

“He hinted at it. At the reception. But also...”

“Yes?” She was now in the same place as Cooper—spinning and turned around at all the discoveries.

“I mean, I didn’t know that he liked to... watch.” It was so cute how shy her husband could get. “But sometimes I... listened.”

“Listened?”

“Oh, God, I can’t believe I’m...” He covered his face.

“Hey, it’s okay. It’s okay. No judgments from me.” She pulled his hands from his face and peered up at him. “Listened?”

“The floors in our old apartment aren’t really all that insulated, and I could hear you two. At night. In bed.”

“Oh.” She drew a heavy breath, thinking about all the crazy things that he must have heard. “That’s pretty embarrassing,” she said, then quickly added, “For me, I mean.” Brett got her to say some dirty things. “Oh, my God. And you still wanted to go out with me?”

“Are you kidding? It was like dating a pornstar.” Annika giggled. He added, “And every day since we got together, I’ve been waiting for the dream to end.”

“Or for the actual pornstar to emerge?” she asked.

“Sort of, but honestly, I always worried that when she did, she’d realize that I didn’t do the things to her that Brett did.”

“Oh, Cooper.” She pulled him into her arms. “You silly man. That’s not how it works.”

“You sure about that? I can still remember those nights...”

“I told you already, you *are* the man for me. The only regret that I have is that we never talked about this sooner.” Something clicked. This was where his fantasy came from. This is how he dealt with her sexual past—by turning his fear of losing her to some stud into a fetish. “But now that I know...”

“Yes?” He sounded equal parts eager and worried.

“Come on, let’s go back to the hotel. I’ve got a fun idea for tonight.”

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PART VII

RYAN

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Ryan couldn't believe his good fortune, although he knew the wedding of Margot Hughes, née Fitzgerald, would be wild. He just didn't realize how over-the-top it could get.

"So you want to suck my dick...?" He looked at Margot, who still had her veil in her springy, white-gold curls. Then he turned to Annika, looking like a fucking Swedish bikini model in her blue and white suit and her pale skin and sweet smile. "...while you watch?"

"Close." Margot beamed. "Her husband's going to probably watch, too."

It wasn't the weirdest thing that he'd done with Margot. To Annika, he asked, "Kinky. That why your husband left you alone tonight?"

Annika looked hot even when she blushed. "That's what we're trying to figure out," she said. Just like at the reception, she didn't back down. He wondered how far he could push.

“And what do I get out of this exchange?”

Margot pouted. “A slurpy stroll down memory lane.”

Annika chortled.

“Will you be joining?” he asked her. “Margot always performed best with a partner.”

The two women looked at each other. Margot was down for it, Ryan knew. Annika seemed less convinced. The idea of it, though, was enough to get him hard.

“He’s always been like this,” Margot explained to Annika. “Like a spoiled child who can never have enough.”

“Come on, Margot,” he said. “You of all people know there’s no such thing as enough.”

Annika looked amused by the whole exchange, which gave Ryan hope. She even said, “Ryan, if you’re still looking for a hookup tonight, I think I just found someone who’s perfect.”

He chuckled at the callback joke, when they’d been scoping out chicks together at the reception. “You know, I’ve been giving this matter a lot of thought—”

“He really has changed,” Margot commented sarcastically.

Ryan ignored her. “—and you said, technically, that you wouldn’t *sleep* with me. But technically, oral sex has nothing to do with sleep.”

Annika laughed. Another good sign. Margot turned to her, swayed by the argument enough to ask, “You game? I know it wouldn’t be your first double BJ.”

Interesting detail. “Brett told you,” Annika said—not a question, more like a detective putting the clues together.

“We tell each other *everything*,” Margot said, sidling up closer to the other blond. Ryan’s blood really started pumping now. He knew it was probably all a show, but when he thought of a future of these two hot things crawling all over him in bed, he was hooked.

“Okay, I’m in,” he said, too quickly to sound good and confident. So he added, “I’ll let you two suck my cock.”

“Ryan always liked the promise of girl-on-girl.”

Annika beamed at him, adding, “Number one guy’s fantasy, right?”

Was this really going to happen? Margot leaned closer to Annika, giving her a soft kiss on the side of her neck. Annika’s skin was pale enough that

Ryan could easily see her blush spread. She looked at him with those sweet, hazel eyes and he was smitten.

“Come on,” Margot said. She guided Annika through a door marked, *Employees Only*, shooting him a sly look over her shoulder. “We need to swap bikinis for this to work.”

Ryan waited outside long enough to toss back his drink before turning and following. He knew Margot’s game. She’d done this very thing years ago. Annika, despite her willingness to flirt back, he was less sure of. Like a wild mustang, he didn’t want to spook her.

But like a wild mustang, he was determined to ride the shit out of her if he could.

“You have amazing tits,” Margot was saying as he followed their voices into the catering hall. They were in the store room, already topless. Annika was turned away from him, but he could still see the curved side of one weighty globe. “Who did them?”

“Oh, they’re real.” Annika laughed. “Doesn’t the sag give it away?”

Margot palmed her own tits, which Ryan knew were store-bought. “You’re kidding, right? They’re, like, perfect.” Margot wiggled out of her bikini bottoms without a hint of modesty. She still kept herself bare shaven, he was happy to see. “I bet your husband loves it when you titty fuck him.”

“You know, we’ve actually never done that.” Annika laughed again. “You’re very forward.”

“I am,” Margot said unapologetically. “And why not? It’s like fifty percent of the reason I had mine done. Nothing quite like seeing a fat cock sliding through your cleavage.”

“Now that’s Brett talking,” Annika said with a giggle. “But no, haven’t done that since we broke up.”

Her husband’s such a pussy, Ryan thought. If he was married to a fox like Annika, he’d ride that chest every night.

Her turn to shimmy out of her bikini bottoms. As if to preserve modesty, she turned away from Margot, treating Ryan with a glimpse of those amazing titties. They swung heavily beneath her as she bent forward, bouncing outward as she straightened up. Ryan’s mouth salivated at the thought of wrapping his lips around those large, pink nipples.

Quickly, she stepped into Margot’s bikini bottoms. Ryan caught the flash of her trimmed bush, and how her shaved slit glistened beneath. Some part of her was excited by all of this.

“You really wear this in public?” Annika asked, adjusting the white thong into her heart-shaped ass. “I feel so exposed.”

“You’ve got the body to flaunt it.” Margot was slower to put Annika’s suit on. “And I hardly consider the party out there ‘public,’ you know? We’re all friends.”

Annika looped the white top over her neck, but when she reached behind her to tie the top, Margot stepped up. “Here, let me help with that.”

Annika began to turn around to face away, but Margot didn’t let her. Instead, she stepped right up against the other woman, her bare breasts pressed into Annika’s, and reached around her back to begin to tie. As she did so, Margot shot a glance at Ryan, beckoning him to enter before meeting Annika’s eyes.

“I’m so happy that you came to the wedding,” she said. “You know, if your husband really is a cuck, we could have so much fun.”

Ryan barely heard it. His dick had taken over. He was already thinking about looking down to see two hot blondes slobbering on his cock.

“Brett and I got a beautiful VRBO in Carmel, just south of here. Oceanfront views, nicely secluded. Maybe you could come out.”

“Isn’t this your honeymoon?”

“Oh, sweetheart, we have so much love to share.” She leaned in and kissed Annika softly on the lips. “And we *love* sharing.”

Ryan couldn’t stay back any longer. He was hard, and his dick was ready to get wet. He stepped right up behind Annika, running his hands along her hips. Her skin burned. She gasped at his touch.

“Do I get an invitation, too?” he asked.

“We’ll see how things go,” Margot said. She put a hand on Ryan’s face and pushed him away from Annika. “But you’re not earning bonus points. Get out of here.” To Annika, she said, “I only invited him for his dick. He can be pretty fucking arrogant.”

Annika snorted. “I gathered.”

“Hey, I’m almost offended,” he said.

“You’re about to get a Margot Hughes beej, babe.”

“They as good as Margot Fitzgerald blowjobs?”

“Better, and you know why?” She looked at Annika as she answered her own question. “Because he loves it when he plays with other men’s wives.”

Cooper forced himself to stop tapping his finger onto the bar top after the second dirty look from the guy sitting next to him. Cooper offered a weak smile. “Sorry.”

The guy just swallowed his beer and continued to thumb through his phone. Cooper wasn’t one to eavesdrop on total strangers, but he was pretty certain the guy was browsing porn. He dutifully averted his eyes.

He was sitting at the outdoor bar at Del Mar, one of the many restaurants along Fisherman’s Wharf, waiting for Annika to make her entrance.

“*So I was thinking...*” she’d said on their walk back to the hotel. “*Why don’t you go ahead to the bar, and I’ll meet you.*”

He’d been confused until she added, “*Or you could sit back and watch me flirt with strange, hot men.*”

It was the “hot men” part of the statement that really got Cooper going. Annika didn’t talk like that. Not normally. But she knew how words like that triggered him in all the delicious, cuckoldy ways. Because, he supposed, sitting there at the bar, that’s what he was, right? A cuckold?

The man beside him cleared his throat again, and Cooper realized that he’d been tapping again. He shifted his nervous energy into bouncing his knee, which was only a little better. The guy picked up his drink and moved to the other end of the bar.

Then, it was like clouds parting to let in the sun. There she was, Annika at the door, her red dress tight and tiny and unlike any he’d seen her wear in many years. It brought back the memories of their time as friends, of clubs and bars and nights that ended with him listening to her fuck other men. It left him aching now.

She scanned the bar—crowded despite it being a Sunday evening. The tourists were out, but that wasn’t all. A band had attracted a nice gathering, playing classic rock inside, the drums and vocals spilling out into the warm night. There was energy all around, and in that moment, it seemed like all the energy radiated from Annika.

She met his eyes, electric and alive, and a smile tugged across her angular face. She’d pulled her hair back, gathered it in a ponytail that could have been cute, but in that dress was borderline trashy. She didn’t come to him, though, but instead made a show of searching the group and not finding who she was looking for.

Everyone at Del Mar seemed to hold their breath as she wound her way to the bar, Cooper included. Even the band inside seemed to stumble, feedback shrieking out of the open bay doors.

In that dress, her legs seemed endless and her tits so big. If she’d parked herself beside him now, he wasn’t sure he’d be able to speak.

But she didn’t park herself beside him. Instead, she settled in at the opposite end, where Cooper had chased the man off to. The bartender greeted her like she was a regular, and when she started to pull a credit card from her small clutch, the formerly annoyed man made a motion to put it on his. ‘*Thank you,*’ she seemed to say with a flirty smile.

The jealousy was delicious.

“You two are really kinky.” The unfamiliar man’s voice came from behind him. “That’s some dress...”

Cooper turned to see Ryan there at the bar, leering across the room at Annika. "You..."

"I'm Ryan." He dragged his eyes away from Annika. "We met last night. Couple times, actually."

He had a friendly smile that came easily—and the smile lines from frequent use, but it made Cooper about as comfortable as a gun in his face. "Ryan. Right. What a coincidence."

It was only as he said it that it occurred to Cooper that maybe it wasn't a coincidence at all. He looked at Annika, but she was still engrossed in the other man, who'd now dropped his surliness.

"You should have stuck around last night." He remained fixated on Annika. "Things got fun."

"Uh huh." Cooper, too, kept his eyes on his wife.

"Brett was pretty glowing about Annika's oral skills. I think he was mostly doing it to get Margot worked up, but man, he went on and on about how she was the first chick who could throat him." He took a sip of something he was drinking. "You should have let her join last night. I was looking forward to feeling two mouths on me."

"I bet, but it wasn't my decision."

"Oh, but in a way, it was. You see, Brett told me about that, too. Your wife has a sub streak. She's a pleaser. He said, and I quote, 'Nothing was off limits for her.'"

Cooper swallowed hard. Of course, he knew all that. Didn't make hearing it any less exciting.

"Is that what you've found, too?" Ryan pressed. "Does she give you everything that you want?"

Cooper felt pummeled beneath this man's questions. He couldn't find his voice.

"Is that what tonight's all about? Is she giving you your cuck experience?"

"I..." Didn't know? Didn't want to tell this other man? But wasn't another man necessary for this particular experience?

"Wearing a little, red party dress, coming into a bar separately, flirting with another man... I'm not jumping to conclusions here."

"No," Cooper croaked.

"You denied me a threesome last night with two hot blondes." His tone shifted. "I was looking forward to fucking your wife as she went down on

the new bride—and before you tell me that Annika isn't into it..." he said, reading Cooper's face. "...I know for a fact that she's tasted pussy before. For Brett."

"Really?" The words slipped out before he could stop them.

"Oh, Coop." He may as well have added, *you sad fuck*. "There's a lot she's done for Brett. You should ask her about it sometime."

The guy speaking to Annika left, taking his drink with him. She stared into her own glass, half full, a pleasant smile lighting up her face. Then she turned towards Cooper, seeking him out. When she saw that he wasn't alone, though, the smile faded.

"Looks like that's my cue," Ryan said. He slapped Cooper on the back. "Wish me luck, although I'm not going to need it."

Annika kept her eyes fixed on Cooper's, even as Ryan weaved his way through the crowd towards her. He couldn't read her, but suddenly got a very sinking, terrible feeling.

Annika was falling, spinning, end-over-end. She was dizzy from it. She was disoriented by it. She hadn't felt this way in many years. Not since she'd been with Kai and had learned that Brett had set it all up. It was happening again. It was—

“That’s a nice dress.” Ryan, cocky, smug, good-looking Ryan, leaned an elbow against the bar, blocking her view of her husband.

“Glad you approve.”

His eyes crawled all over her, just like the last guy’s had. She’d forgotten what that felt like—to be completely objectified. “You put that on for me?”

“Now why would I? I didn’t know you’d be here.” Her eyes narrowed. “Why are you here, Ryan?”

“Same reason as you, I imagine.” He held up his glass and winked. “To have a drink.”

Last night, the swagger had been charming. Last night, all of this was harmless. But last night was a long time ago. “Is that really the only reason you’re here?” she asked. “Because it’s not mine.”

The way he looked at her sent a quiver through her. It was easy to overlook this kind of attention when there wasn’t a possibility of it going anywhere, but now, anything was possible.

“You should have stayed last night,” he said.

“You think?”

“Your husband’s all for it.”

“Oh, I see. You two have it all worked out, huh?”

Ryan glanced back at Cooper, who looked like he wanted to be anywhere but there, but also *really* wanted to be there. “Isn’t that what last night was all about? Testing him? I’d say that he passed.”

She narrowed her eyes. “You seem to know a lot about my husband.”

“I know his type. I’ve met guys like him before in the lifestyle, and you’ve got a real winner there.” He reached out and ran his hand along her bare arm. His fingers were soft—the pampered hand of a man used to getting everything that he wanted. “Or loser, I suppose, depending on how you want to think about it.”

Annika stiffened at the insult. “You think you’re going to make much progress calling my husband names?”

“It’s all part of the game, Anni. You should count yourself lucky.”

“Oh, because you found me?”

Ryan snorted. “I mean, of course, but that’s not what I meant. No, see, your husband isn’t just, like... he’s not Brett.” Her heart pulsated at the mention of her ex’s name. “He’s not a stag. You familiar with that term?”

She shook her head.

“A stag is a guy who shares his wife, or girlfriend, with other guys, but in, like, a dominant way.”

“That’s Brett.”

“Right. And you’re a hotwife.”

“I’m the object to be shared.” She couldn’t keep the bitterness out of this, thinking back to her times with her ex. Thinking back to why they broke up.

“That’s one way to look at it,” Ryan said. “But would you really consider Margot a passive part of that relationship?”

“Okay, good point.”

“But regardless, Cooper isn’t a stag, and I don’t mean this as an insult. I’m just stating what I’m seeing.”

“And that is?”

“Your husband is a cuckold.”

“Well, not yet,” she said. “Now you’re really getting ahead of yourself. I have *never* cheated on him—”

“Were you an English major?” he asked. “Never mind. No, he’s not a cuckold in, like, the Chaucer sense. It’s a term in the lifestyle, like bulls and stags and hotwives. He’s a cuck, and here’s why you’re lucky. His fantasy, like the stag’s, is to share you, only he’s a passive participant. You are not the object. You’re the predicate.”

“Were *you* an English major?”

“Hell, no. Do I look like a man who reads?”

“Fair enough.” She laughed, despite herself. This man was full of himself, but the banter with him was fun.

“Point is, you get to call the shots. You get to do what you want, and the kicker is, he’ll eat it up—whatever it is. I suspect that he even gets off on the idea that you’re cheating on him behind his back.”

“No.”

“Oh, yes. I’ve dated women like that before, with husbands who have the ‘unfaithful’ fantasy. There’s nothing quite like it.”

“And the husbands didn’t come after you?” Now she was intrigued, leaning into the conversation.

“One thanked me, once. One wanted to suck my dick.” He chuckled. “But most of the guys don’t want to know me at all. The bull is the true object.”

“Is that what you call yourself? A bull?”

He tossed his head. “Do you like my horns?”

She reached out, running the tips of her fingers through his hair. It was long enough to curl around his ears, the dark hair fine and streaked with silver. “Why is it okay for men to go gray, and us women have to cover it up?”

“Maybe I dye the gray in because women like it.”

She laughed. “It works for you. Too bad I think stags are hotter.” She patted him softly on the shoulder. “I’m partial to antlers.”

“If you were my woman, I’d share you.”

“You’d shave me, too, if I recall.” She squeezed her thighs, feeling the way her soft panties brushed along her bare mound.

“I’d do all kinds of things to you.” He leaned into her, his hand coming to rest on the outside of her thigh. “If you’d stayed last night, I would have given you a demonstration.”

The hand climbed higher, those soft fingers tracing the contours of her quads. She was back there, once again, watching Margot on her knees, her head bobbing. She remembered the way Ryan had looked right at her, and how she’d trembled.

He moved closer still, his breath tickling the nape of her neck. “I could probably squeeze in a second performance, if you’d like.”

Annika snapped out of the fog, looking towards Cooper, half-expecting that he was gone. He wasn’t. He was still there, nakedly watching her, his shoulders rising and falling with each heavy breath. The way he watched her felt like a finger right against her clit. She gasped as if touched.

“But my husband...”

“Can watch,” Ryan said. “Or, even better, he can watch us leave the restaurant together and wonder.”

“That feels so mean.”

“And we both know he’ll love it.” Ryan glanced towards the bartender. “I’d like to close out my tab. Pay for that guy’s drinks, too, at the other end of the bar with the blue shirt.”

“I didn’t say that I was going with you anywhere,” Annika said. She felt like she’d waded into this night, intending to test the water temperature, and had suddenly been caught up in the swift-flowing current. It reminded her of her life before Cooper, which wasn’t necessarily a bad thing.

“We’re just walking out together, Annika.” He scribbled a generous tip onto the check he received. “After that, we’ll see where the night takes us.”

She glanced at Cooper, still sitting there, shifting and restless, turned on, confused. She looked back at Ryan. He thought he was playing it cool, but she could see his excitement roiling beneath the surface. He was the current of the night—or so he thought.

She took a deep breath and slid off her stool, tugging at the short hem of her dress. “Okay,” she said. “Let’s see where it takes us.”

Sitting at the bar, watching Annika in that tiny dress flirt with the confident, older gentlemen, Cooper was so hard that his balls hurt. He ordered a second drink, telling himself that he would nurse it, only to find it empty again within a minute.

Unlike her friendly exchange with the scowly guy from before, she seemed to enjoy her time with Ryan. She didn't humor him but seemed to give as much as she got. It was like watching two champion duelists spar, and Annika rose to the challenge.

Cooper wanted to remember every moment of this—the way Ryan touched her arm, how he stepped close and whispered to her, how Annika seemed to caress his hair as they laughed together. It felt good and wrong all at once. He wondered if this was why masochists liked to be spanked.

It was nothing compared to the helpless thrill he got as he watched her leave with another man. That was him on the beach as a tidal wave reared

up before him, as tall as a skyscraper, with nowhere to run. This was the moment he'd been waiting for since he'd gotten together with her. This was inevitably writ in bold, black script.

She glanced at him as she left on Ryan's arm. He wondered what she wore beneath the dress, thinking of her claim last night that it would top the black lingerie. He wondered if he'd see it now, and was titillated that maybe he never would.

And then they were gone, and that tidal wave came crashing down, rocking his insecure world. What was he doing? What was Annika doing? If this was solely for him, he would hate himself forever.

Like they were connected, he got a text from her that only stirred up those fears even more.

ANNIKA

Last chance. Is this really what you want?

They couldn't have been gone more than a couple minutes. They probably were still somewhere in the hubbub of the Wharf.

COOPER

If you're feeling it, go for it.

Oh, I'm feeling something!

The text carved through him. So much so that the bartender asked if he was alright.

"Yeah, I'm fine. Could I..." Did he want to pay off his tab and leave, or get another. His brain stumbled over even a simple decision like that.

The bartender helped him make his decision. "Want a refill?"

"Please." He'd been drinking Jack and Cokes and knew he should have switched to something with less caffeine—and less alcohol, for that matter—but the bartender was already moving. Like his life, it was already out of his hands.

He didn't write back to Annika, though. Everything he started to compose felt silly. Besides, she'd write again if something was about to happen.

When Cooper had finished his drink, almost 45 minutes had passed and she still hadn't written. Now that was plenty of time for something to happen, and the possibility that something had happened got his heart racing more than the whiskey and coke—but that didn't help, either.

“I’ll close out my tab,” he said when the bartender came back.

“Sure thing. It’ll just be for the one drink, though. Some other guy paid the rest.”

Was that a knowing smile on the bartender’s face? Blood coursed through Cooper’s own as he felt the rush of humiliation. Even still, it took him another ten minutes to fight his erection down enough not to make an embarrassing exit.

It was still early when he stepped out. The band had begun to play in earnest now, and he could see the crowd spilling out the front of the restaurant. He stood on the outskirts, listening without really hearing any of it, and wondered what the hell to do.

He checked his phone obsessively, willing her to text something and fighting the urge to ask where she was. He broke down after another ten minutes of that.

COOPER

So, hey, just checking to see if everything is okay.

It was as he was standing there, waiting for a response, that he saw Ryan. He was in the crowd, watching the band, and for a minute, he felt both relief and confusion. Of course Annika was messing with him. Again. If she was capable of what she did last night, then leading him on now was child’s play.

Only Ryan wasn’t with Annika, he noticed. He’d moved on, apparently, and was chatting up a brunette who looked twenty years his junior.

Cooper’s phone buzzed.

ANNIKA

So are you really, really, positively sure you’re okay with this?
Because things are about to cross a line.

He grinned. Suddenly, the weight was gone. The bite lacked teeth.

COOPER

Go for it. Cross all the lines.

And then, because he was drunk and falling in love with this woman all over again, for indulging him in this silly game, he added:

I love you!

He watched Ryan inside, making sure that Annika didn't emerge from the bathroom and pull him away. Ryan remained there, relentlessly focused on bedding the brunette. That felt good, too. Annika deserved better than this man, even if none of this was real.

He walked back to the Cormorant as if on a cloud. The night felt alive. He floated along, adrift on the sounds of the ocean waves and the ringing of dingy bells in the dark. He arrived back at the hotel, the bar much quieter than anything back at the Fisherman's Wharf.

In the short elevator ride up, Cooper wondered if Annika would be out of her dress, perched on the bed in the sexy lingerie she'd alluded to last night. He wondered if it was red, like the dress. She didn't wear much red lingerie, but he always liked the idea. He had to adjust himself before stepping off the elevator, his cock painfully hard in his pants once again.

As he arrived at the door to the hotel room, he heard her.

Sliding his keycard against the lock, he thought he heard a giggle as it clicked open. He grinned, relieved and ready to show her how much he appreciated her games. *Fool me once...*

Opening the door, he was greeted with an entirely unexpected scene. A trail of clothing led into the room, starting from just inside the door. There was Annika's red dress, and just after, a man's collared shirt... and not his shirt.

"Uhh... ohh yes!" Annika's moan. Not a giggle at all. "Yes! Fuck me harder!"

Cooper's stomach swam. Everything felt hot. Too hot. He felt dizzy. He floated into the room like an untethered balloon. First thing he saw was more clothes. A red bra. A pair of jeans and a man's belt.

They were on the bed, naked and covered in a sheen of sweat. Annika was on her knees, hips high, face down on the mattress. She still wore her red heels, tall and sharp.

"You like my cock?" the man demanded—the man who was kneeling behind her, fucking her from behind as he held her arms against the small of her back. "You miss my dick?"

Her cry was a garbled mess, somewhere between plea and release. "Yes!"

Cooper had never fully understood the sensation of shock until that moment. He floated outside of his body, watching a scene lifted right out of

his deepest fantasies and most repressed memories. It was a scene he only ever imagined... only ever dreamed about.

He watched himself watch Annika writhe and moan on the bed as her old boyfriend, Brett, fucked the shit out of her.

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PART VIII

BRETT

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Brett and Margot's wedding was beautiful, held out on the same veranda that the reception would later take place. The setting sun provided the backdrop as they exchanged their vows. The breeze carried the salty brine of the ocean and all the excitement of a carefree summer.

It was magical.

It was, Annika realized, the wedding she'd once dreamt of having with Brett.

She didn't have any regrets marrying Cooper. He was the best thing to happen to her, just as it seemed Margot was the best thing to happen to Brett. But she still felt... something. Call it jealousy. Call it nostalgia or sentimentality, but she felt the bitter-sweet twinges of it as the newlyweds stared at one another and kissed.

“I’m happy for them,” Annika told Cooper. They were shuffled off the veranda so it could be transformed into the reception area. “He looks happy.”

Cooper gave her a measured look that she always thought of was jealousy—only in a few short hours would she realize that it was something so much more profound than that.

“I really am, Coop. We were never the right fit.” She wasn’t just saying it to convince herself, although that was certainly part of it. She really was happy for him, and hoped that he’d finally found his hedonistic match. “Now you, on the other hand...” She hugged him close. He was stiff and wound up. “Everything okay?”

“Yeah,” he said unconvincingly. She didn’t probe. Cooper often got lost in his thoughts, and she’d learned to let him work it out on his own.

“Come on, I heard there was a cocktail named after the bride and the groom.”

The shift to the reception was quick. It was light *hors d'oeuvres* served outside, where the sun finally disappeared beyond the horizon. Annika wanted to go up to the bride and groom and congratulate them, but couldn’t build up the nerve. Then Cooper disappeared and Ryan approached, and the night moved on.

To Cooper going back to the hotel without her.

To the rooftop afterparty.

To Margot and Ryan, the blowjob, and Brett blundering into the situation.

Annika didn’t realize how much she’d been avoiding her ex until he was right there—granted he was there, ready to join the orgy, but still. She needed to put off that me reunion, if only for a little longer. She needed some space with her husband and his fantasy. She needed to understand.



THE LAST TIME she’d seen Brett in person, other than at the wedding, was one month before she got together with Cooper. He showed up at her apartment one evening, leaning against the bricks of the building as she approached. He straightened himself up as she said, “You cut your hair.”

After all this time, it was an absurd thing to say. All of this felt absurd. Brett ran his hand over the top of his head, where he once sported a topknot. His hair was short now, cleaned up and corporate. "Yeah."

Things felt awkward. She fumbled for something to say. "It looks good on you."

His shoulders were slumped in a way they never were before. When he smiled at her, though, there was the charm. "Thanks. I figured I needed a change."

She nodded. Her heart was racing. "So what are you doing here, Brett?"

"Just wanted to talk. Last time we talked..." He took a deep breath. "I wanted to say that I'm sorry."

Her heart broke a little. How many times had she dreamed about this moment over the last half year? How many times did she wish that he'd show up, just like this, and say these very words, and how she'd run into his arms and take him back?

"Want to come upstairs?" Not exactly running into his arms, but not exactly asking him to grab a coffee around the corner, either. His grin felt nostalgic, and as soon as they entered her apartment, they were all over each other.

They tore at one another's clothes as they kissed and stumbled into the bed. The more clean-cut Brett was just as fit and gym-hewn, if not moreso. She missed all his hard muscle. She missed the things he could do with his cock.

"Ah, Annika," he groaned. He was over her, smothering her, fucking all one-hundred-and-ninety pounds of man into her and she was loving it. She'd been with others since the breakup, but none of them could compare to Brett when it came to raw physicality. He knew her body, and he knew his own, and he knew how the two connected.

"Give it to me," Annika cried. Her world was crashing around her. "I'm coming... oh, Brett... Brett... I'm... uhhh fuck, holy shit, I'm coming!"

Brett joined her, driving his eight-inches of perfection into her. She felt his balls tighten. She felt his cock begin to pulse, and then everything was hot and sticky and full of fire. She milked his cock with her pussy, welcoming every drop, because deep down, she knew that this was a farewell.

"You know, I didn't come here for a booty call," he said. They were lying on their sides, sweat cooling on their skin but still warm in the

afterglow.

“Liar.” She touched the hair at his temples, marveling at how soft the short hairs were.

“I’m serious.” He said it, but his boyish grin was there—the one that got him out of so much trouble in the past. “I just wanted to apologize.”

“So you could tell me to my face that you were in a bad place, and not of the right mind?” She couldn’t keep the sarcasm out of her voice. He was here, in her bed, having fucked her like no man ever could—and she still loved him so much—but she couldn’t forgive him.

“No excuses from me,” he said. “I took advantage of you. I took advantage of our relationship. My therapist says—”

“You’re seeing a therapist?” The man was full of surprises.

He shrugged. “Sure. When I lost the best thing to happen to my life, I figured I needed to do something about it.”

“Okay.” Wow. “Continue.”

“We... you and I... we’re not good for one another—”

“Well, good of you and your therapist to decide what’s best for me,” Annika interrupted.

It didn’t faze Brett. He only grinned wider. “I like this new you. Sassy. But also, you kind of did decide what’s best for you. When you broke up with me.”

“Jumping to some conclusions I see.”

“Just hear me out. Our relationship wasn’t healthy. I’m a hedonist, and you’re a...” He hesitated before saying, “A submissive.”

That got her brows up. Deep down, though, she knew he was right, and over the years to come, she came to accept that there was some truth to it.

“I just take and take, and you will give and give because that’s who we are. Most of the time, it worked out pretty well. I got you to do things that you never would have, but seemed to really enjoy...” She blushed, thinking of Phoebe, and her first time with Kai. “But sometimes—like with Kai—it didn’t work. Like at all.”

“But it could have,” she said. “If you’d stayed here.”

“Ultimately, I would have pushed things too far no matter what. That’s who I am. And you would have done it. Because that’s who you are. And it would have been a disaster.”

“So deterministic, Brett,” she said. “You know, we’re not just at the whims of our base instincts.”

“Speak for yourself. I happen to like my base instincts.”

She laughed. “You make an excellent point.”

“I love you, Annika. I will always love you. But that’s why I need to say this...”

She felt her heart breaking. “You don’t have to.”

“I do. We don’t work. I can’t hurt you again, and you deserve someone who won’t take advantage of you. Someone who gives as much as you do.”

She said, “You changed.”

“So did you.” He kissed her softly. “But I’m still a hedonist.”

“Hope that when you find your hedonistic match, the two of you don’t ruin yourselves.”

“Well, if we do, it’ll be spectacular, won’t it?”



DAY AFTER THE WEDDING, she finally met Brett again, along with his hedonistic partner. It was Margot who spotted her first, browsing a small dress shop. “Look who it is,” the newly wed said with delight. “You should definitely get the red one. Don’t you think, Brett?”

“She looks great in red.”

Annika almost didn’t want to look at him, as if refusing to look would make him disappear. That last memory of them together was still so fresh, like it was yesterday.

“Hey, Anni,” he said. His hair was longer than the last time she’d seen him—the last time they’d fucked—but still far shorter than his barista days.

“Brett.” Even saying his name left her feeling breathless. *Don’t tremble, don’t tremble, but God, did he still look good.* Even the salt-and-pepper in his scruff looked good. “You look...” She caught herself before saying something stupid in front of his new wife. “...scruffy. Can’t even be bothered to shave for your own wedding?”

Brett grinned good-naturedly. Margot burst out laughing. She said, “He’s a slob, isn’t he?”

“Always.”

“Hey, now. I did shave.” He rubbed his face. “Oh, did you mean this?”

Margot elbowed him.

Annika laughed.

“I’m sorry I spooked you last night,” he said. Right, so they were going to talk about that. “Margot gave me an earful afterwards.”

“It’s okay. It was time for us to leave, anyway,” Annika said.

“You got what you needed?” Margot’s blue eyes sparkled.

“Definitely.”

Margot glanced at the dress that Annika had been eyeing, short, red, slinky. “That for tonight?”

“Yeah.” She glanced at Brett, self-conscious that he was overhearing this, only to remember how much he already knew about her. No secrets here. “I’m going to tease Cooper. We’re meeting at the Wharf, and he’s going to watch guys try to pick me up.”

“Ooo, I love that game,” Margot said. “Maybe we could join you? We’ve got dinner plans at the Wharf tonight and—”

“No, honey,” Brett interjected. “This is for them.”

Margot pouted. “You’re no fun.”

“Oh?” He collected his new bride in his arms. “Pretty sure I don’t believe you.”

Watching Margot and Brett together like that stirred up more of those bitter-sweet feelings. She’d been in Margot’s shoes once, and she was glad that Brett had moved on.

“You definitely should buy that red dress,” Brett told her.

“Definitely,” Margot agreed. “You’d be hot as fuck.”

Like everything about this weekend, the encounter left Annika reflective of the past—of her time with Brett and her imagined future with him. It was like she was a boat, untethered and rudderless, letting the ebb and flow of the waves raise and lower her spirits.

Always, though, in the end, she came back to her life with Cooper, of the joy she felt when he first asked her out, like everything finally fell into place. She could love both men, she realized in her heart. But in her head, she knew that only one was the man that she needed.

She bought the red dress, of course. If anything, Brett and Margot’s encouragement bolstered her idea. She sent Cooper out to meet her at Del Mar as she got ready. She took a shower. She made sure to shave her mound again, to be extra smooth. She took her time to dress in the racy, red lingerie that she’d brought and that went so well with her new dress.

When she entered the bar, she was wet and excited. Cooper’s eyes were all over her. So was every other man she passed. All of the attention got her

going. This was just a tease tonight, but she couldn't help but think about the *possibility*. Cooper had given her permission, and if she wanted—and did a half-way decent job of flirting—she could have anyone. She scanned the room, settling on a guy sitting opposite the bar as her.

He was a good flirt, decent at banter, and had the kind of cockiness that reminded her a little of Brett. It was fun until she looked over and saw Ryan sitting with Cooper. All of a sudden, her confidence was gone. The fun was sapped. Her own insecurities turned the banter hollow and her drinks to ash.

Was Cooper arranging things behind her back? Had Cooper, like Brett long before him, decided to cut her out of the game that she so needed to be part of? By the time Ryan had made his way over to her, she'd gone from despondent to angry. Fine. If he wanted to play this way, she could fucking play.

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“Let’s see where it takes us,” Annika said, sliding out of her stool. Her dress was so short that anyone looking would catch a flash of most of her thighs—and Ryan was definitely looking. She looped her arm in his and let him guide her out.

She passed her husband on the way, locking eyes, trying to figure out what his state was. What she saw was a man who looked on the verge of hysteria. He didn’t look like he was enjoying himself, and yet there was a manic nature to the way that he watched her, a man trying to hold all his excitement together for just a few more minutes.

Margot was right—Cooper was into this. Ryan was right—he was into this the way a cuckold was into it. And lastly, she was right—she could be the woman he wanted, because she also wanted it.

Unfortunately for Ryan, she just wasn’t into *him*.

“So back to the hotel?” he asked.

“That’s my plan. You can walk me back, but just to be clear, you’re not getting any.”

She watched his cocky smile melt away. It felt just as satisfying as she’d hoped. “I’m sorry?”

“Tell me one thing, Ryan. Did you and Coop really think that would work?”

“What? Me and Cooper...? No, you’ve got the wrong impression!”

The relief that washed through Annika felt just as good as shutting him down had. Cooper hadn’t arranged Ryan to be there. It was all some weird coincidence.

“Guess I do.” She kissed Ryan’s cheek softly. And dismissively. “On some things, anyway. Goodbye, Ryan.” She glanced back into the bar, where people were cheering for the band. “And good luck?”

She was already on her phone, composing two texts to two different men. In her periphery, she saw Ryan stand there, stunned, before muttering and fading away. She smiled to herself.

To her husband, she wrote:

ANNIKA

Last chance. Is this really what you want?

After hitting send, she composed her second message. To Brett.

Hey, you doing anything right now?

She giggled. It was the line they used to send each other for booty calls. Just like back in the day, she felt silly and excited and flushed all over.

She didn’t hit send, though. She waited to see what Cooper had to say, because while she was excited, she wasn’t going to start this ball rolling until she was sure he was okay with it.

She didn’t have to wait long.

COOPER

If you’re feeling it, go for it.

Reading that text had her stomach fluttering and her heart pounding. This was happening. This was really going to happen. Her fingers shook as she typed back:

ANNIKA

Oh, I’m feeling something!

She shook even more when she switched over to her text thread with Brett and finally hit send. Things were in motion now. When her ex responded a moment later with a “*well I just got married, but at the moment, I’m not doing a single, damn thing,*” there was no stopping it.

Would Margot let you come out and play?

BRETT

She says, ‘Only if I’m invited next time.’

Annika didn’t immediately recoil from the idea. The platinum blonde was really sexy, the way Jessica Rabbit was sexy. Annika didn’t really think of herself as into other girls, and the one time that she’d played with one, it was mostly for Brett—although she’d also had fun. It wasn’t a bad price to pay.

ANNIKA

Sure, why not. But just you this time, please.

BRETT

I’ll be there in 30!

Annika took her time heading home, wandering through her thoughts as much as the streets of idyllic Monterey. If there was one recurring theme with her and Brett, it was that when he beckoned, she came. What he wanted, she wanted. He was the active agent, and she was happy to be along for the ride.

When she was with Brett, it was like being caught in the undertow of something powerful and intoxicating. He had a pull that was undeniable.

Undeniable, anyway, until she was on the outside looking in. Or maybe, more like, outside looking in with Cooper.

The dynamic was different now. It was Annika doing the beckoning, and Brett doing the coming.

She blushed at her own, internal double entendre. “Now you’re getting ahead of yourself, girl,” she said to herself. Although she certainly hoped it would go that way.

In contrast to the Fisherman’s Wharf and all its touristy hubbub, the Cormorant was quiet. Its small bar was already closing down, the few guests remaining nursing their drinks as the bar counted out the register.

ANNIKA

Bar's closed. Meet me up in my room. 923.

She hesitated before sending the text to Brett. She knew how he'd read it—and it wasn't an incorrect reading. Just felt a little tawdry. Then again, she thought, what would Brett have done?

She hit send.

BRETT

I'm definitely okay with that.

Annika went up to her room and raided the minibar, taking out a single serving bottle of white.

Just parking.

Annika's stomach started to squirm. She swallowed half the glass of wine before forcing herself to slow down. Her phone buzzed again, and she nearly dropped the glass completely. It was her husband.

COOPER

So, hey, just checking to see if everything is okay.

She caressed the screen of her phone as if Cooper was standing right there. She knew what he was going through. Her last message was a tease. Her next may be so much beyond that.

She took a long moment to compose her response. This was it. There was still time to back out, but this would be the last chance.

Before she could respond, the knock came. Brett had arrived.

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Very few things in life made Brett nervous—the profound finality of death, spiders, and his ex-girlfriend all made the cut. For different reasons, naturally, but all just as profound.

Annika had been the one who got away. He secretly followed her Instagram account—not by actually following her, but manually searching for her. He’d often wonder how she was doing, hoping that she was happy. Sounded stalkerish, but it really wasn’t. He hoped that she was happy, and he hoped that she found someone who was nothing like him. She deserved better.

He was surprised when she RSVP’ed for his wedding, and actually pleased that she was coming with her husband. Margot had teased him about his ego when he’d confessed that, but Margot didn’t fully understand the nature of his past relationship. Annika was like his personal, sexy genie

—he'd ask, she'd do. For a moment, he worried that it was like that all over again, with this wedding invitation.

Actually seeing her in person snapped him out of all of those preconceived notions. She'd matured, blossoming into a new woman, and by Margot's telling, she'd married a man who was definitely not like him.

"Although you do have one thing in common," Margot had said.

"Yeah?"

"He gets just as excited watching his wife play with other men as you do. He just needs the confidence to admit it to himself."

Standing before the door of 923, Brett hoped that the man had found that confidence. He was certainly going to need it.

He knocked.

Annika had purchased the red dress after all, and it looked even better than he'd imagined. It was so short and so tight—the kind of dress that Margot wore all the time, yet on sweet, girl-next-door Annika, it was devastating.

"Hey, there," she said. She blushed, which made everything so much sexier.

"Hey."

They grinned at one another, old friends again, the years melting away. "Come on in."

She turned, leaving the door open for him. Was it possible that her ass looked even better now—filled out and firm, the dress conforming to each taut butt cheek? He couldn't wait to get his hands on her.

"I'm *really* glad you bought that dress." He closed the door gently behind him.

Annika smirked over her shoulder. "You always liked dressing me up like a slut."

"I liked doing a lot of things to you, yes." And if they'd stayed together, who knows where that would have gone. Her submissive nature meant that there were no checks on what he wanted. Until she dumped him, he was a man without consequences. The breakup snapped him out of it. Better than an OD, his therapist continued to remind him. But tonight wasn't the start of something new, just a trip down memory lane. A dabble. A living memory.

"Take it off," he said. He started to unbutton his own shirt. "Let's see how that dress looks around your ankles."

Annika's lips parted in her sharp, silent intake of air. Her pupils dilated the way they always did when he told her to do something. And she did as told. Without turning away, without breaking eye contact, she reached behind her and lowered the dress's zipper. She brushed the dress off her shoulders, but it was still tight enough that she had to shimmy and peel it down her body.

Beneath, she wore a red lingerie set that seemed to be constructed entirely of lace and straps. "Wow."

"I've got matching stockings and a garter belt. Let me go put them on —"

"No, fuck that," he said, advancing on her. Lingerie was hot and all, but the lean body with her too-big tits were what he wanted to get his hands on.

Annika laughed at his enthusiasm. Before he got to her, though, she held a hand up to fend him off. It wasn't something that the old Annika would have done. "I know you're eager to get to it, but this is important." She kissed him before sliding past. "You may not care about it, but Cooper does. Don't worry, I'll be quick."

Stunned, but happily so, he watched her wiggle her ass at him, pleased to see that the back of her panties were all strap, no lace.



ANNIKA

So are you really, really, positively sure you're okay with this?
Because things are about to cross a line.

SHE SET her phone down on the counter as she made a few, quick adjustments to her lingerie set. It came with a matching garter belt, which she knew Cooper loved, and she paired it with a pair of nude stockings with seams that ran up the backs.

Her phone rumbled on the sink.

COOPER

Go for it. Cross all the lines.

She smiled at it.

I love you!

“I love you, too,” she whispered to herself. But what would come next wasn’t just for him. It was for *them*.

Checking herself out one last time, she took a photo of herself in the full set, because she wasn’t sure Cooper would see it intact by the time he made it back to the hotel.

“Damn,” Brett said, taking her in. He was already naked on the bed, one arm behind his head, dick hard. “Now that’s worth it. Why didn’t you ever wear this stuff for me?”

“You mostly just wanted me naked?” Despite Brett being the buck naked person in the room, Annika felt exposed before him. She could feel the heat climbing up her spine and the almost unbearable urge to cover herself or flee back into the bathroom. “How about Margot? I feel like she wears pretty things, too.”

Brett grinned. “Yeah, she does. It’s just different... on you.”

Annika crawled up onto the bed, and predictably, Brett’s eyes dipped into her cleavage. It felt as familiar as an old t-shirt, soft, comfortable, but no longer for her—not long term, anyway.

When their lips met, the last of her anxiety melted away. When her hand curled around his thick cock, she let herself be Brett’s Annika again, climbing on the playground of his beautiful, muscled body.

“You like that cock, don’t you?”

“You know it.” She said it because she knew he liked to hear it.

“Show me.”

She knew what he wanted and was happy to give it to him. Shifting down his body, she held his cock high and wrapped her lips around the tip. Sucking Brett’s cock was like riding a bike—if riding a bike regularly caused her to gag as it hit the back of her throat.

Speaking of gagging, she was able to swallow him all the way to his trimmed pubes after only a few minutes of warming up.

“You’ve still got it, girl.” Brett’s encouragement didn’t just take the form of words. He slid his hand down her body, down the ridge of her back and along her ass cheeks. Pushing the thong aside, he found her wet, swollen gash. “Sucking dick still gets you nice and warmed up.”

She focused on the blowjob, keeping her throat open, her lips slack enough around his shaft that her gargles and chokes could tease him. Focus, however, was hard, with Brett shoving his thick fingers in and out of her pussy.

He put a hand on her head, the way Cooper would do when he was about to come. Only Brett wasn't warning her. He took control of her, forcing her to hold him in her throat until her eyes began to water and froth drooled down her chin—all while churning his fingers against her g-spot. She was overwhelmed and overloaded.

Brett pushed her right up against her limit before releasing her. She gasped, sucking in air, red-faced and sputtering. She stared up at him, ready to do whatever he told her to do.

"Get up here on your knees," he said. "Time to fuck."

Time to fuck. His words bore through her quivering gut. She crawled forward, assuming the position that Brett always loved so much—doggy style. She glanced back, towards the door to the hotel room, wondering where Cooper was. She wanted to share this with him, but wasn't sure when he would come home.

She grasped at her phone and handed it back to him. "Take a video. I want to share."

Brett chuckled. "Kinky. First things first, though." He whipped her thong off. "You put it over the garter belt. Very sexy."

She heard her phone's camera chime on, the video engaged. His fingers glided back down between her legs. "I see Cooper prefers you shaved."

"Maybe it's me who prefers it." He just assumed that she did everything for someone else. Expressing her defiance felt good. She glanced over her shoulder, looking into the lens of the phone's camera. "Maybe I like naughty, little secrets."

"Fuck yeah, you do." He tore open a condom that he seemed to produce out of nowhere, and rolled it on, all with one hand. The other kept the camera recording. "It's what makes you so special, Anni..." He pressed his cock against her pussy. "...just how wild you could get."

With that, he thrust forward, filling her with the first non-Cooper cock she'd had in over five years of marriage and plenty of years of dating. Guiltily, she loved every inch of it.

Yet this scene was incomplete. Brett gave as good as he ever did, but it felt more like her threesomes with Kai—only Brett wasn't Brett in this scenario, he was the other man...

She glanced at the door, thinking of Cooper. She wished he was there. She wanted to share this moment with him. At least she had the video.

Brett popped her bra off, and with his dick still in her, got her to sit up onto her knees. His chest was hot against her back, and his right hand cupped and pinched her tits. He swung the camera around to face them, and all at once she was assaulted with the image of what she was doing—her face, sweaty with excitement, her shoulders naked, another man’s head so close to her, kissing her neck in the reflected video.

“I have my cock buried in your wife’s pussy.” Brett grinned at the camera, all charm and showmanship. It wasn’t a statement the way Ryan would have made it—he wasn’t bragging. It was one hotwife husband’s statement to another. It’s the thing that Brett would have wanted to hear. “And it feels just as wet and hot as ever.”

“Wish you were here.” As Annika said it, she felt the weight of the wish. “I want you to watch me fuck him.”

The confessional was over, just like that. Now it was down to the business of fucking. This is where Brett excelled. He was still the physical force. He was still the master cocksman. He pinned her arms behind her, fucking her face down, ass up, a helpless fucktoy that she loved to be. For this man. In this situation.

“Fuck, you feel good!” he grunted. “You like my cock?”

Everything was on fire—her body, her mind. She moaned, focusing on the dick slamming in and out of her, but what really drove her wild was the thought of rewatching all of this, revisiting it with Cooper.

“You miss my dick?” It was a demand.

She cried out, thinking again of Cooper as she made sense of the question. What did Cooper want to hear? She was so close. So on edge. She screamed, “Yes!”

People often call an orgasm a release. Teeth-clenching, nostrils flaring, throat burning, in that pure moment, she finally, truly, profoundly understood why. It was a release of all the pent-up energy, of all the fear and anxiety, of all the nervousness.

And when she looked over and saw Cooper standing at the edge of the room, she knew everything was going to be just fine.

Cooper floated outside of his body, disembodied but not weightless by any means. He felt heavy. Everything felt so fucking heavy. Yet as soon as Annika turned to him, as soon as she smiled in his direction, he snapped back, and he was himself again.

Brett pulled out of his wife, dick still hard and too fucking big to be real. “You made it,” the guy said. “Guess I don’t need this anymore.”

Cooper hadn’t noticed that he’d been holding a phone until the man tapped on it and tossed it over to the bed. This was where things could have gotten awkward. This was that moment—standing at the entrance to a room, catching his wife in bed with another man—that reality crashed hard into fantasy.

The crash was, indeed, hard, slamming into his gut and nearly driving all the wind from him. But then Annika opened her eyes, still soft and

unfocused from her orgasm, and the smile and warmth that spread over her was infectious.

Brett's good-natured, overflowing smile helped. The man stood, unashamed of his own nudity—and why not when he looked like that?—and strutted towards the bathroom, his dick bobbing erect like an enthusiastic flag bearer. “I’ll let you two catch up.” He clapped Cooper on the shoulder as he passed, paused to flex and admire himself before the mirror mounted on the closet door, and disappeared into the bathroom.

Cooper turned back to Annika, and they shared the same thought—“*Is he for real?*” They both laughed without having to say a word.

“What happened to Ryan?” Cooper finally found his legs, moving into the room and settling on the bed next to his prone wife. She looked beautiful and exhausted and happy all at once.

“Oh, he was just a prop. And kind of a dick.”

“And...” Cooper glanced towards the bathroom. “...he’s not?”

“‘Prop’ and a ‘dick’ in a totally different sense.” Annika giggled. “Are you upset?”

“I’m not.” All it took was him saying it and he realized how true it was. He wasn’t upset. How could he be upset? Annika had just fulfilled his ultimate fantasy—was, in fact, *still* fulfilling it. They’d come full circle. She’d gone from the attractive blonde in 3C to the laundry girl to barista to best friend to wife. And now, to the attractive blonde hotwife.

He took her into his arms and kissed her. “I’m a lot of things, but definitely *not* upset. You’re... amazing.”

Annika blushed.

“Yeah she is,” Brett said, coming out of the bedroom. He hadn’t dressed. He wasn’t going anywhere just yet. “And so are you, Cooper.”

He poured himself a glass of water, buck naked, as if inviting us to look. Annika couldn’t help herself, and Cooper noticed. When their eyes met, he nodded at her in encouragement. *Go for it, I want to watch.* No words were needed.

She smiled broadly, kissed him again, and floated over to her ex-boyfriend. “How does it feel to be the other man?” she asked.

“Feels fuckin’ amazing,” Brett said. “But you know what would feel even better?”

“Yes,” Annika said, dropping to her knees. Cooper felt his knees buckle at her complicity. “Your big dick in my throat.”

She glanced at Cooper, then to the desk chair by the wall. He nodded. She wanted him there. She wanted him to watch, and he was so ready to do that. The angle was perfect. In profile, he watched his wife wrap her lips around another man's considerable girth. His knees buckled beneath him as he fell into the chair.

Brett wasn't a passive recipient, either. He held her head in his big, meaty hands, fucking his hips into her as much as she bobbed. Cooper's protective hackles went up as he listened to Annika gag on Brett's cock, but when Brett released her and pulled her back, Annika's gasp was one of delight rather than relief. She huffed in air, staring up at Brett, a smile curling the edges of her lips. *More*, that expression said, and Brett was ready to give her so much more.

"Annika is one of the only chicks I've been with who can take all of it," he explained to Cooper. He demonstrated by pulling her face back to him and sinking down until his balls rested on her chin. He held her there until her eyes began to water, then released her. "She loves it. Don't you, Anni?"

"I love to please my men," she said, and even though she was saying it to Brett, staring at him with the reverence of a suppliant, Cooper had the feeling that she was talking directly to him. She sat higher on her haunches, collecting her tits in her hands, and wrapped them around Brett's dick. "Mmm... Remember how much you liked to fuck my tits?"

Cooper had never even considered asking her to do that. The very idea was demeaning to the woman he loved and respected. Brett had no such hangup. "Fuck yeah, Babe. Wrap those titties around my dick."

Annika looked so hot like that, yet so very different than the woman he'd fallen for. This was the girl that he imagined she was, long before she became so much more real—and yet she was still that real woman.

"Fuuuck, that feels good."

She bounced her tits along Brett's dick, watching the pleasure play across his face. He tipped his head back, facing the ceiling, eyes shut tight and legs planted wide for support as she titfucked him.

Cooper couldn't help himself. He was done simply sitting there, rubbing his cock over his pants. He unbuckled himself, freeing his aching dick, and started stroking.

"Come over here," Brett said to Cooper. To his wife, he ordered, "Put that mouth to work. Show your man how much you crave a dick in your mouth."

Brett's magnetism was too great. Cooper did as he was told, standing just to Annika's side so she could turn her head and take him into her mouth. She never missed a beat as Brett continued to use her chest. Cooper was spellbound by the raunchy sight, and driven wild by the sensation of her wet tongue along his length.

"*I love you,*" he mouthed. He couldn't hold out. Her blowjob, her eyes staring up at him, her tits gripping another man's large cock—it fried his brain. This was happening. This was really happening.

"Uh!" he grunted. She drank him down, swallowing his load with ease. Cooper stumbled back, his dick never going fully soft, as Brett rammed his own cock back into Annika's mouth.

"I'd love to give you a double dose of protein, Babe," Brett said. "But Cooper there is going to want to watch you get fucked, and I want to try out your bald look again. Get on up here."

They moved to the bed, this time Brett laying on his back as Annika swung her leg over his, reverse cowboy, facing Cooper at the desk again. He watched her, eyes locked, as she first rolled a condom on her ex-boyfriend's monster of a dick, then placed it against her pussy, then slowly, erotically, deliciously lowered onto it.

Walking in on them had been a shock. Watching Annika blowing Brett had a teaser. Seeing his wife's shaved pussy stretch around him, her clit swollen and edged by all that hard manhood, was like destiny finally arriving.

If he hadn't just come, Cooper surely would have lost it. As it was, he felt his balls tighten. He swooned in the chair. His cock sprang back to full and attention-demanding life. He wrapped his hand around it and starting beating off in time with their fucking.

And they *fucked*. As much as this was for Cooper, Annika was into the sex with Brett. Like, *really* into it. "Uh! Uh! Fuck... your big... fuckingdick... feels... *sogood!*" Her words were stilted, blurring into one another as she rode him, her tits bouncing, her hair a sweaty mess. "Yes, yes! Fuck it up into me! Fuck, I'm... I'm coming!"

This was 3C all over again. This is the way she'd talked. These were the gasps and moans and curses that filtered through the thin flooring. This was the woman she'd locked away since they'd been together, real and in all her naked flesh.

And when her orgasm rolled through her like a summer squall and she came down from it, she saw Cooper there, watching her, jerking off, and smiled. He nodded to her. She mouthed, *I love you*.

She lifted off of Brett with reluctance. The two groaned when his dick was fully released, swinging back and forth, still fully erect. They moved with such familiarity, each anticipating the other as he rolled her onto her back and mounted her missionary style. It was that familiarity, more than anything else, that felt so erotically wrong. It was the thing Cooper craved, before he knew that he craved anything at all.

Brett lifted Annika's legs over his broad shoulders, folding her in half as he leaned into her and kissed her passionately. The kiss was like sweet torture. So was the way she guided his cock back to her pussy. So was the way she arched back as he re-entered her.

The tenderness lasted less than a minute, but it remained there, like a sunspot burned onto his retina, long after they'd shifted to ball-slapping fucking. They had history. So much history. They had love, once. Once, she would have done whatever this man wanted.

Now, though, despite the frenzy of the moment and Brett's lunging hips, she managed to turn her head and find Cooper through the fog. She smiled, comforted that he was there, and almost all of the anxiety that he'd been feeling in his gut melted away.

Almost all of it.

"Take the condom off," she said to Brett. "I want you to feel me."

Brett didn't need any convincing. He pulled his hips back and snapped the latex sheath off with delight. It was like Cooper had walked into a sauna. The heat hit him like a wall. He actually groaned out loud, watching enraptured, as Brett rubbed his unprotected dick along Annika's smooth mound.

"You should keep it like this," Brett said. "I love a shaved snatch."

"You could have asked," she told him.

"I liked the landing strip, too. It was cute." He buried his bare dick into her, and they were off to the races again.

It was like watching two athletes at the top of their game trying to outdo one another. Brett didn't hold back, and Annika was loving every thrust and hard pump. She clawed at his back, leaving streaks along those muscled shoulder blades, and locked her ankles behind his neck.

Cooper's heart raced. His hand was a blur as he watched. He knew she was close—*again*—locked in on her panting breath and how wound up her moans became. She was about to come—and come really hard—because another man was fucking her.

And because her husband was watching.

"You ready for my come?" Brett asked.

Annika, beyond language and coherence, could only groan in response. But she did reach up, grab Brett, and pulled him down to her for one final, torrid kiss as he pumped her full of come. The lovers broke the kiss, gasping and sputtering, their open mouths open and inches from one another as they both climaxed.

Cooper felt his own balls tighten. Their intimacy, the way they stared at one another, the way their lips hovered, moments from a kiss, were all triggers. He wanted to come. He wanted to join them. He also knew that if he did, that would be the end of it, and he wanted this moment to last.

Annika blinked, seeming to come out of her trance. She saw who was over her, and for a split second, Cooper felt her panic. She only relaxed when she glanced over at him, saw that he was still there, and still hard.

Brett pushed off of her without kissing her, and whatever past connection they had finally broke. He was just a guy, a prop in a game that Cooper and Annika were playing. She wasn't going to run off with him, and in that moment, Cooper realized that she never would.

"That was incredible," Brett said. He clapped his hands once, like a man who'd just finished an oversized steak, and reached for his pants. He chuckled. "We sure spread our things out all over the place," he said, gathering his clothing which had been flung about the room.

Annika just lay there, panting and spent, her heavy-lidded eyes watching Cooper. He rose, crossing over to her side, Brett fading into the background.

Are we okay? she seemed to ask without saying a word. Cooper nodded, a smile breaking across his face, reflected in her own.

"Okay then, I'll leave you to it," Brett said. It was like he was a million miles away. "This is the best part. Have fun, kids."

He left. Or so Annika and Cooper assumed. They were already making out before they heard the door.

She smelled like another man. When he kissed her, she tasted like another man. When he ran his hand down over her used pussy, she definitely felt like she'd been with another man. Cooper was loving it.

"You did it," he breathed.

"We did it," Annika corrected.

"God, I love you."

"I love you, too, Cooper. I loved that you were here."

"Me too." He kissed her again.

She looked sheepish when he broke the kiss and brushed her damp hair back. She said, "I also loved that you let me do that."

"You liked being with him."

She looked adorable, chewing on her bottom lip like that. "I did."

Cooper touched her pussy, pressing two fingers in with surprising ease. Annika gasped. "Careful," she said, voice tight. "Still pretty sore."

“Okay. We can just lie here.” He tried to keep the sound of disappointment from his voice, but Annika heard it.

“No.” She turned fully to face him. “No, no, sweet man. That’s not what I meant. I just need a little time.”

“We don’t have to—”

“We don’t, but I want to. And you do, too. This is the good part, Cooper. As good as the sex was with Brett, this is what I’ve been looking forward to.”

“Really?” Cooper felt his spirit take off like a bird in flight.

“Of course,” she said, like it was the most obvious thing in the world. “But right now, let’s talk. It’s something we need to do more of if we want to make this work.”

Make this work. There would be more times, more experiences. Their hotwife journey wasn’t over yet. “Absolutely. I’ll start.” He took a deep breath. “I want to watch you with other men.”

Annika snorted. “Really? I had no idea.”

“I should have told you about my fantasy long ago.”

“Or maybe before you tried to set me up?” she suggested.

“That was dumb of me.”

“It’s why I broke up with Brett.”

Cooper winced.

“But don’t worry, you’re safe. It’s a good thing I love you so damn much.”

“I did hear you go a little crazy when you’re in love.”

Annika laughed at that. “I agree to all kinds of things.” Color returned to her cheeks. “Speaking of, I may have kind of promised the newlyweds something...”

Cooper felt the pressure begin to build again. “What?”

Annika reached between them, wrapping her hand around his erection. “Well, in order to get Brett here, I kind of promised them a threesome.”

Cooper’s heart rate jumped. She felt his cock thicken inside of her. “Well, seems like a much more appropriate wedding gift than a toaster.”

She giggled, squeezing his dick. “So that’s a fantasy of yours, also.”

“Watching you get it on with another woman? I’d say it’s right behind the hotwife one.” He thought about it. “You’re going to do it?”

“I’ve done it for him before.”

“Really?” Cooper shouldn’t have been surprised by anything anymore. “Did you and the other woman...?”

“Yes. We played.”

Annika gently pushed Cooper onto his back. “I didn’t know you were... into women.”

Gingerly, she teased his cockhead over her clit before sinking onto him. She was so wet, lubricated by another man’s come. He could see it glistening on her hairless mound, and it almost set him off alone.

“I wouldn’t say that I am, but it was fun.”

Slowly, exquisitely, she began to rise and fall on him. She felt different, stretched out by a bigger, thicker man. Cooper reveled in the change.

“I like to please, and I loved the way Brett watched as I licked another woman’s pussy.”

Cooper groaned.

“Would you like to see that?”

“Yes” he hissed.

“Would you like to see me go down on Margot?”

“Oh, Anni...”

“How about watching me eat her as Brett pounds me doggy-style?”

Cooper was on the edge of the world, looking down from the high heights of his life, and for the first time in years, wasn’t afraid of the fall.

“I want to see that,” he said.

“You will.” She rode him faster. “Margot is... tempting...”

“Uh...” Cooper fought to keep his orgasm at bay.

“And you know how much I like Brett’s cock.”

“Anni...”

“Best of all?? She was close, too, her breath shallow and her words tight. “You’ll be there, watching.” She sank her teeth into her lower lips, savoring the thought of it. “You get to watch me be their fucktoy...”

Cooper shuddered.

“...and in the end, you’ll be there to reclaim me as yours.”

“Yes!”

“Now do it, Cooper. Reclaim me now.” She sank down on him one last time, her pussy tightening around his cock. “Make me yours. Give me your come.”

They came together, groaning and loud. Annika’s throat was raw. Cooper felt dizzy. He kept coming and coming, each pulse sending a small

quake through Annika as she folded over him and into his arms.

“You have so much come!” she laughed.

“I’ve been waiting for this moment for a long time.”

She brushed her hair away and looked down at him. “I love you, Cooper. I love our life.” She snuggled. “I love everything about it.”

“You love that you get to sleep with other, hot men.” He was no longer defensive. The suggestion held no insinuation.

“I love that you want me to,” she corrected. “And if it ever becomes a problem, I’ll just as easily walk away from it all.”

“If it ever does, I’ll let you know,” Cooper said.

“You better.” She kissed him, tweaking his nipple.

“Ow!”

“We’re a team, Cooper. We go into this with our eyes wide open.”

“Don’t worry, Annika. My eyes are definitely going to be open.”

She laughed. “And you know how far I can go for love...”

PART IX

EPILOGUES

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EPILOGUE 1

The Pacific Ocean sparkled, vast and deep blue. On the horizon, only a few, lazy clouds floated by. The world was open and alive before them. Cooper met Annika's eyes. They shared a smile, fingers intertwined.

"You two are so fucking cute," Margot said.

They were having lunch out on the veranda of Brett and Margot's honeymoon home in Carmel, invited here ostensibly for a private pool party. Cooper suspected that the invitation from the newlyweds was just an excuse to get them in their swimsuits—not that Cooper minded.

Annika wore her same blue-and-white string bikini, and while she still got a lot of looks her way, it looked practically wholesome next to Margot's suit. The thing was seemingly constructed entirely of golden bands that wound around her otherwise bare, tanned body. Even Annika couldn't stop looking at the woman.

"That's some bikini," Annika said.

“I’ve got a few more just as sexy,” she said. “And I know we wear the same size.” She winked, referring to two nights back at the post-reception orgy.

“Not really my style,” Annika said.

“Isn’t your style whatever Cooper likes?”

“Margot, stop messing with her.” Cooper was surprised to find himself speaking up. He started to feel the confidence wane until Annika squeezed his hand.

“It’s okay, honey. I don’t mind.” To Margot, she said, “I guess it does play a part. Just not the only part.”

“Very interesting,” was all Margot said, studying the two of them.

Annika looked at her husband. “What do you think, Coop? Should I get a suit like that?”

“Only if you wanted one,” he said truthfully. “I think you look good in anything.”

“See, now I know he’s just saying that,” Margot said. “Coop, just think of all the attention your wife would get from guys as she walked down the beach in this.” Margot gestured at her gold suit.

“She doesn’t need it, Babe.” Brett joined them with a tray of drinks. “Annika’s hot because she’s the girl-next-door.”

“Literally,” Cooper added. “Or girl-upstairs, I guess.”

“So you really would listen to them fuck and get off on it?” Margot asked.

“Yeah.” He was getting used to talking about it. “Aural voyeur.”

Margot pressed. “Was that better than last night, when you became an actual voyeur?”

Cooper looked to his wife. “I’d say last night was everything I ever dreamed it would be.”

Margot bit her tongue. “I can’t wait to see it. Watching Brett fuck another chick is always so hot. I’m getting wet just thinking about it.” She picked up her margarita and held it up. “To watching our partners have sex with each other.”

The toast was directed just at Cooper. He grinned and clinked the blonde’s glass.

“Can you believe these two?” Annika asked Brett. “Like we’re not even here.”

“Wonder if they’d notice if we snuck up to the bedroom?” he said back.

“Come on, let’s find out,” Annika giggled. She winked at Cooper, and he gave the slightest of nods.

With that, Annika rose with Brett, who slipped his hand into hers. Cooper, who’d been fighting back an erection ever since they’d arrived, was instantly hard, his breathing shallow, his head light.

“See? Told you they wouldn’t notice,” Annika said loudly before they entered the house.

Watching them disappear brought back the rush of the past, of those years when Cooper and Annika were barely acquaintances. When he’d pass her on the stairs as she and Brett made their way back to her apartment.

Only now, everything was different. He didn’t feel left out. He didn’t have to fight back those feelings of inadequacy and exclusion. Annika was going to have wild, hard, multi-orgasmic sex with Brett for *them*—for Annika and Cooper and the bond that they had.

“Your wife’s a lot more vanilla than I’d imagined,” Margot said.

“Yeah? What’s that mean?”

Margot shrugged. “Guess I was expecting someone crazier, based on Brett’s other exes.”

For whatever reason, It was comforting to know that Brett had other exes. “She’s special. But I’m not sure I’d consider her ‘vanilla’.”

“Oh, I didn’t mean it as an insult! And no, I guess vanilla’s not quite the right word, since she just walked off with my husband. But, like, I would have thought, based on Brett’s stories, that Annika would have stayed with me and Ryan. Brett always implied that she was down for whatever.”

“Guess she’s changed.” Cooper took a sip of his margarita to clear the frog from his throat.

“Yeah.” Margot glanced up into the sky, the sun falling across her face. “You two are totally inspiring.”

“You’re pretty inspiring, too.” The words just fell out of Cooper’s mouth before he could stop them. “I mean, you and Brett,” he stumbled. “And your... how you two... your, you know...”

Margot giggled. “You can just say the lifestyle. You like it?”

“Maybe not all the time, but yeah.” He chuckled. “Obviously I like it.”

“Ever imagine Annika eating pussy?”

Cooper nearly choked on his drink. “I mean, yes. But never realistically.”

“Come on then. Let’s make another one of your fantasies a reality.” She rose and offered her hand to his. It was soft, yet firm, her fingers long like her limbs. Inside, she said, “You know, I’d love to fuck you, too.”

Margot seemed to take delight in keeping him off-balance.

“Brett would, too.” She pressed closer to him, linking her fingers around his arm and guiding him towards the stairs. Then, she clarified, “Like to watch, I mean. Not fuck you. I’m the only one who swings both ways. Well, me and possibly your wife.”

Annika’s giggle filtered down from above as they crossed the living room. Margot paused, looking up at the ceiling with a smile. Brett’s rumbling voice followed, but Cooper couldn’t make out the words.

“This what it was like?” Margot asked.

“Pretty close.”

Annika giggled again. This time, though, the laugh was quickly silenced. Margot speculated. “He’s either kissing her, or he just shoved his dick in her mouth.” She turned to Cooper. “Which do you hope is happening?”

Cooper couldn’t answer. His ears were perked, listening for some clue. Margot sidled up against him, her skin hot on his arm. “I bet she’s sucking his dick. Brett told me that the girl couldn’t get enough of it.”

“He did?”

“He does have a very nice dick,” she whispered. Her hand closed around Cooper’s, tracing the erection through his swimming trunks. “And so do you, it seems.”

Cooper pried himself away, somehow. As tempted as he was by Margot, there was something that overruled it. “You know what’s different now, than then?” he asked. “I don’t have to just listen to them and wonder. Come on, let’s go.”

Margot was just as jazzed to go along. Cooper’s confidence grew as he led, and she followed.



COOPER WAS OVERCOME with *déjà vu*. He’d been here, countless times, experiences overlapping into a dizzying swirl that left his gut fluttering and face a ball of fire.

Brett stood on the far side of the room, legs planted shoulder-width apart, hands akimbo. On her knees before him was Annika, topless, her blue-and-white bikini bottoms riding her ass. This time it was no trick. This time, it really was Annika, blonde hair bouncing as she sucked Brett's cock.

Seeing movement, Brett looked up. Annika saw the shift and knew that the audience had arrived. She squeezed her hand around the base, slurped off, and looked over her shoulder. "I was wondering if you'd join us."

"That an invitation?" Margot asked.

Annika shifted over, saying, "Brett always liked double the fun."

"He wouldn't stop at double. Trust me." Margot sashayed over to the two of them and sank down to her knees. "He's a greedy one."

Without further tease, Margot swallowed her husband whole. It was impressive. She didn't need a warmup. She didn't ease into it. She had him in her throat on her first bob.

Cooper stood in the doorway, watching, envious—but it was a good kind of envious. The kind of envious that he wanted to remember for years to come. Seeing two blondes go down on a guy in real life would have been incredible all on its own. But one was his dearly beloved.

Watching her suck another man's balls while the other bobbed above her had Cooper on edge. Watching them switch back and forth pushed him closer.

But it was when they were both working Brett's shaft, a mouth on each side, that did him in. Brett placed a hand on the backs of their heads, and when they reached the tip, all it took was the slightest nudge and the two women were kissing.

Cooper's balls tightened. He grunted, unable to stop himself, and came prematurely in his swimsuit. The threesome didn't notice. Annika was too busy giving herself fully to the kiss. It was deep. It was sensual. It was unmistakably feminine. And Annika was definitely okay with that.

It didn't end. They didn't go back to the double blowjob. They didn't go back to the man. Before she knew it, Annika was on the bed, and Margot was lapping at her nipples. The woman's technique was perfect—a gin and tonic on a hot, summer day; a deep breath after a hard ride; a hug from Cooper when she was feeling down.

Cooper! She snapped to, fear locking her body up. But he was still there. Still with her. Still standing awkwardly in the doorway.

She beckoned him to join, and for a moment, she swore he was going to look over his shoulder like she was talking to someone else. She rolled her eyes and held out her hand.

He went to her, his weight on the bed, his hand in hers as Margot shifted down her body and pulled down her bikini bottoms. She reached up and pulled him in for a kiss, just as Margot tongue swept across her sex.

The kiss didn't last. It couldn't. Annika needed to moan, and Cooper needed to watch. Looking down, he met Margot's eyes as she lapped away, her tongue a blur. "Oh my...! What are you... what are you *doing* to me?!"

Margot looked up from between Annika's legs, her chin glistening with excitement. "Turning you into my bisexual slut."

With that, she easily finished Annika off, her tongue and fingers working in perfect harmony. It was inspiring to watch. Annika's orgasm came loud and unrestrained, her body bucking, thrusting her tits high, her eyes shut tight.

Cooper was hard again, and Annika was ready for him to play. She grabbed him, dragging his mouth to him in a devouring kiss. She was still drunk on her climax when they broke, staring up at her husband and relieved that he was there with her, experiencing this with her.

But things were just getting started.

Margot moved out of the way, and there was Brett once again, naked and holding his erect cock in his hand. Margot leaned down and gave it a few sucks before pulling back. "Main event, right?"

Annika checked in with Cooper with a glance, and he reassured her with a short nod. "Have fun, Anni."

Brett took his time sliding his cock home. He had an audience of three, and was a natural showman. It looked exquisite—the thick cap rubbing along her smooth folds, teasing her clit, parting her. She stretched and stretched around all his girth, the pressure building and building.

Cooper was there with her, right by her side—holding her, kissing her, being a part of this moment. She knew this was where he'd always be.

Life had a way of continuously surprising them, and they both knew there would be more surprises to come. It wouldn't always be easy, but they'd always have one another. In the end, they had come out stronger and closer than ever.

"I love you," she mouthed.

Cooper kissed her softly. "You're amazing."

She turned to Brett first, who'd finally pressed his entire length into her. He wasn't looking at her, though. His eyes were trained on his wife, sitting opposite Cooper, the two sharing as warm a moment as he and Anni.

Annika could have ended up with that man, and she would have been happy. He was a good man, loving and funny, charismatic—an amazing lover. But it would have been different. There would have been more Kais and Ryans. There would have been more orgies. It was a life that she would not have known that she didn't want until she'd discovered an alternative. Until she'd discovered a man like Cooper.

That didn't mean she couldn't dip her toes into that lifestyle, every now and then.

She reached out to Margot, running her fingers up the woman's forearm. "I think I owe you something, for letting me borrow your husband."

The sharp-eyed blonde bent down towards her. "Oh, I haven't forgotten."

The two women kissed, open-mouthed and passionately. Brett and Cooper watched, mesmerized, Brett slowly pumping in and out of her. Annika caressed Margot's face, shifting her fingers through her hair.

When they broke the kiss, Annika said, "I cannot wait to eat your pussy."

Cooper groaned, encouraging Annika. Margot wasn't one to delay gratification. As soon as it was suggested, she started stripping out of the golden bikini. It was the first time Cooper had seen Brett's new wife naked, and she was just as unreal as he'd imagined. Her tits were perky, if not a little too perfect, her skin free of tan lines, her pussy as bare as Annika's.

With a smile at Brett, Margot straddled Annika's head, facing her husband, and lowered her pussy onto Annika's waiting mouth. Annika didn't show any hesitation. She went to work on the other woman, using her lips and tongue to please.

Margot cooed happily, grinning at Brett, then to Cooper. "This is why I wax. There's nothing like feeling a soft woman's face down there." She undulated on Annika's face and bit her tongue, humming to herself. "Mmm... eat that *pussy*, Baby. Do me with your lezzie tongue."

"Fuck, that's hot," Brett said, staring between Margot's legs as Annika's tongue flicked about.

"She's good," Margot confirmed. "Thank you, my love. Fuck!"

Brett matched his wife's hips, the two of them smothering Annika beneath them as they got off on her. "I'm going to come inside of her," Brett announced. "And you're going to clean her up, Babe."

"My favorite way to eat your come," Margot said. "Right out of a hot slut's juicy pussy."

The newlyweds shared a sloppy kiss as Brett buried himself all the way to his trimmed hilt and filled Annika with his spunk. Annika, smothered beneath Margot's thighs, moaned and shuddered as she received her ex's heat.

Brett pulled out, groaning, his dick only semi-soft. Cooper saw the pearly evidence leaking from his wife's pussy for only a moment before Margot leaned down and completed the sixty-nine.

Margot didn't release Annika until she'd licked her to at least two, monumental orgasms—and gotten off on one of her own. When she finally did, Annika looked dazed, yet happy. "You're good at that," Margot said, hopping off her.

"Thanks. I like to please."

"You certainly do." Margot laughed. She leaned down and kissed Annika on the lips. It quickly turned into something deeper, full of passion and desire and a lot of tongue. It wasn't a show kiss. Annika made out with the other woman because she was enjoying it. Margot broke it and smiled. "It's good, because I like to be pleased."

She straightened up and looked at Brett. "Come on, Babe, let's get some water. Pussy always makes me so thirsty!" Glancing at Cooper, she added, "And I think you need some love."

Cooper crawled onto the bed and kissed his wife, tasting the tang of Margot's come. Her lips were warm, her face hot, and she eagerly returned her husband's kiss. By the time they came up for air, they were alone in the room.

"Did you like the show?" Annika's voice was raw from all her moans. "Was it too much?"

"No, definitely not too much." He nuzzled her nose. "It was amazing."

"Felt pretty amazing, too," she confessed.

"Which part? With Margot?"

"Yes, that. It was fun, eating her pussy." Those words from his wife had Cooper instantly throbbing. "But also... all the rest of it. When she sat on

my face as Brett..." She glanced at Cooper, even now uncertain this was what he wanted to hear. "As Brett fucked his big dick into me."

Or maybe she knew exactly what he wanted to hear, and the hesitation was for effect. It worked. Cooper needed his wife more than ever.

He climbed onto her, dick in hand, hard as a hammer. She hissed as he pressed it against her pussy, slick and supple from all the sex. "Are you too sore?" he asked.

As an answer, she put a hand over his and guided him into her. She was loose. Brett had stretched her out. Cooper was in heaven at the thought.

"Mmm, yes, Cooper," Annika groaned. "This is what I need."

He didn't fuck her the way Brett did. He was neither built for it, nor wired that way. But that's why they worked. He was her center, and she was his. She loved getting crazy, both for herself and for her husband, but in the end, what was wanted was Cooper's loving familiarity.

"Come in me, Baby," she sighed. "Make me yours again."

Cooper was close, driving his hips with more and more urgency. All the events of their intersecting lives tumbled through him in a flash, and he now knew, without a doubt, that there would be so many more fun moments to come.

EPILOGUE 2

Cooper made the idiotic decision to move himself. He was young, his former apartment was small, and he was only moving from the other side of the city. He figured it would take a couple trips and he'd be done. He didn't have close enough friends in San Diego to ask for help, so he decided to go solo.

It was on his fifth trip that he realized he'd made a mistake and probably should have sprung for movers. Even though his apartment was only one floor up, apartment 2C, that one flight of stairs was going to be the death of him.

Tired and cranky, it was late by the time he made his tenth and final trip. All he wanted to do was crawl into a bed that he hadn't made yet, and sleep under sheets that he still needed to unpack.

At his lowest was when he first saw her—the blonde in 3C who would one day be his partner in life. She smiled at him as she passed, holding the door as he lugged his last box in. “Hey,” she said.

“Hi.”

And Cooper suddenly knew that everything was going to be alright.

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